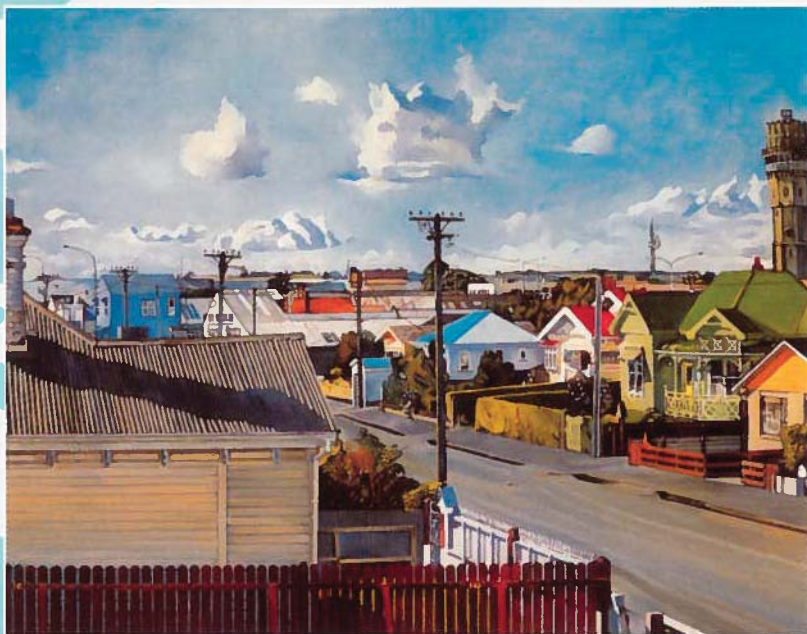


Mapping the Godzone

A Primer on New Zealand Literature and Culture



William J. Schafer

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University of Hawai'i Press
Honolulu

For Martha—little blue penguins, pukeko, tuatara & all

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Designed by Jennifer Lum

Their town, called Waimaru, was small as the world and halfway between the South Pole and the equator, that is, forty-five degrees exactly. There was a stone monument just north of the town, to mark the spot, in gold lettering.

—Traveller, the writing said, Stop here. You are now standing between the South Pole and the equator.

What did it feel like to be standing at forty-five degrees?

It felt no different.

—Janet Frame, *Owls Do Cry*

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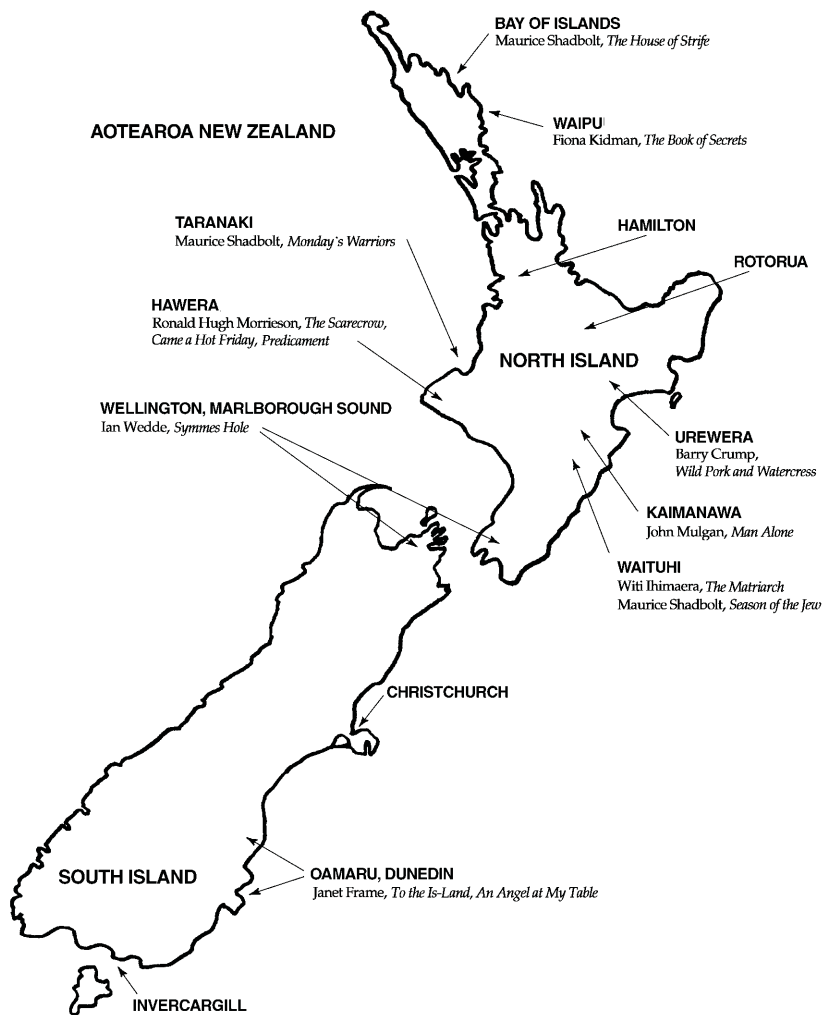
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Preface:
Sailing to Aotearoa

I wrote this book in a sustained burst of enthusiasm for New Zealand, its people, places, culture, and literature. My feelings came from reading and dreaming about New Zealand, followed by a five-month visit in 1995, during which my wife and I tried to see, understand, and absorb as much of this remarkable place as possible in the months from midwinter to early summer of the antipodean year.

We traveled to New Zealand in a romantic, anachronistic fashion—sailing on a Blue Star Line container ship from Long Beach to Auckland, with an afternoon stop at Suva, Fiji. The experience of the huge, sullenly stable cargo ship, the vastness of the Pacific, calm seas, and the restful ennui of a two-week voyage with few enforced amenities or mandatory pleasures prepared us for landfall at the North Island.

Nothing, not even the tourist brochures, travel guides, and videotaped glossies on the attractions of the land, prepared us for the diversity, the temperate climate (even in the midst of an unusually cold and protracted winter, by local standards), and the sheer physical beauty. We disembarked at Auckland, after sailing along the east coast of Northland and observing the diorama of small islands and coastal villages, took a taxi ride across the city from the harbor to the airport, and examined all the streets of simple, colorful villas and bungalows, the gardens glowing with flowers and fruits in midwinter. It was wet and chilly, like an average winter's day on the mild south coast of England.

Then we flew across Cook Strait, down the spine of the South Island, with the grandeur of the Southern Alps and Mount Cook under our wings as we turned across the Canterbury Plains and landed at Christchurch. The weather was colder, more a real winter of the mid-

western U.S. variety. We had left Los Angeles in early summer, as the heat and haze set in, and now we were in a land of ice and snow, however ephemeral. South of us was Antarctica. South were several species of New Zealand penguins—Little Blue, Yellow-eyed, Crested—and albatrosses that patrol the endless cold at the southern end of the earth.

The last hop was down the coast, still southerly, to Dunedin, a Scots-settled city that was the first major nineteenth-century metropolis for New Zealand, capital of the early gold rushes, with Port Chalmers on the Otago Harbor where thousands of the earliest settlers disembarked. Whalers, I knew, had worked out of this long harbor, and at its very end, on Taiaroa Head overlooking the empty ocean, was the only mainland colony of the Royal Albatross, king of pelagic wanderers.

We settled in Dunedin, a sprawling and friendly place of villas and bungalows, focused on the Octagon, a nexus of streets with names like Princes, Great King, and George, for “Dunedin” is the ancient Scots’ name for Edinburgh. On a chair atop a tall pedestal in the Octagon sits Robbie Burns, tutelary spirit of the Scots settlers, who included his nephew. We worked at the University of Otago, the oldest established university and the major medical center for the country.

Dunedin is an archetypal university town, shaped by the schedule and culture of the Varsity, and in term time it fills with students from all over the country—from deep Southland, still sprawling pampas of sheep stations and forestry plantations, and from remote Northland, the old high-timber country and home of the earliest whalers and transient traders. The city rises on seven hills, like all classic-minded conurbations, the center a bowl, with the long harbor to the east and a beach coast rambling to the south.

From Dunedin, my wife and I drove all around the South Island for several months, then spent a final two weeks in a circuit of the North Island. We avoided cities and aimed for mountains, lakes, beaches, small towns and hamlets, the empty backcountry of sheep stations, cattle farms, the revenants of the old lumbering days, deserted mining towns, the long wild west coast, the serrated and hilly country of the northern South Island, from Golden Bay east past Nelson and on to Marlborough.

I read books and viewed films, talked with ordinary folks and

high-powered academics, tried to absorb what is possible from only a traveler's glimpse of a complex society with a dense, thousand-year history. I have tried to focus impressions of a dedicated and lifelong reader of literature on significant aspects of New Zealand's literary culture since the 1950s. I selected a handful among many authors and novels to discuss New Zealand's recent history and culture through its literature. This meant omitting many fine writers and excellent books.

This is not a history or a survey. It is local and idiosyncratic, not general and comprehensive. Much is omitted and much severely compressed. Readers looking for general discussions of New Zealand literature should see Patrick Evans, *History of New Zealand Literature* (Auckland: Penguin, 1990), Lawrence Jones, *Barbed Wire and Mirrors*, 2d ed. (Dunedin: University of Otago Press, 1990), or Mark Williams, *Leaving the Highway* (Auckland: Auckland University Press, 1990). I have tried to be summary but not reductionistic—to write fairly of what I understand. I hope for that audience Doctor Johnson called “the common reader,” a person educated and interested in literature for its own sake, not as a profession or a trade, not as “expertise” or “training,” but for the pleasure of discovering a life elsewhere in books.

I chose novels dealing with significant episodes, eras, and characters in New Zealand's story, as writers of the past fifty-odd years view them. These are partial truths of fiction, imaginative insights into history, not the ordered, dated procession of the chronicler. They are views by individual literary artists that interest me and that I hope will interest readers outside New Zealand. I have tried to draw parallels and analogies with U.S. culture and literature, not to create odious comparisons but to find common points of reference.

To make my reading of literary works intelligible to readers who have neither visited New Zealand nor read its history or literature in detail, I include a running commentary on the history and culture of the place, again with no pretense of being comprehensive or authoritative. Views and judgments are my own, conclusions drawn from reading and observation. My journey in this book is one of living imagination and sense, not of quantitative fact and digitalized reason. I composed this on a computer keyboard and manipulated it by microchip, but I hope the discourse is animated by a fallible, contradictory (and therefore perverse) human spirit, not by mechanical crit-

ical principles mechanically applied. Thus I have shunned fads of contemporary academic criticism—the obsessions with literary theory and its plethora of neologisms as shoptalk for university researchers—and have given summary discussions of literary works to animate New Zealand for a common reader or a literate moviegoer in the age of videotape.

If I have missed the subtlety and complexity of these books, I apologize in advance to both readers and writers. But my basic aim is to drive readers of my book to their books—to see for themselves. My journal of this voyage is only a route map for other travelers. Go: see for yourself, read for yourself, draw your own conclusions. The road is open to the literature, and it is easy enough in our age to make the long flight across the Pacific, to rediscover the length and breadth of Aotearoa.

In my writing I have used the terms “Maori” and “pakeha” to distinguish New Zealanders of Polynesian descent from those of European descent, knowing the dangers and ambiguities with this language. The terms animate a complex, prickly, and ongoing debate about the nation’s multicultural status. I have capitalized “Maori” as the traditional respectful name for members of *ngati* or *iwi* (“tribes” and “subtribes”) who really had no generic term for themselves. The word “Maori” meant something like “ordinary,” “common folk,” or “human beings.” Maori used the word “pakeha” to define the strange new people who sailed into view in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. It has a mysterious etymology but possibly meant something like “pale goblins” or perhaps just “strangers” or “aliens” (in a science-fictionish sense). I have not capitalized “pakeha,” since it was never an accepted generic term for all European settlers (although adopted by some early arrivals who lived with the Maori and called themselves “pakeha-Maori” or by contemporary activists who feel the word grants them a share of Aotearoa on a level plane with “Maori”).

A debate and political movement for Maori rights, a strong sense of *Maoritanga* (“Maoriness”), and a genuinely multicultural New Zealand have developed over the past generation and revolve around the profoundly ambiguous Treaty of Waitangi (1840), Maori land rights and self-determination, and social conditions in the cities, schools, and institutions. This movement has been spearheaded by a drive to revive

and spread the use of Maori as a living language, and terms keep passing into the general culture, showing the movement's efficacy. The dialectical interaction of Maori and pakeha is visible and audible everywhere in New Zealand and has prompted urgent questions and answers about national identity, equality, and justice. It has sometimes echoed the freedom struggle in South Africa and the U.S. civil rights movement, but the "Maori renaissance" of the past twenty-five years is its own unique phenomenon and (I believe) has stimulated the vitality and creativity of modern New Zealand culture.



The format of this book does not follow chronological or historical lines, nor is it animated by critical orthodoxies or shibboleths of contemporary literary politics. I begin in an introduction, "Fishing with Maui," and chapter 1, "Where on Earth Is Aotearoa?" with basic definitions and terms and my impressions of New Zealand's culture and sensibility in the 1990s, ending with discussions of two novels and novelists—the Maori writer Witi Ihimaera's *The Matriarch* and pakeha writer Fiona Kidman's *The Book of Secrets*, both historical epics that detail the heroic struggles, resilience in the face of tragedy, and stoic attitudes of the pioneers of Aotearoa New Zealand, paheka and Maori.

In chapter 2, "Whalers, Sailors, Sealers," I discuss the settling of Aotearoa New Zealand and relate the pioneering Pacific visions of Herman Melville with those of Ian Wedde in his contemporary fictions *Symmes Hole* and *Dick Seddon's Great Dive*. The broad romanticism of Melville is reflected in the dense postmodern ironies of Wedde, as they each define a paradisaal vision whose idealism is tempered by recognizing the materialism and greed inherent in the modern world.

In chapter 3, "The Last Big Islands," I examine the mythic background of Maori culture and relate that to two versions of New Zealand's classic pakeha Man Alone myth, John Mulgan's *Man Alone* and Barry Crump's *Wild Pork and Watercress*. I connect this literary pattern to a survey of four novels by Maori and Pacific Island writers: Albert Wendt's *Pouliuli*, Alan Duff's *Once Were Warriors*, Keri Hulme's *The Bone People*, and Patricia Grace's *Potiki*. These writers all define and develop mythic worlds and patterns of belief to reveal the spiritual

dimensions of Pacific life—the relationships of humans to nature and to the transcendental.

In chapter 4, “Once Were Crusaders,” I discuss the West’s Crusader ethos and connect it with Maori religious movements and the historical epics of the New Zealand wars by Maurice Shadbolt, *Season of the Jew*, *Monday’s Warriors*, and *The House of Strife*. The vicious warfare of the nineteenth century was a powerful force in shaping the ethos of self-sufficiency and hardiness cherished by New Zealanders, and the dispossession of the Maori has been a delicate subject in the nation’s annals. Shadbolt takes on the tragic fatality of the wars directly, to explain his understanding of the national character.

In chapter 5, “The Bildungsroman at the End of the World,” and chapter 6, “The Necessity of Ghosts: Aotearoa Gothic,” I discuss the highly original and quirky fiction of Ronald Hugh Morrieson from two different angles, illustrating two central and characteristic New Zealand literary patterns—the story of a youth’s education and the classic horror story. Morrieson’s antic imagination created classic versions of New Zealand life in the 1930s and 1940s notable for their deftly intermingled terror and slapstick comedy.

In chapter 7, “Falling through the Hole in the Godzone,” I discuss the fiction and autobiographies of Janet Frame as both New Zealand and world literature of the mid-twentieth century. Frame’s story encompasses the nation’s cultural history from the 1920s through the 1970s, and her sparse, poetic prose evokes easily the realities of working-class family life and the life of a dedicated literary artist.

Chapter 8, “Aotearoa at the Movies,” is a brief survey of New Zealand cinema and a discussion of its unique esthetic and viewpoint as a version of postmodern Sublime, with thoughts on Maori esthetics and spiritual attitudes as expressed in the *haka*.

Throughout, I have intercut discussions of literature, film, and culture and tried to counterpoint pakeha and Maori achievements and visions. But the basic force behind my discussions is, of course, my own interests and judgments, which I hope resonate with U.S. and other non-New Zealand readers. I have supplied examples and analogues from American literature and culture not to overshadow or diminish by comparison but to supply useful points of references, the familiar among so much that is new and alien to untraveled readers. Comparisons may be odious, but anyone reading a map needs a com-

pass rose and a scale to understand the cardinal directions and the distances implied. My work here is only a sketch map, not a comprehensive atlas and log. I hope it may serve as the jumping-off point—not the conclusion—of each reader's journey.



I owe vast, complicated debts to many people in the making of this text.

Thanks to Rod and Ann Plank, of Sumner and Lincoln University, whose hospitality, wisdom, and enthusiasm originally led us from Kentucky to New Zealand.

At the University of Otago, Colin Gibson, then department chair, and Muriel King, his infallible assistant, made it possible for me to spend six months in quiet comfort in their Department of English. While I was there, Heather Murray, coordinator of the Center for New Zealand Studies, was a guide, good angel and overseer for me and my wife. She read a draft of the manuscript with keen attention and helped eradicate many blunders. Her husband, David, was a good host and helper in several quests. Janet Wilson, also of the Center for New Zealand Studies, was a faithful correspondent and provided an excellent meal and evening in distant Oxfordshire a year later. Rochelle Simmons and Mark McGuire were keenly interested in the project and provided films, film information, and brilliant intellectual stimulation, including a superb tour of Dunedin from end to end. Lawrence and Marion Jones were both fine hosts and companions, and Lawrence's matchless knowledge of New Zealand literature was a free and golden resource. He also read the manuscript and helped erase many egregious errors and foolish opinions and provided endless insights into the works I discuss. His writings and conversation have been key to all my interests in and understanding of the New Zealand literature he has so thoroughly explored over the past thirty years. To Chris Prentice, I owe a large and specific debt for intriguing ideas she displayed lucidly in a fine faculty seminar and paper, which led to and shaped my own disquisitions on Aotearoa gothic.

Just off campus in Dunedin, George Griffith runs a superb and useful bookshop. He thoughtfully inveigled me into a memorable night (sponsored by the Friends of Hocken Library) commemorating

the centenary of Mark Twain's visit to Dunedin. He also supplied hard-to-find New Zealand books with ease and panache. Happy bibliophily, George! Ian Church and Donald Reid welcomed us in Careys Bay. Ian put me onto Barry Crump's *Wild Pork and Watercress* with his memories of teaching high school, and Donald was an excellent neighbor, raconteur, and host whom we look forward to seeing often again.

At the University of Durham, Chair Dick Watson and Diana Collecott made a six-month stay there both possible and comfortable and located havens wherein I wrote. (Hello and thanks to Sandi Russell, too, while I'm here.) Agnes Delanoye was, as usual, a superb departmental scout and facilitator. At St. Mary's College, the principal, Joan Kenworthy, arranged excellent housing and supplied ever-ready kindness and constant friendship.

At Berea College, President Larry Shinn, the Trustees, and administrators support a generous sabbatical leave policy. Thanks to the Committee on Professional Growth and its chair, Associate Dean Bob Suder, for a grant paying some writing expenses, and to colleagues like John and Sandra Bolin, Dorothy Schnare, and many others who help keep our collective eyes on the prize in terms of Berea College's historic commitment to interracial education, multiculturalism, and the diverse intellectual, moral, and spiritual values of humanistic study. Thanks to Raymond Betts in Lexington, whose example as a superb historian of colonial and postcolonial cultures and whose active encouragement made me think this project was even remotely feasible.

I owe the cover image to three good, tireless angels: Heather Murray, who traced it relentlessly from a teeny clue in my poor memory; Julia Millen, the biographer of Ronald Hugh Morrieson, who knew the painting and led Heather to it; and Marianne Muggeridge, the artist who painted "From Ronald Hugh Morrieson's Room," that wonderfully evocative townscape of Hawera in Taranaki, from the vantage point of No. 1 Regent Street. Morrieson's family home is gone, razed and replaced by a Kentucky Fried Chicken emporium, of all ironic things, but Ms. Muggeridge and a group of like-minded artists tried to preserve memories and visions of the place before it disappeared into the wastebin of our fast-food, throwaway culture. Marianne Muggeridge graciously allowed us to reproduce her superb work. The back cover is graced with a snapshot of my own: the

astoundingly goofy tourist-gorilla who leers over the Marine Parade from atop a dairy store in Napier. This sheet-iron construction is by master *bricoleur* Jeff Thomson, whose gargantuan sculptures (like Morrieson's Rabelaisian novels) embody the mixed spirit of Kiwi gothic—a little shiver, a little giggle in the brilliant subtropical sunshine.

Elsewhere in the wide world, thanks and hello to Scott and Ruth Sanders, who housed us in a London summer, wandered Oxford Street and Portobello Road with us, chewed over some of these ideas, and opened windows into Scott's ceaseless and stimulating flow of literary production. Mike and Char Polad provided us the haven of their home for the thirtieth-odd summer, fed and entertained us, supplied a monster computer and endless technical aid and advice and unfailing interest in my eccentric writing projects. Most of all, thanks to Martha, who was (and is) always there and always made everything possible from hour to hour and day to day, and to the children—Amelia, Richard and Lisse, and the grandchildren, Michael and Robert, just for being here.

Fishing with Maui: Beginning the Voyage

I reached my destination in one of the last months of 1868, but I dare not mention the season, lest the reader should know in which hemisphere I was. The colony was one which had not been opened up even to the most adventurous settlers for more than eight or nine years, having been previously uninhabited, save by a few tribes of savages who frequented the seaboard. The part known to Europeans consisted of a coastline about eight hundred miles in length (affording three or four good harbours), and a tract of country extending inland for a space varying from two to three hundred miles, until it reached the offshoots of an exceedingly lofty range of mountains, which could be seen from far out upon the plains, and were covered with perpetual snow.

—Samuel Butler, *Erewhon*

On the Road Again

The hills are mystical South Pacific white whales in winter—slow-rolling humpbacks surfacing from craggy stone foothills, sere meadows, and expanses of stern high-plains desert. Vistas open out broadly, of rolling paddock upon rolling paddock, of a very high and wide blue

sky spotted by clouds like the lambs that speckle the hillsides, so green-ing earth and towering sky echo each other eerily. As you drive, you climb easily from ridges along which the wide two-lane blacktop slithers, up into suddenly steep upgrades that kink themselves through neck-wrenching switchbacks higher and higher to a triumphal pass with a view of mountaintops in all directions. Touring by car in New Zealand is easy but disconcerting for U.S. cross-continent drivers: no interstates, no big four-lanes, aside from a few tentative miles of what look like abortive test roads around Auckland, Christchurch, and Dunedin.

A few more than three million people inhabit these two big Polynesian islands, one million in and around Auckland, the only twentieth-century conurbation, a ligature of sprawled cityscape around the neck of the North Island that separates the Waikato and the King Country, the broad agricultural heartland (including a lush lakeland thermal zone and a high desert plain pallisaded with volcanoes) from Northland, the old kauri timberlands.

The other two-million-plus New Zealanders are spread thinly across two long islands in a constantly varied and rich topography that includes rugged coastlines with violently scenic volcanic harbors (Christchurch and Dunedin), huge agricultural steppes like the wheatlands of Kansas or Nebraska (the Canterbury Plains), rolling pastureland with rainfall and climate custom-made for sheep and cattle (Southland, Taranaki, and the Waikato/King Country), temperate Mediterranean zones perfect for traditional viticulture (Marlborough, Hawke's Bay), dense rain forests and virtually unexplored "bush" (Fiordland, the Urewera), majestic glacier-clad mountains as imposing and challenging as any in Europe (the Southern Alps), Riviera-like beaches and resorts (Napier, Whangarei).

With only two million people outside Auckland in the islands—roughly the same size as the British Isles—concentrations are small and widely spaced. New Zealand is a land of hamlets and towns. The definable cities (Invercargill, Dunedin, Christchurch, Wellington, Hamilton) are more concatenations of small towns shoved together: low-rise, suburban districts of small, mostly single-story, wooden houses ("villas" and "bungalows") on modest garden plots in the English style, with a few civic buildings of stone or brick looming over low-rise city centers that look like Ohio or Wisconsin in the 1950s,

before the International Style was prefabricated and trucked across America, before vinyl-and-chrome Las Vegas baroque lined the freeway entrances. Streets are very wide—"wide enough to turn a wagon and team"—opening the grids that define most urban plans. Every city is tempered by green space—city parks, "domains," or botanical gardens laid out on the principles of Frederick Law Olmsted. The parks are well tended, planted with year-round flowering plants and antipodean trees. New Zealand cities are made to breathe deeply and face the prevailing winds, in a land of year-round seaborne gales.

The sense of an immediate cultural past is strong: New Zealand captured and preserved the evanescent modernism of the early twentieth century. Art Deco and Style Moderne are well represented and lovingly maintained. Napier, on the sunny east coast of the North Island, was leveled by a powerful earthquake in 1931 then imaginatively reconstructed in the then-most-modern architectural fashion—faithfully reproducing the pastel elegance of Santa Barbara, California.

Everywhere else, signs and facades and civic buildings recall the way the world built its way out of the Great Depression, with concrete, stucco, moulded aluminum, stacked glass bricks. It is lively nostalgia, the immediate past recaptured, an amber-bound Proustian moment from the day before yesterday. Wright Morris, in a famous set of essays on American literature and culture, *The Territory Ahead* (1964), defined nostalgia as a cultural honeypot, a lure toward sentimentality and falsified history, citing the tearjerking documentary art of Norman Rockwell. Traces of this self-satisfied sentimentality exist in New Zealand, but most of the attitude toward the past and the culture is one of cheerful improvisation and suburban *bricolage*—old villas and bungalows are preserved because they are still habitable and comfortable: "She'll be right on the day, mate," the Kiwis say, or "No worries," their equivalent of "No sweat."

Photographer Robin Morrison, a New Zealand artist comparable to American Wright Morris, recorded idiosyncratic island sites through the 1970s and 1980s in distinctive color photographs, usually shot from eye level off the road, at dusk when a certain slant of light strikes facades squarely and colors them through the roseate filter of sunset. His photographs are sharp, hard-edged, and slightly fogged by the flat plane of the light; usually scenes empty of people or human activities—just buildings, isolated, without extensive background or con-

text. They take on their own life, subtly personified or animated, slightly uncanny: a photographic equivalent of the pathetic fallacy.

Morrison was eloquent in capturing strange summer shanties, backcountry wooden churches, ancient hinterland hotels that all seem timeless and valuable, frontlit as if by God's own footlights, on a stage presenting a mystical hometown pageant. When he presents people, they fit like mannekins or actors into these sets, representative inhabitants of lost backblock towns or side-street cafes. Wright Morris, in the 1930s, used a big old view camera to collect similar American images in black and white, off the two-lane blacktop roads of rural Nebraska. He assembled two books of photos and texts to explore these samples of the preserved immediate past—*The Home Place* (1946) and *The Inhabitants* (1949). His titles say it all.

On the road, in the driver's seat, you exit any New Zealand city or town quickly, like a human projectile from a circus cannon. You're in town and then—zoom!—you pass a war-memorial arch (remember the Anzacs at Gallipoli!) or a bandstand or a moa statue of cast concrete standing guard at the playground or the Art Deco Plunket Rooms and you're in open countryside. Odds are then that your road bends upward into a range of rugged hills: the Seaward Kiakouras or the Rock and Pillar Range or the Coromandels. You are always in sight of hills and mountains and ranges of foothills that promise to lead you to the pyramidal immensity of a monolith like Mount Cook or to a soaring range of peaks white-capped even in mid-summer.

The road is generally a well-maintained blacktop of U.S. 1950s standards, two generous lanes wide, well sign-posted, but basically empty. Empty. Empty. You feel—or seem to hear—resonant emptiness in New Zealand, whole taxonomies of void, silences like those discussed abstractly by Zen Buddhists (or neo-Zen would-bes): here it is easy to experience No-thing, No-place, No-one.

The road itself is a major event, an adversary: you wrestle with it, overcome it, watch as it writhes from side to side and surges up and down. No guard rails as you soar up through a pass, just a sheer 1,000-meter dropoff to your left, with bits of the verge badly serrated as if chewed away by a restless *taniwha*. Or the road through some old frontier goldfield abomination of desolation like Ophir or Middlemarch suddenly turns from blacktop to loose, fist-sized gravel ("macadam," as if that ghostly Victorian engineer were to blame!), on which the car slithers and shudders.

Emptiness is always with you, like the poor: you drive through a rich agricultural landscape north of Invercargill, down at the blunt bottom of the South Island, for twenty minutes and do not see a car in any direction. You experience a sudden solipsistic foreboding, a Twilight Zone premonitory twinge: Where are all the people? Where is everybody? No wonder *On the Beach* was set in the antipodes—a ready-made postapocalyptic vacuum. Yet the emptiness is everywhere spackled with traces of domestic habitation and use: power lines, fences, farms and farm lanes, roadside signs. In the rolling meadows always mobs of sheep and cattle standing sentry, or in season Steiff-like lambs gamboling and springing. Somewhere someone is planting and harvesting timber, attending the herds of cattle, shepherding. But out of sight. The wide green world is left to tuxedoed magpies or subtly iridescent blue-gray pukeko strutting in the fields, flocks of seagulls or terns prospecting, lone red harriers gracefully shunting on thermals and watching for carrion.

The immediate, constant presence of humanity, the elbow-to-elbow intimacy of Europe or Asia, the working bustle of the United States, are absent or so attenuated as to seem a faint echo. A vehicle coming into view ahead—the rural mail truck, a farmer's Land Rover, an old Humber or Toyota or Holden sedan—is cause to celebrate. At a closing speed of 200 kph, they are in view for seconds, but it is a human event, a confirmation that the world has not disappeared, that the ultimate solipsistic nightmare has not come true and all the lonely five-billion-plus people of teeming Spaceship Terra have not vanished into the intergalactic infundibulum.

Cars you see, on the road or parked along city and small-town streets, confirm a time-warp, history-in-aspic feeling: time here is a viscous colloid, a microscope slide smeared with a growing culture, preserving the immediate past of World War II Modernism. The cars are lovingly maintained models ranging back into the 1950s, all immaculately preserved and polished. Old Rileys, Jaguars, Humbers, and Morrisies, models of Japanese family cars from the 1960s and 1970s never imported in the United States. New Zealanders traditionally preferred big American cars to cope with the roughhewn dirt roads of the 1920s and 1930s: Chevys, Hudsons, Buicks, Packards. They still nourish a small-town, James Deanish affection for cars as objects of veneration, a culture of cheery Motorheads who swap parts and hold village-green concours d'elegance. Parades of old cars grind on

into the twenty-first century, big lumpy gas-guzzlers slurping leaded petrol and exhaling ethyl fumes into the otherwise unpolluted breezes.

Consider one New Zealand normative icon, as it might be photographed by someone with an acerbic eye like Robin Morrison's: a mint-condition 1955 Chevrolet Malibu 2-door hardtop in titty-pink and ivory, parked before a Style Moderne bungalow of sky-blue stucco with magenta trim, sporting wraparound glass-block lounge windows and shaped like a farmhouse loaf. Off to one side an Edwardian bandstand, dripping gothic gingerbread and smartly painted in high-gloss enamel, red and gold and black. Perhaps (optionally) an incurious sheep grazing on the intensely green grass.

Other Roadside Attractions

The driving can be fast and easy for a leadfooted American. Northward, up and down rollercoaster hills and flat along the brilliant white sand beaches from Dunedin to Christchurch is an easy four hours at 90 kph. You transect small towns every ten minutes. You find a passing space to hump past a big semi or a bumbling farm machine about as frequently. A few cars dribble past, headed south. The landscape streams greenly by—vast blocks of pasture, small farms, hills too steep for anything but sheep.

You can stop somewhere like Oamaru, an east-coast port city of Otago province in the 1870s, planned as a modern commerce and finance center for New Zealand. The forces of settlement and history bypassed the town, left it facing a big harbor with nothing much at its back but a faint, illusory view of the distant Southern Alps. At one end of Oamaru looms a clump of buildings of substantial white limestone, like a sample from Chicago's famous White City at the Columbian Exposition of 1893. Impressive colonial-classical offices, banks, hives for the financiers, investors, insurance brokers, real estate moguls, inventors, entrepreneurs who emigrated to New Zealand on the rumors of gold rushes, gum rushes (to mine the sap of the giant kauri trees, used in varnishes), lumber rushes, the ongoing pastoral revolution.

New Zealand was Samuel Butler's mystical land of Erewhon, a newfound land opening up like a flower, blooming for Victorians with

unknown and unlimited possibility—The Future PLC. So Oamaru (with its ancient Maori name) was to become Tomorrowland, Capital of Potential, An Outpost of Progress. The city center was a white European's forerunner of the Melanesian cargo cults: if you build it, they will come—on a massive scale, as if empty temples of commerce would invoke the gods, and cornucopian shiploads of goods and consumers and workers would fill the broad harbor and pour out into the empty backblocks, stringing a lifeline of credit and money to the banks and offices in the white limestone buildings.

But it never happened. The future went elsewhere, northward. The new South Sea MegaBubble burst, leaving a skim of iridescent slick on the tides of history. The buildings of Oamaru are there, ready and waiting, in case it should all come back—the gold, whales, kauri forests, maybe even the moa that greedy Maori ate out ages ago. So the white buildings of Oamaru are museums and tourist information centers and local banks and town council chambers, or they are empty and eyeless, like a very authentic movie set waiting for a drama to unfold, perhaps the last fatal reel of *Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid*.

The rest of Oamaru is a fairly standard-issue New Zealand market town: a long, high street with a quarter mile of arcaded sidewalk along ranks of little shops—cafes, hardware stores, clothing stores, an august old traveler's hotel sporting a fancy restaurant. Wide streets and little British roundabouts, a long avenue like an esplanade running parallel to the seashore and fronted by kilometers of villas and bungalows, rows of comfortable modern motels, neighborhood corner dairies with giant fiberglass ice cream cones on their roofs to tempt you in out of the blazing antipodean sunshine. A few squat cycad palms in gardens recalling that this is a kind of exotic seaside resort, even if as faded and obsolete a Victorian relic as an antimacassar.

New Zealand, like the rest of Planet Earth in the dusk of the twentieth century, is dependent on tourism—and it is a textbook tourist site, "the world in one country," with at least one good example of anything an international traveler might want: beaches, high-plains, deserts, a system of carefully maintained and safe walking trails ("tracks"), mountains and glaciers, fishing streams, pristine lakes, ski slopes, volcanoes and thermal zones, harbors from which you can view whales and dolphins, funiculars, systems of railways, roads, and airports. Aside from Santa Barbara/Napier, it has its own version

of Aspen or Santa Fe (Queenstown), its own Lake Tahoe (Wanaka), its own Hot Springs (Rotorua). Christchurch and Auckland have built big, vulgar, Vegasesque casinos to feed the national passion for gambling and entice Pacific tourists thirsty for stainless steel, strip lighting, and roulette. New Zealand is a desperately long flight from anywhere except Australia, but it is self-contained as an English-speaking (but multicultural) society with an attractively open, welcoming sensibility.

The landscape has often been called the most beautiful on earth, the climate is mild, the days in summer run endlessly long, and winter is often sunny (if cold and windy). It is a paradise of birds and flowers, and most towns are decorated with vivid plantings, while household gardens are everywhere reckless, Dufyesque splashes of semitropical color.

Spots of shabbiness appear, cracks in the facade: abandoned store buildings in a small town, rusting farm machinery or weed-cradled deserted cars of Appalachian homeliness, long-empty sheet-iron warehouses on a waterfront sagging toward collapse. But the New Zealand ethos suppresses evidence of its perpetual boom-and-bust history: householders prop up, fix up, paint up. Old buildings are patched together in pastel cheerfulness, and bits of agricultural or industrial culture are recycled blithely. It is the original land of do-it-yourself, of Number 8 fencing wire and a quick slap of paint.

The tradition of the summer house—the gimcrack beach shelter called a “bach” (for “bachelor’s”) in the north and a “crib” in the south—is a ubiquitous example of the irrepressible Kiwi *bricoleur* spirit. Most baches are shoved into hillsides or scant lots along the coast, near beaches. They were traditionally hammered together of scrap wood and salvaged fixtures, sometimes incorporating whole elements of habitation—old tramcars, small house trailers, defunct railway carriages. Over decades of family visitation, they took wing, acquiring additions, refinements, extensions, growing like Topsy into sometimes large and complex buildings but retaining the provisional, temporary feeling of a weekend fishing camp or hideaway.

And most baches used the basic ever-present New Zealand *bricolage* resource—galvanized roofing iron. Homely corrugated steel is the number-one visual hallmark of buildings across the islands. Most houses are roofed with it, many incorporate it in siding. It can be cut,

shaped, and twisted almost as readily as corrugated cardboard, and it is perfect for do-it-yourself architecture. It can be welded, riveted, or bolted together in walls of nearly any size. And here it is virtually an element of the natural landscape after some hundred years' freehand use. Big woolsheds and barns may be 100 percent sheet iron. Modern architects of sophisticated Bauhaus sensibility create downtown Auckland homes of pastel-painted sheet iron in Maxfield Parrish towers, Californian poolside villas, tropical bungalows of steel.

You love it or hate it. The British or would-be British often regard sheet steel as so provisional, so offhandedly extemporaneous as to seem "prefabricated" or "shantytown" in feeling. It seems an essence of the "colonial" or "provincial," an embarrassing badge of backwardness. Visitors may be unnerved by a force eight gale driving rain on expanses of percussive metal. Americans tend to think of it as another Kiwi version of Wild West. It stirs memories of a small mining town, half-deserted up near Coeur d'Alene, or the "new" farm that replaced the original 1880 sod houses way out in western Nebraska. It is cheap and nasty or homey and practical, depending on how you think about "home": if you demand the solidity of rocks and flints hewn by members of a medieval mason's guild and piled firmly in place since the late fourteenth century, a New Zealand kauri-wood villa with its tin roof and jigsaw-gothic gingerbread of 1870 is distressingly modern and temporary. If you come from U.S. suburbia, with its slash-and-burn expansionism, where "old" developments (ca. 1975) are seized by HUD, boarded up, and zoned off, while the pioneers push on outward, the New Zealand houses are solid Victoriana, collectibles as desirable as the Art Deco tea sets or rimu dining chairs in antique shop windows.

It is easy to become sentimental or nostalgic about these allegedly retrograde aspects of Kiwi culture, as playwright Bruce Mason did in his masterpiece of one-man theater, *The End of the Golden Weather*, which delves the beach culture of suburban Auckland in the 1930s. Starting with a title and a premise from Thomas Wolfe, Mason explored the vanished world of his childhood and the icons of New Zealand's summertime life. The bach and the beach are the boundaries of his memorabilia.

But much of what strikes the observer in New Zealand is a tussle between preservation of a recent frontier past and a contemporary

microchip-driven world that includes computerization, a Pacific Rim sociopolitical culture, and a powerful sense of individual identity as an island nation. New Zealanders are pulled by the nearly irresistible forces of U.S. popular culture (especially as disseminated by television and movies) toward individualistic hedonism and materialism, while the historical ethos they cultivated was socialist and communitarian, dating back to the planned settling of the New Zealand Company and Samuel Butler's precisionist dreams in Erewhon. The remoteness and loneliness of this most distant human frontier traditionally bred a society that forged strong bonds between people—families, tribes or kinship groups, towns or regions. The emptiness promoted a sense of need for others, an altruistic obligation to defend and support those around you, even if they were out of sight across the mountain. By the late twentieth century, the "global village" feeling, the artificial and tenuous bonds of cyberspace and satellite transmission may erode the last of New Zealand's spirit of helpful self-sufficiency, the utopian idea that there was enough of everything in Erewhon to go around, if we shared equitably and fairly.

A View from Maui's Canoe

An American who has lived through the civil rights revolution of the 1950s and 1960s may be puzzled by the multicultural society of New Zealand, based on a slow, uneven evolution of relationships between Maori and pakeha since 1840, when the Treaty of Waitangi was signed, establishing a definition (ambiguous and contradictory) of a society comprising irrevocably both cultures. About 13 percent of the population now describes itself as Maori—roughly the same proportion as African-Americans to others in the United States. But in fact the Maori are culturally more like the Amerindians, only about 3 percent of the U.S. population.

The Maori are a tribal or kinship-group Polynesian communal people, whose traditional life was based on a simple hunting-agricultural form—small villages, usually coastal, lightly fortified against invaders, with pre-iron age technology based on weaving and wood carving. After the flightless birds were hunted out, the diet was based on a few agricultural staples (kumara, fern roots), fish and shellfish,

small domesticated animals (rats and dogs). Tools were of wood or bone, and boat building was highly sophisticated, while dwellings were extemporaneous and nomadic in feeling. Groups migrated freely but cherished a traditional sense of a “home place”—the landing site of their migrational canoe.

The sense of closeness and homeyness in New Zealand may spring as much from Maori roots as pakeha. The Maori were bound in families and subtribal communities when the pakeha arrived, dragging their European sense of autonomy and individuality with them like Jacob Marley’s jangling chains and strongboxes. The tempering experience with the land itself, with the remoteness of the islands, with the Maori, may have given the diverse Europeans—English, Welsh, and Scots in the south, Dutch, Dalmatian, American in the north—reasons to invent or discover the bonds of small communities.

Maori and pakeha alike were pioneers following an expanding frontier of human settlement. Everyone in Aotearoa was a pathfinder, an explorer. And every community was new, fresh, provisional, and dependent on the cooperation and closeness of the settlers. Like all frontier-settler societies, New Zealand’s has at its center a sense of mateyness, of sharing, of communal work, fortune, and misfortune. It is expressed as a baseline of egalitarian manners—openness, frankness, curiosity about others—overlaid with cool British reserve, the determination to keep oneself to oneself, to save a bit of privacy amongst the public bonding.

The Maori presence in the culture is a leaven to the uptight pakeha traditions—puritanism (the bluenoses Kiwis describe as “wowsers”), middle-class self-containment, the essential trademarks of H. L. Mencken’s booboisie. The Maori value of *aroha*—love, community—has made them traditionally open and hospitable, with a duty of sharing and hospitality their first commandment. Add to this the pioneer and frontier ethic of the helping hand and you have the formula for an open, humane society. The Maori values of *Maoritangi* (heritage, “Maoriness”) and *turangawaewae* (domicile, at-homeness) also have enlivened and humanized New Zealand culture. The paradox of a people known for ferocious warfare and cannibalism and for friendly welcome (*Haere mai! Kia ora!*) produces a culture in which everyone easily says “G’dye” and “Kia ora!” and “Do you like our country?”

Tourism is no new experience for New Zealanders. As early as the third quarter of the nineteenth century, the country was famous for excursions and tourism. The Maori were a great curiosity, and pictures and journalistic accounts stressed flaxen-skirted maidens and handsome Polynesian men against a temperate and picturesque backdrop. The term "Maoriland" was romantic in its implications. Geographical features like the pink and white terraces near Rotorua, obliterated by the explosion of Mount Tarawera in 1886, drew scientists, artists, and gawkers from around the globe. The Southern Alps, Fiordland, the various thermal zones, lakes, rivers, glaciers drew world travelers. The Maori began creating "concert parties" to guide pakeha visitors through their lands, especially around Rotorua, to see dances, hear chants and tales, view (and purchase) crafts. So the glitz and slickness of today's Maori presentations at places like the Whakarewarewa preserve of the Arawa iwi in Rotorua have ancient, honored histories. It is showbiz almost as old as P. T. Barnum.

Watching the Maori women spinning the poi poi baubles, the men leaping and grimacing ferociously in the *haka*, mixed groups playing intricate stick games, singing and describing the *waka* (canoe) voyages, you feel the sense of *aroha* even while the sights and sounds are exotic and alien. The familiar keeps breaking through the Otherness of the mixed Polynesian culture. Old chants have been reset to Western harmonies in handy popular songs, hymn tunes, or folk songs. It is exceedingly odd to listen to an elaborate Maori chant, rendered in beautiful choral harmony, only to recognize a hymn set to "Love Walked In" or a play song set to "Little Brown Jug" or a canoe epic sung to the melody of an Al Jolson revue hit of 1916, a scrap of mock-Hawaiian gibberish called "Yaka Hula Hickey Dula."

The presentations are lighthearted but dignified and polished by long repetition. Like all pageants for tourists, the quotient of sincerity may seem suspect, but the Maori are open and engaging, and it is easy for a pakeha passing through to feel welcomed and respected. Sites like marvelous St. Faith's Anglican Church on the Ohinemutu marae at Rotorua also connect familiarity and Otherness in a strange way. The 1910 building, on a site of churches for 150 years, combines frontier church styles with Maori totemic art in a seamless manner. The exterior recalls traditional English West Country ("Tudor") construction—crossbeams and plastered walls. But rather than the

Welsh-border black and white, it is cream and red, like the Ohine-mutu meetinghouse that faces it across the *marae*. The church might look at home in rural America—Iowa or Ohio—as much as in the heart of Maoriland.

Inside, the church is stunning: densely figured wood carving on pulpit and pews, traditional red-white-and-black painted decorations, and wall panels of the intricate, subtly colored woven flax (*tukutuku*). One large gothic window of etched, rather than colored, glass depicts Jesus in a Maori kiwi-skin robe walking across the Sea of Galilee. The clear pane is backed by a view of Lake Rotorua, over which the Maori Christ seems to stride toward the congregation.

Elsewhere are churches that have grown indigenously to New Zealand—notably the distinctive Ratana churches with their twin steeples and Islamic-looking star-and-crescent emblems. This religion sprang from the healing and preaching of a Maori layman—Tuhupotiki Wiremu Ratana—in 1918 and has flourished since. The brightly painted churches remind us that pakeha missionaries (Anglican, Methodist, and Roman Catholic workers arrived in the 1820s) planted seeds with the Maori that have become native plants, creations now neither pakeha nor Maori but new and prophetic.

The land has been marked by all the settlers over the past millennium. The country that has emerged is both ancient and modern, as new as fiberoptic technology and as old as the surging glaciers in the high Southern Alps. Heading into the twenty-first century on the Western-Christian time scale, New Zealand seems a young nation in a timeless setting, as much an island in world culture as in the great southern ocean. It is now near all the world in flying time and in the instantaneous present of cyberspace. But it remains an island nation still, with a long gaze across the blue seas and a sense of self-sufficiency that is both defiant and inviting.

1

Where on Earth Is Aotearoa?

One Way of Looking at It

The Maori explained the peopling of New Zealand thusly: a demigod or culture hero named Maui sailed the great southern ocean. He cast a fishing line with a magic hook into it in the remote and empty south, far from the many islands of Polynesia, and pulled up a great fish, which we now call the North Island (Te Ika a Maui, “the fish of Maui”). The South Island (Te Waipounamu, “the road to the greenstone”) was Maui’s overturned canoe, on which he sat to fish.

These places were later discovered and peopled by Polynesian explorers in great oceangoing canoes, sailing from a distant homeland called Hawaiki. These Maori (human beings) called the new place Aotearoa (land of the long white cloud, the bright and shining land). The canoes landed up and down the jagged coastline, and each crew staked out a territory. From these ancient crews (said to be mystically seven in number) sprang all the tribes or kinship groups (*iwi*, *ngati*) that define the Maori people.

Aotearoa was benign and rich, covered with evergreen forests, temperate, inhabited by birds and insects (only two species of mammals—bats—lived ashore), without dangerous predators. Many birds in the peaceable kingdom were large and flightless. The arriving Polynesians saw the great birds as “moa,” gigantic fowl like those they had domesticated. The rain forests were dense with evergreen shrubs that over decades grew into huge hardwood trees, ferns that grew into trees.

From the beginning, the place felt like a “land that time forgot,” existing in its own slow dreamtime over an unknown horizon. In Europe and Asia, human settlements were built and destroyed, cities

like Troy rising on dozens of layers of human struggle, war and peace, millennia of technological development, rise and fall of dynasties and empires. Aotearoa existed outside the human definition of the world, like a reminder of nature's heedless autonomy.

The Maori filled the blankness of the bird-paradise, fished, ate fern root, introduced agriculture (with new plants like the kumara), killed the six species of moa in their thousands and hundreds of thousands. Flightless birds who knew few enemies encountered the most rapacious and efficient predator on the planet. Territorially driven omnivores, the Maori developed warfare to demarcate and control Aotearoa—as their myth framed it, to possess the landing points of their great canoes. The dreamtime of oceanic canoes and horizonward racial homelands shaded into the demographic realities of two large subcontinental islands shared by people united and divided by common cultural and religious beliefs, driven by complex processes of exogamy and endogamy to maintain a homeostatic balance of their world. The Maori felt themselves exiled from the peopled center of the Polynesian universe and, like the flightless birds around them, landbound. The fish of Maui and Maui's upturned canoe were limits to the cosmos.

Centuries later, as the pakeha settlers struggled to define their land, they were given one phrase that made it both sacred and familiar. Dunedin poet Thomas Bracken in the 1870s wrote a number of patriotic pieces including "God's Own Country," which in part said:

*Give me, give me God's own country! there to
live and there to die;*

*God's own country! fairest region resting
neath the southern sky . . .*

(Barnett and Wolfe, 19)

The phrase was soon personalized and given a slightly jaunty, slightly sardonic twist, as it became New Zealand's self-conferred nickname: "Godzone." The land has a haunted history, and it is like a "godzone," *tapu* like the nave of a church or a holy space before an oracle, like the open sacred spaces before meetinghouses called *marae* by the Maori. The empty spaces of New Zealand are weighted with a willed silence that precedes epiphany.

The Maori developed a culture based on production and use of native flax (*Phormium tenax*), feathers and fur for clothing, stone and bone tools and weapons, wood for fortification, shelter, boat-building, with a few domesticated plants and animals they introduced into the avian paradise—dogs and rats, voracious mammals. Their subgroups were based on the legends of the canoes and crews, so they defined themselves as travelers not settlers, sojourners in motion not permanently anchored people. They seemed to keep in mind their canoe anchorages against the day when they might up anchor again and sail back to Hawaiki. They kept as pedigrees, as Mayflower Compacts and passenger lists, the landing places and stone anchors of those seven oceanic canoes, along with the names of their captains and navigators. They exchanged among themselves images and sounds but no writing.

Another Way of Looking at It

On December 13, 1642, ships from the Dutch colonial outpost on Batavia, captained by Abel Janszoon Tasman, found the coast of an uncharted land lying in a region where Europeans had long theorized the existence of a large, wealthy continent, necessary to justify the medieval belief in the intentional symmetry of their earth. Tasman's sailors mapped a seacoast and made brief, violent contact with the inhabitants, and four of his sailors were killed. Tasman called this fragment of coastline Staten Land, believing it connected with an island of that name off Cape Horn.

More than a hundred European years passed. Then a British ship, HMS *Endeavour*, reached the coastline represented by one wavy stroke on the Tasman chart. In 1769, Captain James Cook led a scientific-commercial research party to verify or falsify the old theory of the southern continent. Cook sailed around the place now named New Zealand after a Netherlandish province and made accurate navigational maps and topographical drawings of the coastline. Cook also clashed with the native people, and four Maori were shot and killed.

By the 1760s, Europeans were less intent on finding an answer to a mythopoeic riddle (existence of a land of magic and fable from medi-

eval romance) and more focused on new notions of industry, utility, and economics, on a scientific Baconian-Cartesian explanation for the mysteries of any new place on the world map. The *Endeavour* carried a thoroughly modern botanist, Joseph Banks—a pragmatic observer, not a talespinning romancer like Presbyter John.

The most basic confrontation for the *pakeha* (foreigners, others) sailors was with the Maori—humans well settled into the Aotearoa landscape, able mariners and soldiers with a strong ethos of defense. Their heraldic motto might have been the sardonic old French quip: “This animal is dangerous—if you attack it, it bites you.”

Three hundred years after the great Western European breakout, the pattern of exploration and mapping the world was only slightly modified by the Enlightenment and the explosive industrial-technological revolution. Human beings in remote places might be viewed through Thomas Hobbes’ dark glass or in the benignant mirror of Jean Jacques Rousseau: you paid your money in golden guineas and took your choice. You could view these misty islands as the end of the earth, the last empty spot on the map to fulfill the idea of a prison-house earth, a finite enclosure for the human race—no more new worlds to discover.

When Cook arrived off the high mountains of Aotearoa, the North American colonies were moving swiftly toward independence from Britain, the ancient fabric of the French monarchy was rotting, Spain and Portugal had been shoved off the world stage after a century of European wars, and the long British-Dutch maritime rivalry was resolved in favor of Britain. Off the coasts of North America, the great whale fishery was failing, and the southern ocean seemed an alternative hunting ground. From the 1790s through the 1840s, whalers and sealers from North America and elsewhere would be the first steadfast *pakeha* settlers—on beaches, in bays and harbors from whence they launched whaleboats or killed seals. They were transients, clinging to the edge of Aotearoa. Some married Maori women and stayed with the Maori, but most shipped out to some other maritime frontier.

The world beyond Aotearoa was changed rapidly in a process now called “progress” or “evolution” or “development.” Captain Cook’s followers brought with them the requisite attitudes and beliefs about this process of change and all the technological equipment and

expertise to replicate a community of change, complete to the last necessary detail, in that “new world” over the furthest horizon from the old worlds of history.

The world of ordered history and “discovery” collided with the world of timeless myth and “creation.” Robinson Crusoe, on these beaches, met his cannibal kin. When Robert FitzRoy (erstwhile commander of HMS *Beagle*, carrying Charles Darwin to his great discoveries) arrived from Britain in 1843 to become governor of the new colony, the welcoming band struck up a quickstep, “The King of the Cannibal Islands,” as if to emphasize the idea of modern rule and order (kingship) to be imposed on the savagery and isolation (cannibal islands) of this far end of the planet (Mellersh 209).

A Binocular Vision

The Polynesian settlers and their dogs and rats were formidable predators who, along with their introduced agriculture, profoundly changed the islands’ ecology. Yet the environment was benign and temperate. The Maoris invented mythic creatures to fill the landscape—the *taniwha*, a dragon said to have accompanied the migration canoes, became a repository of fears of the unknown, set beside the topography of Aotearoa, which encompassed high mountains, high-plateaus, deserts, rain forests, active geothermal regions with spectacular vulcanism and frequent earthquakes, subtropical zones much like the Polynesian islands to the north. Anxieties were also embodied in the legendary *kumi*, a giant lizard (possibly six-legged!) said to dwell in the deep forests.

When pakeha settlers arrived in numbers, they had similar reactions to the landscape. They established societies to import and acclimatize plants and animals from “home” (meaning Britain in the 1840s and 1850s). They imported literature and culture (“civilization” in European terms, the transformational culture Matthew Arnold liked to describe as endowing humankind with sweetness and light). They set about turning Aotearoa into a half-scale replica of “home,” down to the last detail. The islands, after all, were about the size of Britain and in a similar climatic zone (given odd exceptions). It should be possible, the thought ran, with an infusion of British zeal and Anglo-

Saxon high-mindedness, to make this uncouth wilderness comfortable, safe and utterly familiar. The beloved song ran "There is no place like home," and even this far over the rainbow it might be possible to tame the magic of Oz, to build an emerald city like those in England's green and pleasant land.

The Maori attempts to transform, control, and tame the islands were on a family scale and without ideology, driven only by the pragmatics of daily life. Moa and other flightless birds went into the *hangi* (earthen oven), shellfish middens grew, agriculture modified some landscapes. The geographical scale was the family and tribe, not the town, city, or nation-state. Land was what you could walk and farm, not what could be surveyed, mapped, and reduced to an abstract commodity, a unit of economics, lines on paper and words in contracts. The Maori transformation of Aotearoa was by hand—concrete and physical—while the pakeha transformation was also mental and spiritual: the essentially mysterious idea-dream-connotation of Aotearoa was transmogrified into a verifiable mathematical certainty, the map coordinates and dictionary definition of New Zealand. However, when the British established their claims to the land with the Treaty of Waitangi in 1840, they created not a precise certainty but a maelstrom of ambiguity and uncertainty that has swirled for more than 150 years.

Aotearoa is, in one avatar, the land that time forgot, an Arcadia, a vegetable empire of harmless creatures, a Golden Age and Peaceable Kingdom of soft primitivism. In another avatar it is a land of fearful throwbacks, raw, savage nature, untamed and uncontrolled, the end of the earth, not Godzone but Godforsaken, a small and barren rock onto which the emigrants were dumped and marooned, far from life and civilization.

The poet Allen Curnow wrestled with these prevalent cultural views in his poetry and condensed his feelings into gnomic images. In "House and Land," he projects the idea of New Zealand as a profoundly "unhomelike" place. The immigrants, he says, must have felt

*... what great gloom
Stands in a land of settlers
With never a soul at home.*

A definition of immigration is “homelessness,” and the emigr  never truly discovers a comfortable and always known place to rest. To emigrate is to be rootless and unsettled (thus an irony built into the term “settlers”) for a generation. Only the children and children’s children begin to feel at home, to know only this place, this experience, this field of vision.

Curnow imagines the settlers of New Zealand literally cowering in a strange land (enacting already the idea of the “cultural cringe”), unable to stand upright under their psychological or spiritual oppression, in one of his most famous poems, “The Skeleton of the Great Moa in the Canterbury Museum, Christchurch.” He examines the very tall and erect skeleton paleontologists have restored and connected and thinks about trying to stand up, the basic defining posture of humanity:

*Interesting failure to adapt on islands,
Taller but not more fallen than I, who come
Bone to his bone, peculiarly New Zealand’s . . .*

He concludes with an often-quoted aphorism about future generations who will adapt, as a species, to the new world:

*Not I, some child, born in a marvelous year,
Will learn the trick of standing upright here.*

Curnow projects a powerful sense of the islander’s sensibility in his work, the feeling of isolation and simultaneous imprisonment and security islands offer. In an occasional poem marking the tricentenary in 1942 of Abel Tasman’s sighting of Aotearoa, “Landfall in Unknown Seas,” he notes how New Zealand has been a net gain for the world, an enlargement of the human mind as well as of the map:

*Simply by sailing in a new direction
You could enlarge the world.*

And he returns to the theme of the safe haven and the unknown outside world:

*Always to islanders danger
Is what comes over the sea . . .*

Curnow concludes with the feeling that the sighting of Aotearoa closed a book in human history, a “last frontier” notion, the idea that this discovery was not of a physical place but of a feeling—the sense of finitude or closure for humanity, no more worlds to conquer, no new places to reach:

*O not the self-important celebration
Or most painstaking history, can release
The current of a discoverer’s elation
And silence the voices saying,
“Here is the world’s end where wonders cease.”*

The Garden of Eden was the world’s first prison and haven. An ocean-locked fastness is an image of exile and of safety. Safe landfall—by cloud-shrouded square-riggers or long oceanic canoes—at the “world’s end” is both a satisfying denouement to the human story and an abrupt lapse, a terminal hiatus, in its text. The question left unanswered is “Is this *The End* or *In the Beginning*?”

Witi Ihimaera’s Epic Voyage

Over the past twenty-five years, Witi Ihimaera has cataloged the Maori experience in modern New Zealand. Beginning with naturalistic short stories (*Pounamu*, *Pounamu* [1972], *The New Net Goes Fishing* [1977], *Kingfisher Come Home* [1995]) that detailed life for Maori in rural New Zealand in the region around Gisborne and tracing their migration and adaptation to an expanding city (Wellington), Ihimaera made his generation’s experience coherent and dealt with sociopolitical issues—the search for work and education, the need for community—common to Maori throughout the country. After World War II, as the Maori moved from a subsistence pastoral life to the fringes of modern city culture, they experienced profound upheavals in their family lives.

Ihimaera’s later fiction expanded in scope and complexity, and his 1986 novel *The Matriarch* took on the immense task of surveying

Maori history and culture from mythic beginnings to the present. The tale is deliberately conceived as an epic, based on the story of one family, the Mahanas, and with its hero a powerful woman, Artemis Riripeti Mahana, the matriarch of the title. Ihimaera takes on a radical, revisionary task in that he makes a woman his epic hero and combines Maori and pakeha histories in the family background and in the contemporary culture to create a genuinely multicultural story. It is also both "historical," drawing on real figures from New Zealand's past, historical commentaries, and documents, and "fantastic," drawing on Maori myth and spiritual tales (essentially oral scriptures and tribal lore) and on pakeha equivalents to these flamboyant, heroic tales (mainly through allusions to and passages from the operas of Giuseppe Verdi).

The Matriarch becomes a dense story built up in layers of narrative and history. Artemis Riripeti Mahana has three names: "Artemis," a Western classical allusion (" 'the name of a Greek goddess. Diana to the Romans. The Huntress.'" [250]); "Riripeti," an adopted pakeha name (Elizabeth); and "Mahana," the Maori family name. She lives through at least these three levels of New Zealand existence, one reaching out to Europe and the larger world of remote history and civilization, one dealing with the bicultural realities of everyday life, and one connecting with the independent history, culture, and beliefs of the Maori. So the epic quality of the novel is "classical," "contemporary," and "mythical" in an important synthesis.

The story is narrated by the matriarch's young grandson, Tama-tea Mahana, who by the mid-1970s is an up-and-coming middle-class Maori—well educated, comfortable, with a life and career in Wellington's pakeha society, married to a pakeha—who embarks on a quest to understand the formidable woman who died in 1957, when he was a child. The voyage into the past becomes more and more extended, right back to the roots of Maori history, and he unravels his own family history (*whakapapa*) in parallel with the story of all the Maori. He uses a powerful metaphor to describe the complexity of the intertwined stories in the novel:

Father Blain said that all families are somewhat like jungles. So it is with mine, but I have made it even more of a jungle by mingling fiction with fact, like saprophytic vines

twining the trunks of already dead trees. I think the matriarch herself would have approved of this. After all, she was the one who turned my own life into fiction from fact. (3)

The “jungle epic” grows as one story is engrafted on another, as the narrator plunges deeper and deeper into unexplored territory of the past.

Ihimaera connects the members of his complex family and the outside world through cultural allusions. Tamatea sees his Uncle Alex as “devilishly handsome. A 1940s film star, a cross between Tyrone Power and Cesar Romero. When he and Roha were married they had been the most glamorous couple I had ever seen. . . . He looked like Escamillo and she, in beautiful white lace and satin looked like Carmen, in the last act of Bizet’s opera.” (10–11) The same kind of image, this time drawn from both music or music-drama and from photography, defines the matriarch herself:

There is a photograph of the Italian diva, Renata Tebaldi, which suggests something of the look of the matriarch in later years. The face has a madonna smile which belies the strength of intellect and beauty that the soprano possessed. The brow is broad, the nose finely sculptured and aquiline, and the eyes are proud. . . . The matriarch was like a diva herself and, in the style of her people she proclaimed her nobility with the beautiful moko [tattoo] on her chin.

The photograph of Renata Tebaldi, in colour, appears on the cover of a recital recording which the lyric soprano made in 1965. Curiously enough, the voice of Tebaldi comes even nearer to describing the matriarch than the photograph. (13)

Two means of twentieth-century mechanical reproduction (photography and recording) and two kinds of popular culture (opera and movies) are used to make the matriarch and her family visible and coherent to the reader. These analogies continue through the story, and we find that the matriarch has Italian connections and evidently journeyed once to Venice. She becomes more and more both a “diva”

(an actress in opera) and a character from a great music-drama, one that encompasses her family history and her own personal story.

So Artemis Mahana is firmly embedded in the world we readers share with the narrator. She also exists in a wider world of myth and magic. While his pakeha wife reads Lewis Carroll's fantastic tale of monsters and magic, "Jabberwocky," Tamatea thinks of the Maori creation myth that explains woman and sexuality:

Sex permeated all aspects of Maori life. The mythology of the creation of woman has the god Tane seeking to create a race of mortal people who might live on earth. He therefore fashioned a mortal woman from the mud and earth. Her name was Hine ahune and she had a daughter, Hine titama, whom Tane married. This was the first incest.

Later, Hine titama discovered that her husband was also her father. She fled, horrified, to the underworld to take a position at the doorway through which all of her earthly descendants would eventually pass. This was woman as Death, whom the demi-god, Maui, tried to conquer by entering her vagina. She crushed him with her thighs and thus death and destruction were brought permanently into the world. (23)

Artemis has told the narrator many Maori myths and legends, tracing the arrival of the Maori people to the navigators and canoes that brought them to Aotearoa, describing Maui's fishing up the islands, laying an ageless backdrop for the novel.

When she told Tamatea stories in his childhood, they were magical and fabulous, and Ihimaera's language takes on the tone of childhood, of a naive picture-book universe, as in this version of the creation story:

The creatures of light were spinning and encircling the matriarch with a net of deadly brilliance. The creatures of darkness were shooting shafts of elemental energy into her soul. Then the child looked up into the heavens and saw worlds beyond this earth, and the worlds spinning into darkness, and the creation of new suns and new nebulae,

were the same worlds of his blood. He looked into the faces of the gods and was not blinded. He was in the universe and the universe was in him. (113)

It is a mystical vision from a child's perspective, and it shares something with documents of popular culture as diverse as Stanley Kubrick's image of the "star-child" in *2001: A Space Odyssey* and Maurice Sendak's marvelous *In the Night Kitchen*, which evokes a childish dreamworld with elusive, surreal imagery ("Mickey was in the milk, and the milk was in him"). The image of continuous creation owes something to both Maori myth and pakeha astronomy.

The matriarch's life is studded with incidents that can be interpreted as magical. She uses (or possibly even creates) an eclipse of the sun to intimidate her opponents during a debate on the *marae*. She seems to call down a plague of spiders in the meetinghouse to forestall an enemy. We are never sure if these are "magic tricks" or mere illusions, or if they are in some way "real magic" by a genuine shaman. An aura of impenetrable mystery surrounds her, like the Maori concepts of *mana* and *aroha*, the charismatic qualities of leadership and love analogous to the Japanese concept of "face" or the classical Greek ideal of *arete*. One episode of family history invites us to draw such parallels, from Maori history about 1650 to Renaissance Italy:

If you wish to, you might imagine all this happening against the background of tall castellated cities, and dress the actors in the drama in the rich costumes and accents of the courts of renaissance Italy. Imagine it in Siena. Or Venice. Or Modena, with all the trappings of intrigue and violence and clashes between rival factions in cobbled streets, of courtesans watching from high balconies, and the cortegiani divining the ebb and flow of events. (98)

This parallel becomes dominant as the novel unfolds, so Maori history and culture are compared with those of Italy (specifically the "water republic" of Venice), with its aura of mixed greatness and corruption, of statecraft and vendetta, of courtly drama and family squabble intermingled. It becomes more and more like one of Verdi's melo-

dramatic operas, at once lyrical and ennobling and permeated with tragedy and unavoidable sorrow.

As he searches the past, Tamatea also brings in episodes from New Zealand history that develop the Mahana story. He begins to put the settlement into perspective:

It was a world which had seen the gradual coming of the Pakeha—first as whaler (not only of British descent but Spanish, Portugese, Italian, black American, as many of the Maori genealogies will today testify), then as flax trader during the flax boom, tree feller, evangelist and, finally, settler and farmer. (46)

And the conventional glorious starting point of New Zealand history in the old textbooks—Cook's landfall at Poverty Bay—becomes a bitter moment when the shooting of the Maori who met Cook is re-envisioned by the young narrator:

Captain James Cook claimed New Zealand for Britain. The *Endeavour* finally left Poverty Bay on Thursday 12 October, 1769. The glorious birth of the nation has the taste of bitter almonds when one remembers that six Maoris died so that a flag could be raised and that the *Endeavour* had lain in Poverty Bay for only two days and fourteen hours. (37)

The novel goes on to detail the episodes of the prophet Te Kooti's war in 1868, the Hau-hau rebellion and its bloodshed, a kind of repayment for Cook's initial act of murder and aggression.

Ihimaera draws from contemporary eyewitness history to depict Te Kooti as an epic warrior, using the words of a pakeha settler:

His height is about five feet nine inches, he is about thirty-five years of age, stoutly built, broad shouldered and strong limbed. His features are not repulsive, and rather large development of jaw and chin conveys the idea of a man of strong and resolute will. He has no tattoo; hair black and glossy, wears a black moustache and short black beard. His dress consisted of woollen cords, top boots, and a gray shirt,

over the latter he wore a loose vest with gold chain and green-stone ornament. I noticed that he had lost the middle finger of the left hand. (145)

A portrait as intensely detailed as the photographic study the narrator found for the matriarch. The nineteenth-century testimony makes Te Kooti at once a matter-of-fact inhabitant of a real world and a carefully humanized character. While he is an epic hero like one of the Achaean commanders in *The Iliad*, he is also an ordinary Maori man living in a rough-and-ready frontier society, dressed like a pakeha settler but wearing the Maori greenstone.

Te Kooti's war to drive the pakeha settlers from the eastern North Island was motivated by a personal need for revenge and by religious feelings, the belief that the settlers were defiling Maori homelands. As an exemplar, Te Kooti showed how Maori might resist the seemingly implacable course of settlement. He operated as a warrior-priest, and historian James Belich explains why this was significant at that time:

Te Kooti was able to dominate [his followers] and their warriors through what is sometimes described as "charisma", but this was not the ephemeral magnetism of the hysterical evangelist or soap-box orator. Te Kooti's powerful personality worked in concert with his well-developed belief system, which reconciled the temporal and spiritual worlds in a way many Maoris found intellectually convincing as well as emotionally satisfying. (219)

The Hau-hau or Ringatu faith was integral to the guerilla war of 1868–1872, and Te Kooti was a genuine prophet-figure with a profound effect on his people.

The many worlds and layers in *The Matriarch* include the narrator's personal history and memories—his own experience of growing up in the 1950s and 1960s, of watching Maori society experience a dislocating change from rural poverty to urban poverty, the simple pastoral life of Ihimaera's early short stories replaced by the chaos and debasement of modern city life:

The Matriarch is more politically engaged, more angry and antagonistic than the early stories. At its heart no longer lies the loving evocation of a pre-industrial world of bucolic Maori simplicity, enclosed within tradition, in harmony with the earth. That vision must co-exist with a sharper one of Maori as “bottom-barrel” citizens of a world they have no part in, workers and poor people. . . . Behind the novel’s formal organization lies Ihimaera’s need to show how the wholeness, connection, and meaning he finds at the heart of traditional life were subsumed under the brokenness, alienation, and loss that have permeated and shaped Maori life since colonisation, and especially since the drift to the cities. (Williams 118–119)

In the early stories, Ihimaera used a metaphor, the idea of the Emerald City and the Yellow-Brick Road of the Oz books, to think about his Maori characters moving from the farms to the cities in the 1950s. It is a bittersweet image, evoking ideas of self-delusion, fantasy, childishness, as well as the yearning and sentimentality of “Somewhere over the Rainbow” and the old comfort of “There’s no place like home.” *The Matriarch* keeps asking, via the rummaging of the narrator through his past, “What is home, and do we have a home (now) on this earth?” We have moved from the technicolor childhood fantasy of Judy Garland and *The Wizard of Oz* to the adult tragedy of Renata Tebaldi and *Il Forza del Destino*.

The portrait of the matriarch is detailed and complex. She is a product of two worlds—of Maori and pakeha cultures—and is ambivalent in herself and in her grandson’s vision of her: “Possessed of Maori and Pakeha blood, she was born thirty years [after Te Kooti’s war]. She was already at war with herself. The midwife saw, at her birth, not only that eye swimming in blood. She saw also that the matriarch had her hands at her own throat as if attempting to strangle herself.” (50–51) Like all tragic heroes, she is self-divided. Te Kooti’s war, then, is not just the war between Maori and pakeha but the condition of war within people of mixed heritage.

Ihimaera confronts the difficulty of the past and the legacy of violence in Maori culture. The narrator, as he grows up and in his quest for the meaning of the matriarch’s life, encounters physical violence.

The matriarch herself uses her physical and spiritual powers to keep her family and people in line. The image of the spiders that she calls to her aid in the meetinghouse is a "black widow" metaphor—Kipling's idea that "the female of the species is more deadly than the male." When the narrator finds himself struggling with his grandfather to keep from being superseded as eldest son and heir in his family, he uses the matriarch's magic (it is described as something like voodoo—"I put both hands into the air and began to squeeze. Toroa started to gasp, to fight against an invisible presence."). When he has won, his mother declares sadly, "Your grandmother Artemis won after all." (402) He has inherited the capacity for violence at the core of Artemis Mahana's power as a leader.

The novel includes the Maori political struggles of the past century, up to and including the Land March of 1975, when large numbers of Maori walked a thousand kilometers down the North Island from the far north to the capital at Wellington to present a petition of grievances. This act of public protest is a modern equivalent of Te Kooti's war and his retaliation against the pakeha. Among the final episodes of the novel are stories not historical or political but mythic, the end of the world of myth and the beginning of the modern world of the Maori. One is the last sighting of a sea serpent, the magical *taniwha* of Maori legend ("the great Ruamano, the taniwha which had led *Takitimu* to Aotearoa," 438), in 1913. A second episode is the appearance of a sacred greenstone adze, which appears swimming through the ocean and singing a magnificent at Artemis' command. The adze is the spirit or soul of Artemis' people, and its appearance is the final confirmation of her power as a conduit between the spirit world and the world of human beings, a weapon she uses to break down the doors between herself and her people.

The story has led the narrator to understand his grandmother in a very complex way. His cousin has recalled Artemis for him: "Beauty, intellectual skill, and the ability to debate in a hostile arena—these are the three things your grandmother had. . . . she was able to persuade people to take faith in her leadership. To trust in her as a leader of her people." (26) He remembers her as a beautiful lady with black dresses, pearls wound in her hair, driven in a big Lagonda, who may or may not have traveled to Venice and been known there as Marchesi, another kind of nobility. But she also exists in the spirit world as a magi-

cian, a possessor of power beyond her political skills and charisma as an elder. At one point, a psychologist offers a Freudian analysis of Tamatea's condition to rationalize the whole quest:

"You're telling me a story, a fantasy, and you have used your intelligence to make it so believable that you believe in it yourself. The truth must be simpler, and you are hiding it from me and from yourself also. . . . I would suggest that you were jealous, sexually, of your grandfather. The matriarch was a goddess. . . . Nobody, in your eyes, would have been worthy as her consort except, perhaps, one person. Yourself. But it was your grandfather who slept with her, who shared her bed and took her body." (409)

But the combination of materials Ihimaera blends in the story—myths, folklore, oral history, political records, tribal genealogy, journalistic reports—all transcend the rational explanation or analysis of twentieth-century psychology. The story moves us from realms of fantasy and dreamlike imagery to everyday reality, in and out of a variety of texts and allusions from local and national history to make the point that the intertwined worlds of Maori and pakeha are beyond simple category or historical convention.

The definition and location of Aotearoa in Ihimaera's novel are interwoven with stories of the Mahana family. The process of the story is like the old custom of "ownership" that the Maori once practiced:

In the old days, the boundaries between the neighbouring canoe areas or tribal grounds were mutually arranged and decided upon. . . . These boundaries and the stories attached to their making, would be memorised. In this way, the entire land was like a living geography text and history book in one. The minutiae of life, ah yes, all imprinted and still living, inscribed on the land. And to ensure the continuity of the tribal memory, the people would traverse the land from time to time and from generation to generation. (102–103)

So *The Matriarch* is a "living geography text and history book in one" to find and describe the boundaries of one Maori family and all Maori

peoples over the past century and a half and back into the time of myth. It is interesting that Ihimaera has made his charismatic leader a woman, running against the stereotype of ultra-macho, patriarchal Maori leadership. She is Artemis, the Huntress, and Marchesi, the ruler. She stands in a line of leadership succession that includes Te Kooti, the warrior-leader, and Wi Pere Halbert, an ancestor who was an effective and famous Maori representative in Parliament (and who like Te Kooti was concerned over the issue of Maori retention of Maori lands).

Ihimaera's novel is often flawed: "In style the novel moves from conventional fiction, to expository prose, to rhetorical argument, to historical record. . . . The tone swings back and forth between the grandiose and the banal. All this puts a great strain on any sense of artistic unity." (Stead 192) But it also is ambitious and exciting in the range of its feelings and episodes. It reads like an epic, and it often has the epic's sense of artificiality, as reflected in the quotes and allusions to grand opera, that most artificial, most melodramatic musical form. The novel's flaws are those of overreaching and excess, and perhaps this long road of excess finally brings the reader to skin-tight contact with the Maori world.

Fiona Kidman and the Wages of Sin in Aotearoa

The *waka* that met HMS *Endeavour* as it rounded the coastlines of Aotearoa were nearly as long as Cook's sturdy Whitby collier, their sailing as intricate an exercise in skilled cooperation. For all the superficial differences, pakeha and Maori were much alike: islanders, sea-wanderers, seekers, restless migrants driven by powerful religious impulses. One story that powerfully describes the pakeha pioneer strain in northern New Zealand is Fiona Kidman's 1987 novel *The Book of Secrets*, which traces a set of evangelistic Protestant immigrants from Highland Scotland in the early nineteenth century to Nova Scotia, to Australia, and finally to Waipu, on the east coast of Northland.

The novel is shaped as "women's history"—the complex genealogy of a pioneer family as passed "secretly" by three generations of women and focused on the compelling figure of Norman (Tormod)

McLeod, an evangelical lay preacher of immense charismatic power, known only as “The Man,” as if he were a mythic being (and the only “real” man in a woman’s world). The story, based on genuine historical characters and events, is narrated by Maria, a descendant of McLeod, who by the 1950s lives as a recluse (known as a “witch”) in the old family homestead at Waipu. Maria recites her family history, a pakeha *whakapapa* or genealogy, that includes the tragic history of Scotland in the eighteenth century:

[McLeod’s] people, who were also mine, were driven out of the northwest Highlands of Scotland by the terrible clearances of the crofters a hundred and fifty years back. The crofting people had occupied cottages and land owned by the lairds, since time immemorial. The lairds were like fathers to them, they would do pretty much anything that a laird wanted, including defend him and fight for him. They never thought they would be evicted from their homes, but things changed after Culloden and Bonnie Prince Charlie. The lairds said they had been betrayed; they were hungry devils who wanted some reason to put the people off the land. That is how it has been told to me. They wanted to run sheep on the land, blackfaces they called them, and there was no room for men and women and children alongside of sheep. (11)

The Scots settlers, then, experienced the same dispossession the Maori would experience later.

The novel depicts the settlement of Northland graphically, including the arrival of the “Dalmatians,” the Yugoslav workers, in the 1890s:

At that time the north was full of dark men from Dalmatia, which from my random newspapers I now know as part of Yugoslavia. All the good British people (with whom the Scots were for better or worse lumped in) did not like the Dalmatians in their midst. They were great gum gatherers. That is, they dug out of the ground lumps of a clear hard substance called kauri gum, bright gold in color

though it was translucent. They used it for making varnishes and polishes and it was valuable. They called it poor man's gold. (12)

So a cycle of immigrant "waves" is traceable in New Zealand, as in the United States, with each ethnic group scrabbling up an imaginary social ladder to keep the newest incomer at the bottom.

In 1812, Maria's grandmother Isabella Ramsey, a young, middle-class Scotswoman, followed McLeod's working-class sect, a severely puritanical offshoot of the Church of Scotland that rejected salvation and reveled in the overwhelming probability of damnation. For McLeod's congregation, election is virtually unthinkable and grace unattainable. The pervasive sinfulness of the fallen world is McLeod's whole harsh text. His sermons are often personal attacks on followers, designed to humble them and keep them loyal to his theology and his example. He rejects ordination from the church he despises and leads away the followers he has gathered with his hellfire sermons and disquisitions on guilt and sin. McLeod revels in his heterodoxy and rebellion:

"Miss Ramsey, I will never be ordained so long as I live in this country, so long as the Church of Scotland and its clergy are so much in error in their interpretation of the Scripture and so lax in their moral behavior. There are some people, ma'am, who consider me strangely singular, or even a touch fanatical, because I will not pronounce their shibboleth. I'm seen as a proud and insolent man, but that is as I am, and there is no other way. I will not seek favours or benefits, I will not flatter anyone in order to find an easy way. I chose not to go into the ministry after seven weary years of training for it, and I'm nothing more than a stickit minister, d'you know what that is? Aye, I'll tell you: a man without power or authority in the eyes of the law. But in God's name, I have no shame about this matter, and I know what is best for the people." (51-52)

McLeod's fanatical self-assurance and certainty of belief attract weak, confused, and self-doubting followers who nonetheless are willing to

go with this “stickit minister” clear around the globe to unknown wildernesses.

This mystery of faith and the power of charismatic teaching is at the center of *The Book of Secrets*. Kidman’s vision of the settlement of New Zealand depicts Protestant saints, the dispossessed of Scotland’s barren hills, and their strong, stubborn women, as they discover alien landscapes that become for them home—first Nova Scotia (“New Scotland”), then New Zealand, the two ends of the “new worlds” available. The women bear up under disease, poverty, sexual assault, frontier hardships, while the men often collapse under the physical and spiritual strains. McLeod fulminates against his enemies, including the orthodox church and the women who are seduced by its allure:

“They are pawns in the Church of Scotland’s grr-aand de-signs. De-signs, and stup-id women who put their noses into the business of men. For, yes Lord, it is known indeed that it is women, and especially Mrs. McKay, from the Edinburgh Bible Society, who are behind all of this, despatching witless young men to do their duty in the colonies, yes, and unsettling and dismaying the whole community of men who live on this island, with the exceptions of ourselves, my good friends, and now let us pray, saying, Our Father . . . ” (130)

McLeod’s angry, unyielding patriarchal theology is oppressive and cold, but it is also powerfully attractive to those weak in mind and spirit. The existence of all-pervasive sin and evil explains the daily hardships of the settlers’ lives very adequately.

Kidman’s novel deals with the “secret history” of the settlement—the suffering and isolation of the women—as well as the public history of the determined puritans and their self-sufficient community in the new world. It is a powerful way of re-envisioning women’s stories, the rediscovery of documents and traditions ignored and devalued by “official history” and by the blind, dominating force of patriarchal lineage and rule. McLeod dies in the 1850s, but his heavy spirit has permeated settler culture, and he lives on like a guilty conscience:

McLeod had died one yellow afternoon and the world carried on. True, some would become emotional recalling his last days when he lay by his window and blessed them as they visited. In the final hour he called aloud, "Children, children, look to yourselves, the world is mad."

He was buried beside Mary in the cemetery by the sea. The settlers had cleared land there soon after their arrival, so that those who died could lie close to the ocean, a reminder of all the oceans they had crossed in life. (203)

McLeod is followed by other vindictive prophets, who keep the stringent spirit of barebones Calvinism alive:

Some said that it was this young man, however, who had a visage like McLeod's and that his sermons were full of fire that reminded them of the past. His frequent sharp remarks appeared to be aimed at members of the congregation, striking to the very heart and causing blushes of shame such as had not been seen or felt for thirty years. (209)

The harsh settler spirit is inextinguishable. It has created personal pain and anguish, but it has also sustained the families, planted them forever across the world from "home" and given them the strength to feel at home in this other, alien place.

The force of puritan self-sufficiency has been the means of sheer physical survival, but it has exacted a high cost in happiness and simple human dignity. At the end of her long life, Maria thinks back on her family history, which is also the history in outline of the community at Waipu:

She thought back with care and reopened Isabella's journal that night. It was as she had remembered. The community had been there for a hundred years. A century had passed since the first of the six ships sailed from Nova Scotia to New Zealand, and land had been taken up at Waipu. It must be 1952 or thereabouts. She sat and poked pine cones into the fire. It spluttered and hissed, flared up, illuminating the dark room. She did not need an open fire, for the

evening was warm. But lately she had been feeling the cold.
 And it was company. Now who ever would have thought of
 her needing company?

"I am made of sterner stuff," she said aloud. (309)

Maria dies in her battered seaside house, alone and unaided, cut off from the community that McLeod's harsh gospel was supposed to forge. She has become an outcast, a marooned hermit like Robinson Crusoe, banished and shunned for her supposed sins.

Fiona Kidman's study of three generations of women survivors is an important picture of the puritan-pioneer spirit and its high human costs in New Zealand. It parallels Nathaniel Hawthorne's dark tales of his puritan heritage and the dark secret history of Salem, Massachusetts. The pakeha settlers of New Zealand found a home in a strange land, and they changed and prospered. But as *The Book of Secrets* reminds us, they carried with them a heavy burden from generation to generation, the burden like the weighty wallet Christian totes through the sinful world in Bunyan's primal puritan allegory. The settlers at Waipu brought with them the stink of poverty from the devastated Highlands after 1745, the severe hardships of coastal Canada, the uncertainties of life in New Zealand's Northland among the whalers, traders, lumbermen, prospectors, and freebooters. The hardy women survived by holding to themselves their own free souls, the "secrets" they withheld from patriarchal authority, from the harsh militant spirits of John Knox and John Calvin, of McLeod, "The Man."

2

Whalers, Sailors, Sealers

Outposts and Frontiers: On the Beach and After

New Zealand, after Captain Cook's voyages of mapping and exploring (1769–1772), was settled by small groups of mariners arriving from the new settlements in Australia and commercial seamen opening the vast South Pacific fisheries and hunting grounds. Sealing and whaling began in New Zealand in the 1790s. By the 1820s, the seals were depleted and whaling was the dominant industry. Sealers and whalers had worked the Foveaux Strait and Stewart Island, an easy voyage from Tasmania and Botany Bay in Australia. They also set up stations along the coastlines of both the North and South Islands.

Shore and bay whalers operated differently from the midocean hunters of Nantucket. Shore whalers kept seaside camps, launching whaleboats and pursuing whales that came within sight. Bay whalers launched whaleboats from ships at anchor in harbors. Sealers also worked out of crude beach camps to hunt and slaughter fur seals and prepare hides for shipment. Thus all these industrial sites were provisional, improvised, temporary, essentially commercial processing plants gathering commodities for export. These pro tem New Zealanders were not staking land claims, exploring the interior, or developing permanent settlements. They did begin to interact with local Maori, taking wives, starting families, clearing land for farming, and training men and women as workers in their enterprises.

They created an integrated, familial society based on work and entrepreneurship, not on treaty, law, land purchase, tenancy, and the like. The mariners were British, American, Dutch, Australian. Their basic loyalties were to their employers, to their work mates, to the principles of their labor, to the forces of the marketplace that created

demands for products and skills. The culture created was a coastline society that drew on people and resources of the islands but that was oriented toward the ocean for resources (seals, whales, fish) and for the lifeline to the outside world of money, markets, supplies, commodities. The tiny communities were wild and woolly frontier settlements—the one at Bay of Islands was familiarly called “Blackguard Beach”—and contempt for a rootless, lawless “beachcomber” society prevailed in more-settled regions.

The beach camps and the anarchic society of the whalers disturbed early social planner Edward Gibbon Wakefield, a flamboyant British visionary who in the 1830s promoted a highly organized and rationalistic settlement scheme, the New Zealand Company. Wakefield dubbed the whaler-sealer-sailor culture “the new people,” meaning an ethnically mixed, informally governed, nonnationalistic tribal group antithetical to the ideals of rational colonial settlement and government. The “new people,” as Wakefield saw them, were a mongrelized, heterogeneous band with their own agendas, their own social standards (based on immediate, demonstrable personal competency and productivity, not on inherited standing, family ties, or wealth), and no allegiances to middle-class “homeland” values. Wakefield developed a utopian plan to regulate settlement by carefully monitoring immigration and controlling the labor market, financed by selling the land:

The valuable parts of Wakefield’s theory were that land should be sold, that the proceeds should be used to develop public works and to assist needy people to migrate, and that such migrants should be carefully selected in accordance with their age and occupation and with a regard to balancing the sexes in the colonies. (Sinclair 60)

This regulated scheme would suppress the anarchism of uncontrolled migration and the commerce-based proto-society of the whalers and sealers.

Wakefield’s negative concept of “new people” contrasts with James Fenimore Cooper’s positive vision of the new United States developed in his *Leatherstocking* novels, in which Natty Bumppo (a.k.a. Deerslayer, Hawkeye, Pathfinder, Leatherstocking—his many names indicating what a protean, mythic avatar he represents) embodies a

half-European, half-Indian culture, an integration and synthesis by which a dialectic of historical change is described. Bumpo opens up the wilderness to Europe, protects the settlers, discovers riches, but he also intervenes in the wars of the northern Indian tribes, protects the oppressed Mohicans, brings a questing vision to the static, traditional culture of the indigenes. At the time Cooper was writing, Wakefield and his contemporaries were assessing the realities of the “new people” culture in New Zealand, which they saw as a danger—while Cooper welcomed America’s new people as an opportunity. Bumpo is a weird hybrid of the eighteenth-century rationalist and the romantic visionary in his relations with nature, the land, and the native peoples. Because he is a white child brought up by the Mohicans, he becomes in his person the medium for the development of the land. Wakefield wanted to short-circuit such a social development and promote New Zealand as “a white man’s country.” (Sinclair 64)

New Zealand’s emergent seacoast culture, a thin settlement of mixed pakeha-Maori groups, gave the land the image of a dangerous frontier, anarchic and hostile to the imposed “civilization” of colonial partisans and social planners. Wakefield believed it was impossible to entice prosperous and reliable emigrants through his scheme if the passage into the new land was through these improvised “beach-comber” settlements. At the same time, the whalers and sealers led precarious lives in dangerous work and believed they had earned the complete freedom their enterprise had gained them.

The pakeha frontier of New Zealand was a ring around the islands, the unsettled interior a neck in a noose or in a necklace, depending on your view. Some whalers created coastal farms to supplement their precarious living. But the maritime settlers showed little inclination to strike inland, to disturb the Maori rule over the land, though they were rapidly influencing Maori oceanic culture through the introduction of their high-impact fishing technologies. Rowed whaleboats supplanted paddled canoes, and the risky enterprise of whale hunting was added to the fishing and shellfish-harvesting traditions of the Maori. Some Maori, having learned the pakeha trades, traveled—commemorated by Herman Melville in the figures of Queequeg (*Moby Dick*) and Bembo (*Omoo*), Polynesians who joined the multinational, multicultural crews of whaling ships across the Pacific.

Melville’s vision, especially as cosmically expanded and refined

in *Moby Dick*, is relevant to the background of New Zealand. As Charles Olson regards Melville in a visionary study, he relates the American experience directly to the opening of the South Pacific:

I am interested in a Melville who was long-eyed enough to understand the Pacific as part of our geography, another West, prefigured in the Plains, antithetical.

The beginning of man was salt sea, and the perpetual reverberation of that great ancient fact, constantly renewed in the unfolding of life in every human individual, is the important single fact about Melville. Pelagic. (16)

This sense of a “pelagic” experience is integral to the basic understanding of Aotearoa New Zealand. Olson concludes his meditation with a discursus on “Pacific man,” diagnosing what the Pacific meant to Melville:

(1) an experience of SPACE most Americans are only now entering on, a hundred years after Melville. Of waters, as Russia of land, the Pacific gives the sense of immensity. She is HEART SEA, twin and rival of the HEART-LAND.

The Pacific is, for an American, the Plains repeated, a twentieth-century Great West. Melville understood the relation of the two geographies.

(2) a comprehension of PAST, his marriage of spirit to source. The Pacific turned out to be his Atlantis, the buried place.

(3) a confirmation of FUTURE. We think we measure the significance of Columbus and his discoveries. We still fail to calculate the consequence of Magellan’s discovery of the Pacific. (105–108)

This summarizes Olson’s vision of the American-Pacific nexus and its significance in defining expanding human frontiers.

The idea of the global frontier, as it shaped American (and generally modern) thought, stems from two sources analyzed by historian William H. McNeill—Frederick Jackson Turner (“The Significance of the Frontier in American History,” 1892) and Walter Prescott Webb (*The Great Frontier*, 1952). McNeill summarizes this concept of the frontier:

Webb's Great Frontier, like Turner's, was a region where men with skills derived from Europe met Amerindians and other "savage" peoples who were quite unable to resist the advances of white settlers. The "free land" that white men appropriated was land once used by others. The expansion of one society occurred only at the cost of another's destruction. As such, the American frontier was merely an extreme case of contact and collision between societies at different levels of skill—a pattern that runs throughout recorded history, and constitutes one of the main themes of the human past. (9)

McNeill traces the development of human settlement from Europe around the globe, noting that early frontier cultures developed what he calls an "antithetical complementarity between egalitarian anarchy and legally enforced subordination." (39) This is the theme of many a Western tale, of "no law west of the Pecos" and the clash between the old, conservative law of the "home place" and the new, exhilarating lawlessness of the ungoverned frontier. He suggests that frontier cultures have been permanently shaped by this basic freedom-justice-order tension:

Overall and in the long run, the effect of demographic growth and cheapened transport after 1750 was to reduce differences between center and periphery. But this took time, and whenever a newly emptied frontier opened, the initial stark contrast between freedom and hierarchy reappeared, sometimes briefly, sometimes enduring down to the present. (40)

This feeling of tension between "center" (home) and "periphery" (frontier) is important in understanding pakeha attitudes in New Zealand and the collisions between such anarchic figures as the whalers and the more organized settlers and between both and the Maori.

Frontier complexities were acted out in the development of whaling as the first substantial exploitative industry in Aotearoa. Beginning about 1801, New Zealand became a focus of the worldwide whaling industry, which led to a peak in the 1830s and a rapid decline there-

after: "although New Zealand's whaling production was of importance within the world industry only briefly, the industry in these islands coincided with the highest developments in technique, finance, and effort in the world industry itself." (Morton 16) In other words, a highly sophisticated technology was established in an otherwise raw and "unsettled" frontier—not an unusual occurrence, since open frontiers are often (because of their "unowned" and anarchic condition) sites of high-tech, high-impact extraction, mining, lumbering, and so on, all of which followed rapidly in early-nineteenth-century New Zealand.

New Zealand, through whaling, became the sort of furthest American frontier Charles Olson envisioned, since Americans were "the industry's leaders in technique and organization," and "New Zealand became an increasingly popular destination for American ships. In 1833 about 10 per cent of whaleships leaving American ports came to New Zealand; three years later it was 33 per cent, in another three years it was well over 50 per cent." (Morton 16–17) American sailors brought a democratic frontier ethos with them, and despite the racism inherent in U.S. culture readily set up an egalitarian life with Maori on the beaches. Conditions like those of the southern California coasts in the hide trade described by Richard Henry Dana, Jr., in *Two Years Before the Mast* (1845) prevailed, in which workers set up self-governed camps and traded with the locals under economic (not legalistic) regimes. The brute facts of the environment and the industry and the laws of the marketplace were more significant in determining frontier style and quality of life than arbitrary social structures or laws.

In northern New Zealand, collisions between the industrial whalers and the incoming settlers of the land schemes occurred in the Bay of Islands on the east coast (also the burgeoning capital and bureaucratic center) and the Hokianga region on the west coast. Provisional whaling camps became semipermanent settlements; whalers married Maori women and started families that were incorporated in the *iwi* structure. An unplanned, improvised, and spontaneous culture sprang up on this frontier at the same time that the New Zealand Company demanded an official colonial order from Britain—an imported, prefabricated government with the rules and social distinctions of the Old World built into it. In 1840, the settlers' demands pre-

vailed when the Treaty of Waitangi was drafted and signed by some Maori leaders, and the whole process of land acquisition and homesteading began while the old spontaneous order of the beach pioneers faded into history.

Ian Wedde: Tunnels through Time and Space

There you are: you see Melville hugged in bed by a huge tattooed South Sea Islander, and solemnly offering burnt offerings to this savage's little idol, and his ideal frock-coat just hides his shirt-tails and prevents us from seeing his bare posterior as he salaams, while his ethical silk hat sits correctly over his brow the while.

—D. H. Lawrence, *Studies in Classic American Literature*

Ian Wedde's sprawling, rambunctious epic novel *Symmes Hole* (1986) is a deliberate attempt to create a Melvillean maxi-narrative on New Zealand themes and history. One of the novel's epigraphs is a wistful cry from New Zealand writer Eileen Duggan, "We have no 'Moby Dick' as yet" (16), and Wedde echoes Melville's admiring search for "men who dive" (238) through his own story. It is a rambling late-modernist (or early-postmodernist?) story about an obsessive Researcher (like *Moby Dick's* fusty cetological scholars) who is plowing through heaps of disjointed historical matters—the journal of early whaler-settler James "Worser" Heberley (who staked out part of the harbor before the city of Wellington, where much of the action occurs), the story of Ray Kroc, founder of McDonald's (whose global success story is recited as paranoid conspiracy-theory in the highest Thomas Pynchon style), recollections of the Researcher's own life, meditations on the opening of the Pacific, relations between Maori and pakeha in present and past New Zealand, and other general and specific socio-politico-literary themes.

Wedde's style is intense, elliptical, and disjointed, the Researcher's mind, perceptions, and memory blurred by drink and drugs. The tex-

ture and structure are similar to such modern literary landmarks as Joseph Heller's *Catch-22* and *Something Happened*, Philip K. Dick's *Ubik* or *The Man in the High Castle*, William Gaddis' *The Recognitions*, or Thomas Pynchon's *V.*, *The Crying of Lot 49*, and *Gravity's Rainbow*—that is, blackly comic, apocalyptic, solipsistic, and cunningly paranoid. The familiar pattern of Aotearoa gothic has been stretched and expanded to include the hypersensitive speculations of international Gonzo radicalism in the late twentieth century, in a line that includes such ranting prophets of popular media as Hunter S. Thompson, Thomas Pynchon, Norman Mailer, and Robert F. Stone.

In Melvillean fashion (in a line of descent from such mock-pedantic compendium-writers as Robert Burton [*The Anatomy of Melancholy*], Laurence Sterne [*Tristram Shandy*], and Thomas Carlyle [*Sartor Resartus*]), Wedde begins his novel with a spate of epigraphs and with a mock-scholarly introduction purportedly written by one "Dr Keehua Roa," a Polynesian, with the Social Anthropology Department of the University of West Hawai'i (it might have been Hawaiiki!). These paraliterary devices prepare us for the densely allusive or intertextual format of the novel itself, which is strung together on a series of references to, quotes from, and free paraphrases of such resonant literary fonts as Melville's fiction (principally *Moby Dick*) and his early quasi-fictionalized autobiographies (*Typee* and *Omoo*), Robert Louis Stevenson, and Richard Henry Dana, Jr. Characters from these narratives like "Doctor Long Ghost" and the Maori harpooneer Bembo (Benbo Byrne) from *Omoo*, Fayaway from *Typee*, and others march through Wedde's story, linking the past and present, the imaginary and the historical in an inextricable network. Wedde's surging stream-of-consciousness style erases all distinctions and makes his wildly heterogeneous material equally emphatic in the plane of the narrative.

The central trope of the novel is drawn from goofy nineteenth-century cosmology and fact, the bizarre hollow-earth theory of the "Symmes Hole": "This (Symmes Hole) was the belief that the centre of the earth was hollow, inhabited by another race of beings (Edgar Allan Poe, Jules Verne, Adolf Hitler—guess where he is now— . . . are among those who caught the Symmes bug) and, wait for it, that the entrance, Symmes Hole, was somewhere in the polar regions." (154)

Wedde knits together this idea with other historical abberations like Captain Charles Wilkes' Great U.S. Exploring Expedition of 1842 to the South Pacific, the schemes of financier Jeremiah N. Reynolds, and other events of the era, like Herman Melville's Marquesan adventures in *Typee* and *Omoo*. With the superrationalistic compulsiveness of paranoia, the Researcher knits whole skeins of analogies and coincidences into a unified field theory that accounts for all the political evils and reactionary politics of both the 1840s and the 1980s in New Zealand. He discovers that Jeremiah Reynolds financed the Symmes Hole expedition and that Reynolds' wealthy descendants are involved in both nuclear submarine and fast-food production. He views as equivalent evils of modern life McDonald's hamburgers and the undersea "fish" of the Cold War fleets. He has decided that Wilkes is the historical original of Melville's hubris-stricken and monomaniacal Captain Ahab.

The theorist behind the hole through the earth is described as a Faustian original: "Capt. John Cleve Symmes, hero of the war of 1812, rejected the laws of Newton . . . he almost got Congress to provide money to place 'Old Glory on those interior planets'." (154) The relentlessly analogical mind of the Researcher connects whales with nuclear submarines, whaling with fast food production (both ecologically destructive and indefensible industries), the Symmes Hole insanity with the European peopling of the South Pacific. The image of the Symmes Hole is like the speculative concept of "wormholes," tunnels through space and time that allow a traveler to shortcut circumnavigation, to drill through obstacles as vast as the planet itself, an idea analogous to the mental shortcuts and "interior" connections of creative paranoia itself. The image is like the "infundibulum" Kurt Vonnegut describes in *The Sirens of Titan*, a magical hyperspace funnel that brings together the infinitely remote and the immediate, erasing the rational Kantian constructs of time and space.

Wedde tells his skein of interlocked stories with unflagging, manic energy, and much of the comedy erupts from the mad dash of the prose and the self-inflated theorizing of the Researcher, who simply cannot reject any connection, any atom of "proof," for his speculations, as when he locks together Symmes Hole theory and the garish mythopoeia of McDonald's advertising:

Not just the glass mountain from which tempting light flickered, but the Hollow Mountain within which the children of the Planet Earth could enjoy the fruits of paradise, for ever!

... in fact, not just the Hollow Mountain, but the Hollow Earth! Follow the haunting music of the theme song "Have It Your Way" into the hygienic wastes of Wilkesland, down into Symmes Hole, and whoopee!—it's McDonaldland: here comes Big Mac, chief of patty police, in a big black paddy wagon—he's tending the security system, includes a Burger Alarm and a giant whistle. (165–166)

The Researcher's ultraparanoïd system sews all this together into the link between U.S. whaling in the nineteenth century and military-industrialist capitalism of the twentieth century:

I mean, it's a big grid!—not just the territory, but the time! ... and the hit men know, that the forward-credit capitalist skills of American whaling will segue into armaments and simultaneously shift weight (so to speak) into fastfood. The dollars shiny with whale oil which circulated via Captain Sam Joy of the American whaler *Mary Mitchell* in Cloudy Bay, season of 1836—they're the same greasy dollars that circulate through McDonald's till in Courtney Place, season of the 1980s. From whaling to armaments to food—want to bet there's a McDonald's downtown in Nagasaki? (166–167)

So the notion of the hollow-earth theory, the facts of whaling at the time of New Zealand's commitment to colonialism, and the literature of South Pacific romantics are shaped into a massive gestalt that becomes the Researcher's headlong storytelling and search for his identity in a country that seems "sold out" to every kind of alien interest.

The fusion of the fast-food imagery and the whaling imagery comes in a fantasy, a nightmare vision of the future that is visited on James Heberley (in a device that echoes Philip K. Dick's *The Man in the High Castle*):

There was Den Fujita, the man who brought the hamburger to Japan, he was standing in front of a fast food palace whose facade was decorated with this immortal koan: If we eat hamburgers for a thousand years we will become blond. And when we become blond—we can conquer the world.

Fujita was wearing a blond fright-wig, he'd taken up an aikido ("the way of harmony") stance with his entire baleful attention directed at the garish frontage of the franchise across the road, on which a huge flashing liteshow read, GET HEAVILY INTO HEBERLEY'S below a neon whale sectioned into 240th lays like a Meatboard diagram of prime cuts. . . . "Oh boy . . . Baelena Burgers, I want a Heavily Baelena Burger." (107)

The destruction of the Pacific whales is linked with the mass dissemination of fast food as ideology—the politics of imperialistic capitalism and mass consumption.

The Symmes Hole as wormhole idea gets tangled with ideas like the ubiquity of the White Whale (*Moby Dick*, or *Mocha Dick* in the historical originals, can appear everywhere by diving into passageways through space and time), the ubiquity of mass-produced items like Big Macs, the repetition of adventures and needs and longings from generation to generation (so Melville's South Seas adventures are echoed over and over). But Wedde opposes this monomania with another search that fascinates the Researcher, the search for a genuine historical hero. That is completed in his discovery of the journals of whaler James "Worser" Heberley, a flawed and often fallible human being, an individual swimming against the tide of history and trying to make a small, happy life in the face of chaos and destruction. Out of the horror of whaling, Heberley becomes a settler, a simple family man with modest needs, in opposition to the bureaucrats and social theorists who are colonizing New Zealand:

a place in which he would now be able to see great chiefs
and a woman he loved with his life, and their children,
where the likes of Colonel Wakefield would only see
savages—he would see great captains where the Company

and the administration after that would see no one but a broken shore-whaler like Jacky Love—he would see an earthly paradise, a home, where the men in white flannel would see a licentious Golgotha or an untenanted exploitable resource—he would see a house a home a wife, where the Colonel's galloper would hold his nose at a low whare [hut], a native woman, a rabble of half-caste children and parasite relations. (220)

Like Joyce's Stephen Dedalus, the Researcher is a committed, meticulous historian who nonetheless feels history as "a nightmare from which I struggle to waken" and God as a "shout in the street."

The desperate side of history as a concept (one now discarded in this postmodern end-of-history age) is listed in a large metaphor of searching, which echoes the idea of New Zealand as the result of search-and-discovery missions:

History! . . . the Enlightenment looking for innocence;
microbes looking for hosts; Imperialism looking for
territory; industry looking for raw materials; . . . business
looking for franchise and markets, capital looking for
consumption; . . . Christianity looking for souls to bleach;
. . . James Heberley looking for a home wife and kids in Te
Awaiti. (155)

James Heberley, who becomes known as "Worser," settles in New Zealand with the Maori; he is a single atom, a tiny example in a vast historical progression. But his story is more hopeful than all the sinister strands of the great corporate plot the Researcher uncovers, and Heberley becomes the redeemable average man of the saga, something like Leopold Bloom to the Researcher's agonized, overintellectual Dedalus.

Heberley's wanderings in the antipodes are a rebirth for him. He has crossed the world and must relearn his life, his location, his identity, which he begins to realize when lost in the outback in Australia:

Don't know where I am, he thought. But he was aware
that the ground had stopped its seaman's tilting for the first

time he could remember . . . thinking, I'm but eighteen, I've done all this, mother . . . I'll never be back again . . .

In the mulberry sky the stars were thick as grey mullet. He'd had to learn all them again, everything was arsey-varsey, trees that dropped their bark, kingfishers with heads like coal-scuttles . . . everything was wrong, mother . . . (27–28)

The initial disorientation leads to a new identity, a resurrection of the original, decent man inside Heberley. A sailor through and through, he views the world as a cosmic ocean ("stars were thick as grey mullet"), and the world above his head echoes the world below his ship: "Once, sculling at night with a muffled oar and a pitch flare, netting guarfish above the shallow seagrass flats, he'd looked down through water so clear he'd thought, I could breathe that—shrimps and nodding seahorses came to the light, and the shoals of long-snouted guarfish flashing with blue phosphorescence." (212) He has become attuned to the crazy, upside-down world of the antipodes and the inverted world of the great ocean under his whaleboat, and the lyricism of Wedde's prose here conveys his satisfaction with finding a new and sensuously enticing home. Heberley has passed through the looking glass of the Old World and is thoroughly at home in the New World.

This sense of at-homeness, of finding a "still point in the turning world," is important to the Researcher and to Heberley; it is the theme of the sea-wanderer who finds a home, Melville's Tommo, Joyce's (or Homer's) Ulysses, or R. L. Stevenson's "sailor home from the sea." The Researcher meditates on Heberley's discovery of happiness in the violent, disorderly place that was early New Zealand, as reflected in sea shanties and fo'c'sle songs:

Under the Jack-Tar confidence was the grief of exclusion
from the world "most people" thought fit to take for
granted.

Which was why so many seamen-whalers had beached
themselves with such sturdy commitment to Maori wives,
to their numerous children, to the violent affairs of the
tribes, the hapu? Like Worser Heberley had done? . . .

because, in Te Awaiti you could be respected for your deeds. Whereas in the world of bourgeois educated vandals like Jerningham Wakefield [of the New Zealand Company], you were part of an Adventure . . . whacko, ripping! . . . at best exploitable . . . at worst, scum. (84)

Later, Heberley argues with Doctor Dieffenbach, the great naturalist, about E. G. and Jerningham Wakefield and their racist, exclusionary settlement schemes, resenting their term “new people” for those Heberley counts as “old settlers,” those who came to the beaches and threw in their lot with New Zealand, not the carefully screened and selected yeomen the Wakefields sponsored through the New Zealand Company. (206–207) Heberley has a vision of family and community that opposes the exploitation of “scum” that the utopian social plan represents to him.

Heberley understands Maori culture in an intuitive way—by living with it—that contrasts sharply with the theoretical obsessions of the pakeha settlers. He mistrusts the way the British want simply to transform New Zealand into a small-scale replica of Home, of Old England:

Colonel Wakefield flapping his arms, his head jerking about as if he expected to see a populous town rise out of the ground before his very eyes, English gardens of droopy elms on the outskirts with pretty English women in them, green veins in their necks, and further out post-and-rail enclosures and the squire knocking dung from his riding boot by the stables.

. . . He felt contempt for them. The Colonel’s vision of an English lawn and a drooping elm and labourers’ housing with allotment gardens was just plain daft—didn’t he know that the ground he walked on was steeped in human blood? And that the land he bought didn’t belong to anyone in a way that meant they could do that? (191–192)

Heberley comes to represent an abstract idea of “The Oppressed” in human form—the sailors and seamen scourged and driven by ship-owners and mad captains, the Maori displaced by schemes of “free enterprise.”

This is a lesson for the frantic urbanized present of downtown Wellington (from which we see much of the novel) brought to light by the research into the past:

the researcher's reveries resurrect more than just the capitalist plot that extends over two centuries and links the empire builders of the corporate world to the whale plunderers and colony builders of the South Seas. Also recovered is a counterforce in the form of a nebulous power that lives on in the spirit of the underdog—in the Heberleys of this world, whose secret legacy is their knowledge that their vision of New Zealand as a quiet haven from the corrupting effluent of big business will not die out. (Maxwell 239)

The novel is full of “working-class heroes” of all shades, who represent some aspect of the culture’s heritage threatened by the ruthless business-industrial Toryism of the 1980s, the Decade of the Yuppy.

Along with Heberley, another historical figure who becomes an onstage hero of *Symmes Hole* is Herman Melville, whose prolix, cataloging style and the romantic materials of *Typee*, *Omoo*, and *Moby Dick* haunt Wedde’s novel. There is a long meditation on Melville’s youthful adventures in the Pacific (179–188) that describes the way Melville focused a vision of that new world in his characteristically American writing. In his introduction, the fictitious pedant “Dr Keehua Roa” explains: “Melville’s was a ‘new world’ imagination, and he had, or had learned, [a] philosophy of history, making him a Pacific novelist. It is still a place to start from in his writing.” (9) This view, developed by Charles Olson, makes *Moby Dick* the first Pacific novel in the way that critic Leo Marx once declared *The Tempest* the first American drama.

At the core, *Symmes Hole* is an updating and rereading of *Moby Dick* in the 1980s, “an Augustinian novel about a manichaeian universe, as it is a modernist novel about postmodernist culture.” (Williams 161) It is a story of an obsessive, chimerical pursuit, not of anything as substantial as a White Whale but of ideas and phantoms of the mind, ghosts from past history visited on a present that believes itself to live beyond “the end of history.” The story Melville creates is also about the kinds of people entering the South Pacific in the 1840s (including those at New Zealand)—working men in thrall to corporations (the

whaleship owners and masters of Gloucester and Nantucket), who were much like chattel slaves or like newly colonized indigenous peoples like the Maori. There is a world of “new people” (in Wakefield’s term), described and analyzed at length in C. L. R. James’ eccentric meditation *Mariners, Renegades and Castaways*, which rewrites *Moby Dick* from a Trotskyist, highly personal position.

The Researcher’s rereading of Melville as an anticolonial abolitionist in pursuit of human freedom in an Edenic Pacific is in harsh contrast to the Researcher’s visits to Wellington’s nighttown in search of various personal versions of Symmes Holes that will deliver him from the depressing present: drugs, drink, hitting the road, more research, revery, and memory.

In an earlier short novel, *Dick Seddon’s Great Dive*, Wedde created a Kerouac-like narrative of wandering and doping and goofing on the landscape, the past, the inchoate present. In one passage, he uses photographs as a means to import the historical past and all its ambiguity into the present. One character, Kate, is rummaging the effects of Chink, the novel’s protagonist, to make sense of his early death, when she discovers several old photos:

Delivering stores on the Waipa River circa 1910 . . . for’ard on the flatbottomed steam barge is a large winch. The boat’s got almost no freeboard. The wheel’s roughly amidships, where sacks of wheat and flour are piled. A plank’s been laid from gunwale to bank. In the background are Lombardy poplars whose scale seems incongruous at first: then you realize that they’re still young. There are also some macrocarpa, likewise well-established but young. A road runs past a small farmhouse. In the background is dense bush on hills, possibly Taupiri, the sacred mountain.

Here’s Dick Seddon’s Great Dive. They’re waiting for him to come up. “He stayed under 5 mins. A record!” It’s on the Waikato River, at a Ngaruawahia Regatta. A willow shades a crowd of Maoris on the bank. On the river in the distance is a large canoe. Up close are two boats, the steam boat from which Seddon has dived, and a smaller boat with a brass band in it. Everyone is looking at the calm surface of the river, waiting. . . . In the foreground is a large Maori with a black band on his left arm. (156)

The minute exactness here creates an effect of intense verisimilitude—we see the old photo and feel that it captures a moment of historical reality exactly. The scene is of a “young” New Zealand, of small, introduced trees and plentiful native bush, involving us in an important paradox: what is “old” historically is actually “young,” for as we go backward in time, we reach toward the youth of our world and culture. We, the viewers, are the “old people,” while the photo has frozen in perpetual youth the ancients. The picture captures an instant of silent waiting—for populist hero and Prime Minister Richard Seddon to appear from the river—a second of eternally prolonged suspense, like the “frozen music” of Keats’ “Ode on a Grecian Urn.” It also shows us the surface of things, while the real drama is below the water, hidden from us, so the picture both reveals and conceals a powerful truth. It echoes the idea of the “deep diver” that Melville loved and that is in the background of *Symmes Hole*—the explorer who will find the secret way through our surface world into the worlds below us.

Other photographs are contrasted with the river scene:

Here are two early photographs: *The Tomb of Te Wherowhero* and *The Whare of Te Wherowhero*. The tomb is incongruous, built of weatherboard, set among scruffy bracken, on rough clay, the size of a big dog-kennel. . . . Kate remembers a portrait of the King, Potatau Te Wherowhero, by George French Angas: a tough kind face, hair fierce and curly as though to suggest energy, impatience, intellect, a large *kuru* in his left ear, heavy *moko* [tattoos], sitting at ease in a blanket, probably on the selfsame Delta. . . . By the tomb stands a soldier: a Guide? The *whare*’s also got soldiers around it in ill-fitting uniforms . . . some kind of Palace Guard? (157)

The contrast between seen and unseen is important here, too, in creating a feeling of loss or nostalgia for a heroic past, when this Maori king is represented only by such low objects as the “dog-kennel” tomb, the wretched hut (*whare*), and the shabby soldiers out of provincial comic opera. Where Dick Seddon, the great pakeha hero, is out of sight on a heroic dive to the underworld, from which he will return triumphant, Te Wherowhero is dead and buried away, and there are

soldiers posted to see that he does not resurface. Within the study of the photos is encapsulated the memory of a portrait, to remind us that painting presents the mystery and majesty of people, while photographs hand us only ambiguous realism, the past with all its romance sapped from it by the mechanical process of sunlight and chemicals.

In *Symmes Hole*, Wedde explores the same kinds of paradoxes through the journals of James Heberley, through the books of Melville and Stevenson, through the memoirs and discursive writings of E. J. Wakefield and other colonizers. The issues of settlement and possession of the land, of the routes of exploration and discovery—physical, psychological, and spiritual—emblemized in the metaphor of the title are developed and pursued at great length. *Symmes Hole* is an epic with the same ambitions as *Moby Dick*, with all its bagginess, flamboyance, and excess. The picture it presents of New Zealand in the 1980s is exuberant but not optimistic. The Researcher teeters on the brink of madness and self-destruction in his obsessive pursuits and realizes the futility of an endless search: “Of course, there’d always be more: ‘research’ was infinite regression . . . in fact, it was worse than infinite (parallel), it compounded (diverged) . . . oh, how it compounded!” (268)

His friend Sashay complains that she has been buffeted through time in his manic quest: “‘I fucking feel like Doctor Who.’” (317) She gives him her best advice: “‘Well, you can’t read the future, and you’ve dropped the past, my advice to you is put everything you’ve got left on the present. Stake the lot. It’s all there is. You can’t lose.’” (313) But the Researcher knows that is not enough—that the past obtrudes into the present, that it is caught permanently and silently, like the photographs in *Dick Seddon’s Great Dive*, that it has made us who and what we are. The Maori set great store by photographs of their dead, for they believe that the spirits of the dead are kept in touch with us through their images, that when we see them again, we recall them from the void.

The lesson is an important one for a young culture like New Zealand’s, as the exercise of recapturing the past has only begun. Wedde’s sweeping story expresses both the difficulty of the quest and the pain that it brings with it. But it also implies that we are driven inexorably to find and know our pasts, to find out who and what we

may be. The manic compulsiveness of Wedde's young Researcher may be programed into us, a need to find our roots, to chart our *whakapapa*, that we ignore at the peril of abandoning our true selves. The story of New Zealand's whalers, sailors, and sealers was nearly forgotten seventy-five years ago, when it seemed a painful and disreputable part of the past, like Australia's once-shameful "convict stain." Wedde's novel tries to retrieve it as not only a segment of the complex truth but a genuinely heroic and significant portion of the New Zealand character.

3

The Last Big Islands

If the legend of Maui's Fish is the archetypal mythic creation story of the Maori, the story of Kupe the navigator is something closer to rationalistic Western history. This version of the discovery of Aotearoa is framed in recent historical time and involves mortals, the inhabitants of Hawaiki, the hypothesized Maori homeland.

Navigators and Canoes: Paradise Lost

The story describes Kupe as a skilled sailor and wanderer, an Odysseus of the South Pacific, who compiles knowledge of the seas by experience and intuition. Kupe decides—by foresight or imaginative vision or sibylline insight—that fruitful lands lie an immense distance from Hawaiki, sails and finds the large islands of Aotearoa. After the perilous return voyage, he tells his countrymen of the discovery and recruits them in their seven canoes to sail with him to colonize the empty land. Maori novelist Witi Ihimaera uses the Kupe story as part of the historical-genealogical framing of his saga *The Matriarch*:

Later Maori voyagers came here also, like Kupe around 700 AD, and Toi and Whatonga a few centuries later. Then, in tribal histories we are told of the arrival of legendary canoes from Hawaiki—the *Tainui*, *Te Arawa*, *Aotea*, *Tokomaru*, *Takitimu*, *Kurahaupo* and *Maataatua*. (4)

This tale often accrues layers of rationalistic detail to lend it verisimilitude as "history." Dates are attached ("A.D. 1350" is one conventionally accepted date for the "Great Fleet's" arrival), along with more

or less precise routes and landfalls for the various canoes. The stories often were embroidered or developed by pakeha historians who encountered them:

A number of Pakeha writers were anxious to rationalise and systematise Maori traditions, and by the last decades of the nineteenth century they had elaborated upon such ideas and taken them further. Maori people, who were (and are) keen readers of works on tribal history, accepted this offering, for it suited their purpose. . . . [T]his concept is popular mostly with the tribes which trace descent from [the seven] canoes. It is less important in Northland and in parts of the South Island, where other canoes are honoured. (Orbell 42)

Modern *iwi* (tribal or family groups) derive their *whakapapa* from the Kupe story, so substories of each canoe's landing are attached, often including elements of the Aotearoa landscape that can be located to corroborate the historicity or physical reality of the narratives. Half-submerged rocks at a beach may be cited as the "petrified" remains of an original canoe. Oddly shaped boulders (like those at Moeraki in Otago) are described as the canoe's cargo—baskets, food packages—also petrified. These elements of magical story imbedded in the landscape compare with Western saga elements like Scylla and Charybdis or Gog and Magog or Finn MacCool, Ireland's sleeping giant.

The Kupe narratives are midway between myth and folktale. They have a serious aim like Western history: they are "real," operating in linear historical time (not the boundless, acausal dreamtime of myth), detailed and scrupulous (researched, not improvised) and worth committing to memory. They connect culture to geography and specific landscape. They memorialize the skills and perils of navigating on the planet's largest ocean, about the certainty and permanence of land in a trackless waterworld, about the obtrusion of the past in a concrete, literal way into the present. An *iwi* that over-sees a sacred grove in which is buried their ancestral migratory canoe has found a land anchor for their genealogy that transfers the meaning of the *iwi* from Hawaiki (the lost, Golden Age past) to Aotearoa (the immediate present, with its uncertainties and problems). The relationship of the Maori to the land and the fundamental meaning of

land and landscape in their reality stem from the Kupe stories more than from the Maui's Fish myth.

Kupe's epic tale also connects Maori and pakeha narrative modes. The Kupe story, like the Icelandic sagas or *Beowulf*, floats outside of literary history like an atavistic memory, still alive and resonant but a fossil, a kind of coelacanth. The Kupe story establishes a sense of place, a sense of certainty and belonging, at-homeness for the Polynesian migrants. "Home" and "homeland" are established, and each *iwi* is anchored (sometimes literally—canoe anchors often figure as petrified landscape features) to a locale, an adopted homeplace supplanting the Edenic shadowland of Hawaiki. Thus every *iwi* has a starting point in Aotearoa, and according to another tale an ending point—Cape Reinga, the furthest northern tip of the North Island, where souls of the departed go to make a long leap into the afterworld, out into the limitless ocean where Hawaiki exists.

The sense of a remote homeland reflects an island sensibility. The North and South Islands of Aotearoa are the largest islands in Polynesia. They are also the last major islands on Planet Earth to be explored and colonized—a "final frontier" in an important sense. When the Maori arrived (at about the time Europe was beginning to recover from the catastrophic collapse of the old Roman Empire), they found a temperate paradise of dense rain forests filled with plants and birds, devoid of significant predatory or dangerous creatures, surrounded by fecund oceans. It was a paradise, but like Western paradises it was a closed, walled garden (*hortus conclusus*), a limited and isolated place many weeks' voyage from other lands.

An integral riddle or paradox arises in all tales of paradise: what is the difference between a walled garden and a prison? Do the walls keep intruders out or inmates in? Paradise stories always feel paradoxical, because they are about freedom gained at the expense of security. The "loss of Eden" in Milton's story leaves a sense of unshakable loss and nostalgia and also a sense of possibility and exuberance. The Fortunate Fall is a way to explain why freedom and responsibility are preferable to dependence and servitude. (In Milton's terms it is a lesson about "disobedience," breaking the childhood bond with the father, which leads to maturity and autonomy, the archetypal "leaving home" story.) So paradise lost is (first) expulsion from the womb (into the fallen world of finitude and mortality) and (second) expulsion from the family.

Like all neolithic people, the Maori settlers moved fast to fill the landscape, mapping and exploring and naming Aotearoa, plumbing its resources. In a few generations they visited every part of the islands, and all settlers (however and wherever they arrived) met all others. Territories were inhabited and apportioned, hunting and agricultural patterns established. Some stability of location and culture seems to have prevailed, though there were tales of wars and migrations about the time the pakeha arrived—perhaps populations overstressing resources or migrations reshaping territorial boundaries.

In any event, the Maori met by the first pakeha were described as “warlike” and aggressive by European standards—that is, organized and skillful in neolithic strategy and tactics (about a match for the military skills of the pakeha mariners) and imbued with a strong imperative to defend place and culture. An island culture is ready to stand by and repel boarders, and the Maori had honed the military traditions common to all Polynesians.

The Kupe story crystallizes a sense of place, a sense of “home” for the Maori. No such single cultural explanation was available to the pakeha who first arrived in what they came to call New Zealand. The landfall and explorations of Tasman, Cook, De Surville, and others were minor episodes in an ongoing journey imbedded in a precise chronology (timekeeping and logbooks were crucial in the development of pakeha navigation, and written records underpinned both the exploration enterprise and the pakeha sense of self, of personal and social identity). From the pakeha perspective, the sudden appearance of the shining, silvery-white mountains and clouds of New Zealand were like the apparitions in medieval romance, like the unpredictable and incomprehensible magic of sorcerers and genies in fanciful oriental tales, like mirages—but they were also the expected outcome of a Baconian experiment, like science and history and other orderly, rational thought processes, which could be captured and communicated in straightforward historical narratives and subjected to precise rational analysis. Bacon and Descartes and Hobbes and Newton and Locke were the storytellers for one immensely significant strand of the pakeha cultural narrative.

Cook and his officers drew exact maps and topographical sketches of the shoreline as they circumnavigated the islands (circumscribing and capturing the land on paper, through coordinates and magnetic compass headings, the unknown landscape with its features like

beached stone canoes, anchors, food baskets, etc.). They looked over the rails of their converted Whitby collier to see a wholly alien land through Hobbes' and Descartes' eyes.

If the pakeha sailors could see a paradise, it was one of strangeness and emptiness. "Wilderness" and "desert places," in Western thought of the era, were fearful ideas, dwelling places of demons and temptations and unknown, dangerous animals. In Europe, a sense of "nature" in the raw was developing through the painted landscapes of Claude Lorrain, Nicolas Poussin, and Salvator Rosa, landscapes that were rugged but gardenlike, shaped and tamed by the saving presence of humans and society, "civilized" nature. The Aotearoa landscape did not fit into that pattern but seemed merely void and valueless, fit only to be inhabited by "wild men."

The evidence of the senses, the evidence of compasses and telescopes and clocks and barometers could be organized into pakeha knowledge and carried back to Europe to be retailed. The Maori watching from within the alien landscape saw ships as huge as buildings carrying sails as large as clouds. They saw pale demons (or goblins or fairy folk) of the sort described in many of their stories. The pakeha looking back saw "savages" and "cannibals" and "Indians" of the sort that recurred in the logs and exploration narratives that had circulated since Hakluyt's day. Each watcher could fit this alien Other into a literary-cultural matrix of storytelling. The Western story was linear, chronological, and ongoing, an open-ended narrative, while the Maori story was cyclical, recurrent, and archetypal.

The Maori had to fit these new characters into a sharply bounded, finite paradigm or worldview without damaging it. This was true of the pakeha, too, despite ideas of "scientific curiosity" or "rationalism" or "objectivity." To deal with the reality of a new place and new people, the pakeha sailors used analogies: the Maori were "like" the Caribs and Arawaks of Columbus' time, which he had thought were "like" Marco Polo's descriptions of the inhabitants of India or China or Japan. For Cook's crew, New Zealand and the Maori were chapters in a long story that had unfolded over centuries. For the Maori, the pakeha eruption was a mysterious, one-of-a-kind event, perhaps murkily foretold in legends of pale-skinned goblins who kidnapped some of them, but definitely not a part of the narratives into which Maui and Kupe could be enclosed. The obtrusion of European

ships into the Aotearoa space-time continuum was inexplicable and disturbing.

The Europeans, explicitly charged to “discover” the hypothetical Southern Continent, were mapping, drawing, collecting, locating in space and time the events around them so other Europeans could replicate their voyage, come to these “new” places and possess them. While they were about their father’s (King George III’s) business, Cook’s crew were also carrying out scientific missions—astronomical observations, collection of plant and animal specimens (horticultural pioneer Joseph Banks was the resident Enlightenment genius) for eventual use as agricultural commodities, products to carry away and sell. The Maori they observed fit into a remote corner of such enterprises. The great age of slavery was nearly over, and it was hard to see what “use” the Maori might be, except as guides.

The British sailors on HMS *Endeavour* were skilled laborers in the first stage of the industrial revolution: they operated a complex mechanism, the ship itself, as an element in a sophisticated chain of “information technology.” The crew of the *Endeavour* was organized hierarchically and instrumentally, in the “top down” chain of command of the modern military or the “command structure” of modern industry, and crew members (and officers) had multiple roles to play on sea and on land. Each crew member had a multifoliate identity, the “portfolio” psychology of the modern Western world. Captain James Cook was master of the ship, a servant of the king, an officer in the Royal Navy with a precisely prescribed relationship with officers and men below and above him, a vastly experienced navigator serving the Royal Society and a seasoned sailor with a head full of irreplaceable experience. Every other pakeha sailor had a complex curriculum vitae, including skills, trades, and habits utterly unknown to the Maori ashore.

The Man Alone Myth: Paradise Regained

One cultural myth that dominated New Zealand’s unconscious self-image for the past century has been identified and skillfully analyzed by the preeminent critic and historian of New Zealand literature, Lawrence Jones—the figure of Man Alone, the heroic male in the

wilderness. Jones sees the myth worked out in several ways: "In New Zealand literature of the colonial and late colonial periods, the figure of Man Alone was usually heroic, affirming his society's values." (297) He could become the pioneer-farmer, a synthesis of Daniel Boone and Paul Bunyan, "the Men Alone who are attached to the indigenous myth of the heroic struggle to transform wild New Zealand into a pastoral paradise." (298) This heroic figure became later a tool for social criticism: "a central figure of the provincial fiction of the 1930s and 1940s, not a hero affirming society's values and dreams but rather a victim of the puritanical and narrowly materialistic society that has subverted those dreams, a society whose flaws were made manifest by the Depression." (301)

What Jones calls Man Alone is a dream-figure of Kiwi cartoon-TV culture—the happy-go-lucky joker at the pub, the gumbooted sheep farmer from way in the backblocks, the "dag" (a self-confident and insensitive male, who would be labeled a yahoo or redneck or jock in U.S. culture). His culture is a good-old-boy, Boy's Own/God's Own collage of tramping and hunting, fishing and beer drinking, the outdoorsy belligerence of unrestrained testosterone. He is also a figure of recent history and literature, the phrase itself stemming from a novel that is a New Zealand classic, John Mulgan's *Man Alone* (1939).

John Milton's working title for *Paradise Lost* was "Adam Unparadis'd," and the Man Alone myth is a psychological and cultural mechanism to prevent "unparadisising," to maintain the idea of Adam in the Garden before Eve, before the Serpent, before the Fall. It is related to the cowboy-movie myth and the frontiersman myth in U.S. culture, to Natty Bumppo and Daniel Boone and Davey Crockett and Mike Fink and the Mountain Men, voyageurs, trappers, and traders of the early Far West at the opening of the nineteenth century. When the essential Adam of the pattern receives a helpmeet, it is usually another man, a mirroring "buddy"—in Kiwi, a "mate" or "cobber." So the story is related to the "buddy-epic" pattern of classic nineteenth-century American literature that Leslie Fiedler explored thoroughly in *Love and Death in the American Novel* (1960) and that persists in Hollywood and TV archetypes—Roy Rogers and Gabby Hayes, Cisco and Pancho, Batman and Robin, Newman and Redford and all the countless crime-busting pairs of TV cop shows.

Mulgan's novel is framed by World War I and the Spanish Civil War. A nameless narrator rather like the placid offstage voice in many of Conrad's novels has heard the story and relays it to us. The protagonist is a Briton named only Johnson (as if this were a title or as if he were semianonymous, the "hero with the thousand faces") who emigrates to New Zealand after serving in World War I. He is a drifter and a loner who has been unsettled and deracinated by the experience of war. He reaches Auckland, then a shabby provincial city, undertakes farming as a hired hand, signs on to river scows as a deck-hand. He finds a few buddies in the working-class men he meets during this itinerant life, but he has no plans to settle down. Then the times change: "That was the last of the good years, though Johnson didn't know it at the time—1930, when everyone had money and the war was long over and never coming again. What's a Wall Street crash down there in the South Pacific, or reparations with the summer coming in and the price of butter fat still good?" (Mulgan 39) The walls around paradise are crumbling, but Johnson, one man on his own, does not understand this.

Times change, conditions change, but Johnson remains the same, stubbornly autonomous, not so much unsocial as asocial, unwilling to give allegiance to causes, to sign up for campaigns after the tragic disillusionment of the war. He is a Hemingway hero with the internal toughness and undeflected stoicism of Hemingway's veterans who have been wounded and then grown stronger as they healed. But "stronger" means loyal to the code, the internalized role of the "good soldier" who obeys orders and keeps his own counsel, whose ethical framework is narrow and fragile. Johnson cannot find a wife and a home, cannot imagine a marriage, a partnership beyond work, because his self-protective shield, the armor of his masculine code, is not flexible, will not stretch to cover a social bond beyond the job, the task at hand. This code serves soldiers very well, makes sure that labor is organized, that everyone maintains a specialized role in the defense of the platoon or regiment or battalion.

Yet he is driven by both self-knowledge and the forces of the Depression that are deforming the whole society around him. He wakes after a minor spree with his buddies while they wander in search of work,

lying awake and saying to himself, I've got to get to hell out of this, this isn't any life for a man.

Johnson got to be unpopular because he wouldn't join the U.W.M., the Unemployed Workers Movement. He said to the organiser that asked him:

"I'm not a union man, I'm a farm worker."

"It doesn't give a damn what you used to be. You're unemployed now, ain't you?"

"All the same I never joined a union." (47)

He realizes that "this isn't any life for a man," but he cannot envision himself as joining a larger organization to change the conditions of his existence. "A life for a man" is shaped, directed, and controlled by the Man Himself, the Man Alone.

Nonetheless, Johnson is caught up in his times. He goes into Auckland for a meeting and is swept up in the Queen Street Riots of 1932, in which demonstrators clashed violently with police and destroyed shop fronts in the posh shopping district. Johnson is injured and attacks a police sergeant. He then becomes even more—and officially—an "outlaw." As he escapes back into the dairy country of the central North Island, he runs into a desperate old man who "looked like an escaped convict" and who tells him: "'Brother, you and I are brothers. That is all we know now, brother.'" And then he asks, "'Where is Christ now? . . . Where is Christ now, where is Christ now, and where is Calvary?'" (67)

In the country Johnson finds a job on a small, unprosperous farm with a man named Bill Stenning (again, usually without the first name, as if names were not important in this isolate's world). Stenning is married to a Maori woman, Rua—"little more than a girl, perhaps twenty-two or twenty-three. She had been pretty not long ago; she was still pretty, though sulky and ill-tempered looking." (78) She seems to have an unsavory reputation, according to a gossip lorry driver who gives Johnson a lift: "'She's a bitch, that's all.'" and "'She was well known around here, she was.'" (76) Johnson is an intruder in a grubby little paradise at this point, and Rua protests like a classic nagging wife to Stenning:

"And who he is God knows, and you don't, and up to no good around here. But that doesn't matter to you that I've

got enough work already without cooking and feeding for him as well. And I suppose you think there's enough food in this house for everybody?" (79)

Johnson bonds with Stenning easily—they both know the code of work and order in the rough frontier-style farm. This is a "life for a man" by Johnson's standards.

But the Eve here, the primal Rua, becomes interested in Johnson and seduces him. It is all very simple and natural, as if Rua were conveying to Johnson some message of the way a normal, better life might be: "While they ate Rua was in good spirits, making little jokes and laughing at the things that amused her. After they had eaten she put her arms around him and her face up to his and they lay together on the sand." (108) The Biblical "lay together" reinforces the Garden of Eden feeling, as if the sex were at once casual and very important, as inevitable and everyday as eating.

The fall into sexuality, normality, into a kind of family, threatens to destroy Johnson, to unravel his whole tightly knit individualist ethos, to undermine his stringent sense of self. The affair with Rua moves quickly to a confrontation with Stenning, who knows intuitively of their crime, as do the neighbors. Johnson is enmeshed in the nets of society he has sought to avoid—the nets of curiosity, gossip, lies and half-truths, the rules of a community, even one as flimsy as this backcountry farming region. He is no longer alone but encumbered. He is pushed toward a commitment to Rua, to a shared existence, when Stenning confronts them, seeking the traditional revenge of the wronged husband. The code he and Johnson operate under creates this conflict—in "a life for a man," this is what is expected and what is done.

In the struggle, Johnson shoots and kills Stenning and then flees with a packhorse, a .22 rifle, and supplies to hide out in the bush as an outlaw. The section of the novel that follows is the true *Man Alone* adventure—an outcast running from the retributive powers of society, alone and unaided. Johnson crosses the rugged high-plains desert and mountains of the central North Island and plunges into the most untouched native bush. He learns to track and kill game economically, to cook it, to shelter himself through a severe winter. But gradually the existence starves and wears him down. Even with the wood-

craft skills he is forced to learn, it is too strenuous a life, too many small accidents, semistarvation, cold and unpredictable weather. Even the temperate and semitropical climate of New Zealand, so much like a paradise, is too cruel for an isolated human being.

Johnson is living Hobbes' nightmare after Rousseau's dream of paradise, the pastoral cradle of Stenning's simple farm. In the bush he feels the weight of Leviathan, the forces of society that pursue him and that would try to punish him for his crime—every man's hand is raised against every other man. Yet for all its horror, this section of the story is also one immensely appealing as a male fantasy—the root revery of *Robinson Crusoe* or *Treasure Island* or *Lord of the Flies*, the fantasy of escaping the strictures of family, friends, community, society, to live a wholly unfettered life. The price of this total freedom is total insecurity—no “safety nets” of social aid, no helping hands. Johnson must do everything for himself, discover everything for himself, never experience the simple joy of sharing. The idea is both attractive and frightening as a male daydream. Every boy has such dreams, the Boy's Own version of a seductive, exciting reality pared down to its lowest denominator.

Finally, deep in the trackless bush, Johnson sees a hut, just as he reaches the end of his strength. He enters and collapses, to waken later in bed, being nursed by an ancient hermit, Bill Crawley, another fantasy character like the Old Man of the Hill in *Tom Jones* or mad Ben Gunn in *Treasure Island*. Crawley is understanding, compassionate, skilled as a nurse and tolerant of Johnson's outlaw status. He is what Johnson could become if he lived cut off from society and developed a stoic philosophy to compensate for his lost social bonds and pleasures.

While he recuperates, Johnson catechizes Crawley on the costs and benefits of his hermetic existence:

“What do you do here?” Johnson asked.

“I don't do much, son. You looking for work? . . . I use to prospect a bit once, it's too far away now. They found a little gold right away in here once, never saw it meself. You after gold?”

But it is not Johnson's life of work and bottom-barrel economic struggle that Crawley lives:

"What d'you live on then up here?" Johnson asked him.
 "I got a little money, son, and a pension. It don't cost
 much to live up here." (153)

Crawley is free also of entanglement with women, the distasteful complication that has sent Johnson on the run, hunted by society:

"Everybody gets married once [Crawley says]. She must
 have died, my old woman, time of the last war and I moved
 in here. It was quieter like. That's when it would be."

The phrase "last war" evokes the overarching between-the-wars theme of Mulgan's novel and reminds us that we are watching a small, private war in the context of the great public wars of the twentieth century. Crawley comments sardonically on Johnson's use of the term "the Great War": "They've all been great wars, son. My father called the war they had in the 'fifties the Great War." (154) This is a sinister minor chord, a reminder that what waits for Johnson is not just the civil courts and a murder trial, but the biggest exercise in murder, war—the condition of society he has tried to escape first by fleeing to New Zealand and then by fleeing into New Zealand's unexplored heart. There is no escaping the fact and condition of violence and murder—they exist inside the human being, as part of our hard wiring, a genetic inheritance as fatal as Cain's curse.

Johnson and Crawley have shed the bonds of marriage and society to reach a place like Huck Finn's dreamed-of "Territory," outside "civilization," outside the constrained gentility and politeness of men in the company of women, outside the nets of sexual desire and practice. But if they have reached a haven or shelter, they have also reached the end of the line, the edge of the final frontier—there is nowhere left to go. Johnson's daring trek across the wilderness has been an endgame strategy.

For a while, Johnson's stay with Crawley is like a boy's dream of uninhibited, unsupervised play. Crawley even suggests that Johnson could become a bandit, in the mold of the bizarre Australian bush-ranger Ned Kelly, if he would live an austere and disciplined life:

"You could make a good living with somewhere to hide in
 the hills here—and a good horse. That's the trouble with

those fellows, they always want to go drinking around towns with women and all. That's how they always get them." (157)

Johnson is grown up enough to realize that he cannot fit into the old man's childish dream of a boy's banditry life. Crawley helps him leave the bush and finds a contact in the river traffic who then puts him onto a steamer bound for Panama. Conrad echoes in other aspects of *Mulgan's* novel than the narration—it is a story about sailing into several *Hearts of Darkness*: the darkness at the heart of quiet civilization (as on Stenning's farm), the darkness at the heart of Crawley's hermit life in the dark bush, the darkness of war that awaits Johnson at the end of his voyage on the old Greek freighter.

He reaches Britain and slips easily back into the pastoral dream there, a dream encapsulated by the twentieth century and relentless technological change:

This farm was in Northamptonshire, in the lowlands, where the fen country begins to rise into the hills of Lincolnshire. It lay beside the Great North Road. It was old England and new England. Its grey stone walls and buildings were of the slate grey stone that runs over England from Cornwall through the Cotswolds to die away on these Northamptonshire hills. . . . Across from the farm ran the Great North Road with traffic thundering along it night and day. (190)

The deep solitude and emptiness of New Zealand do not exist on this crowded and ancient island. Johnson fits into the work and camaraderie of the men on the farm gang, which floats along on medieval rhythms. But there are airplanes in the skies and rumors of war in conversations. England rests in an uneasy truce, a state of peace-in-war. Then Johnson hears that someone has been trying to find him, presumably a policeman. He has important memories of his *Man Alone* life, but he is frustrated at never finding his dream, never reaching the ideal state that lurks in his mind:

There were memories of men he had known and liked, men, black and clay-stained on New Zealand roads, sweating on steamer decks, paint-blistered, dirty, and lice-ridden in the

seaman's camp at Panama, tough, sceptical on New York docks. There was a desire in him now for a life that would give warmth and meaning to these memories before he grew too old, for a life active, but with good food and good drink, and men moving, making something together.

It was not here in old-new England, not in these dark green lanes, not here in this village of stone and white-washed timbers, with men, quiet, soft-spoken, and honest. (196)

The only thing Johnson can find in 1937 that corresponds to his dream image of "men moving, making something together" is the Spanish Civil War, a conflict that drew dreamers and idealists from many nations to the embattled Republican cause. He has never found a peaceful occupation that satisfies him, and war is the outlet and condition for the violence inside him, the condition Hobbes defined as the war of all against all, man in the state of nature, outside society, outside the Leviathan of the state.

We are left with an image of Johnson transmitted thirdhand, from an unnamed eyewitness ("this man") to the unnamed narrator to us, an image like a heroic, striding-into-the-sunset portrait projected behind the closing titles of a movie:

He was sitting there with them, very cold and hungry, and not knowing what in hell would happen next with the aeroplanes overhead and the roads jammed with half a million people outside. He didn't say anything, this man said. He didn't seem worried or unhappy. He was just sitting there. This fellow guessed he came through alive, but he didn't see him again. Myself, he said, looking back and considering quietly a war that was not very satisfactory, all things quietly considered, myself I find one satisfaction knowing Johnson is still alive. There are some men, this fellow said, you can't kill.

THE END (207)

It is like the last of Tom Joad in *The Grapes of Wrath*, when he melts back into the crowd, into society, collective humanity, to do his job of organizing and truth telling. But Johnson has no message, has no mis-

sion as defined and altruistic as Tom Joad's. We are to feel, perhaps, that he is expiating Stenning's murder by putting his own life on the line for an abstract, political cause. But Johnson has never articulated a vision like Tom Joad's idea of the masses of humanity as a great, single organism (which is how Hobbes also saw Leviathan, the state—as a great human built of many humans, macro-man composed of micro-men).

On his way out of New Zealand, Johnson had encountered Rua. His only response to her was to warn her not to betray him, to cadge a meal and to disappear:

"I'll be going," Johnson said. "I'm travelling tonight."
She looked up at him. "Where are you going?" she asked.
"Never you mind," he said, and went out leaving her in
the cafe looking after him. (171)

He has forged no bond with her, feels no residual emotion for her. He has killed Stenning out of brute necessity, has no family, friends, ties, home—only the memories of men working, which are never satisfactory because they point to some ideal, meaningful work that Johnson has never found. Mulgan asserts Johnson's invulnerability: he is a survivor, tough, stoical, accepting, self-contained. But it is difficult to understand how his heroism, in a war the anonymous observer has called "not very satisfactory," redeems him as a human model. Mulgan's *Man Alone* adventure has been a sterile journey to a cul-de-sac deep in unregarding nature, and we are left feeling faint pity for Johnson as a victim of war—physical, economic, social, and psychological. His is an image of dumb suffering, like Wilfrid Owen's archetypal World War I soldier, the image also in the old drunken prophet's question, "Where is Christ, where is Calvary now?" We know Johnson will go on, if he has indeed survived Spain, to suffer the next worldwide trauma that begins in 1939, always one of the walking wounded.

The Man Alone Myth: Redemption through Skill

A more recent version of the Man Alone myth, with a subtle and energizing twist, is Barry Crump's *Wild Pork and Watercress* (1986),

one of a long series of hearty outdoors books written in a tone of backslapping camaraderie. Crump began his writing career with a best-seller, *A Good Keen Man* (1960), which imbedded that phrase in New Zealand's language and made Crump a cultural icon, the national emblem of the bush hunter, backblock farmer, always-ready adventurer. His raspy voice and leathery face completed the picture of the man's man ready to recite us a tale of supermacho derring-do. His books often supply tall-tale humor and dag comedy, told with great panache and sensitive timing. His prose is straightforward and unadorned, in the long tradition of tough-guy tales of field and stream.

Beyond his radio-TV image as a guru of the outdoors life, Crump was a careful observer and a skilled storyteller. His books seem designed to capture the eye and ear of the dedicated nonreader, the self-appointed aliterate who would rather eat a toad than read a book. In *Wild Pork and Watercress*, Crump explicitly sets out to define these character types and to give us their story as a tale of self-discovery and redemption. He chooses the buddy variant of *Man Alone* and sets up an improbable adventure of mentor and acolyte with important moral and social reverberations.

The novel records a journal kept by a thirteen-year-old boy of the life he and his uncle led in a nineteen-month stint as fugitives in the Urewera wilderness of the east-central North Island, some of the most rugged native bush remaining in New Zealand. The narrator introduces himself nonchalantly:

My proper name's Richard Morehu Baker but they always call me Ricky. My mother was quarter-Maori and I was born in 1974, years later and a lot darker-skinned than my brother and sister, and don't let anyone tell you that doesn't make a difference. I always had trouble fitting in. People were always getting a surprise to find out I actually belong in our family. I was also a bit overweight and not much good at sports and stuff like that. (11)

Rather a Billy Bunter type, Richard Baker is a naive but perceptive narrator. He is very bright, nerdlike but unhappy and almost feral in his loneliness. His story constitutes a journey of self-discovery and self-fashioning through the wilderness ordeal.

He comes from a broken family and becomes a small-time delin-

quent, shoplifting, filching bicycles, being uncontrollable. He is sent "to Uncle Hec and Aunt Bella's farm at the end of a windy stony road, eighty-seven kilometres from Gisborne." (13) He forms cautious bonds with his aunt and uncle, especially with Hector William Faulkner, whom he sees as "very old. Over fifty. He called himself a bushman but it was hard to tell exactly what that meant. Most of the family used to say he was a no-hoper, when they talked about him at all. I'd picked up that he'd been in prison for 'something disgraceful' when he was young." (14) Hec is short-tempered, opinionated, and supremely competent in the skills he values—farming, tracking, shooting, with all the subskills of animal training, maintenance of tools and supplies, attention to the natural world.

Ricky is exposed to the rhythms and uncertainties of nature and slowly begins to trust these surrogate parents. He learns a new order of values and beliefs, which he absorbs by painful direct experience, as when he clumsily cuts his hand and Hec heals the cut with a country cure, cobweb:

"How did you do it?" he said.

"I must have put my knife in my pocket half-closed," I said.

"Not very smart, eh," he said, and sat down on his staple box again.

"I'm smarter than most people," I told him.

"You're a bit smart," he admitted, and I watched him because he didn't usually admit things like that.

"I'm smarter than you, anyway," I said. "You can't even count 161 sheep."

He started getting up off his box and suddenly I was sitting on the ground with my hearing only just coming back in time to hear him say "... asking for that," as he walked off towards the house. I'd been flattened! (28)

The rude justice and direct action of Hec and Bella reshape Ricky's understanding of himself. He can sense an affection and understanding from them despite the bleakness of the country and the harshness of their teaching methods. It is like boot camp for the alienated boy.

He sees the childless couple as a true family, and he understands

that he is now part of the family, without reservation, qualification or demand: "they liked each other. They were friends better than any other old people I'd ever known before. It was worth putting up with a lot of other grown-up stuff for that. What kept me from running away from there when things got bad was the way Uncle Hec never cared about my Maori skin." (37–38) The bond is fractured, however, when Bella suddenly dies of a stroke. Ricky and Hec are thrown on their own, two rebellious, cantankerous personalities without other bonds or ties. They must learn to trust and support one another. Hector will lose the farm to relatives who will sell off their shares. He decides to take to the bush as a trapper, and Ricky pleads to go with him. The two are minor outcasts from society, lighting out for the territory ahead of the rest. Hec's act of taking Ricky violates the foster-care agreement, and the two become actual fugitives and outlaws, going to the greenwood.

They take minimal survival kits, including their two dogs and a .22 rifle, and Hec walks Ricky into the densest part of the Urewera range to test his resolve, which brings the facts of life home directly to the boy: "Keeping Uncle Hec in sight through the bush became even more important than finding food. He wasn't my best bet any more, he was my only chance of staying alive." (46) Ricky is about to come to terms with his own mettle, his truest inner self. As they pass deeper and deeper into the wilderness, Ricky learns how to make fires and shelters, to hunt, slaughter, and cook his own food, to repair his clothing and equipment, basic woodcraft skills that constitute his heritage as a Maori and as a "settler." They have slipped back in time from the 1980s to the earliest days of New Zealand life.

As in Hemingway's stories of atonement in nature, Ricky finds that attention to detail, sheer immersion in skills and techniques, heals the mind and bonds the soul. As he becomes adept at woodcraft, he loses his physical awkwardness, but he also sheds the clumsiness of spirit that oppressed him. He becomes centered in himself and sure who he is and will become. The therapeutic effects of tracking game, of cooking and eating the wild pork and watercress of the title (along with goat, kiwi, trout, and much else) transform Ricky Baker into a person his ancestors would recognize. He becomes part of a wider family, his whole background or *whakapapa*, as well as Hec's nephew-son.

As they travel by dead reckoning and landmark, Ricky names the places they pass and their campsites, as if he is personally taking possession of the land. At one point, Ricky's book-learned cleverness reasserts itself (despite his earlier "flattening" lesson), when he shows a map to Hec:

"You can't even read a map," I accused him. "Can you!"

"Never needed to," he said.

"But that's why we have to guess where we are half the time," I said. "That's what maps are for, so you can tell exactly where you are. Don't you realise that?"

"I usually get there," he said. (58)

Ricky still believes he must look at a book or a map or a piece of authentic, credentialed knowledge to know where he is. Hec has an inward compass and gyroscope, a sense of self-assurance and autonomy, that tells him where he is and where he is going. The journey they are on will endow this also on Ricky.

The travel is bruising and dangerous, the weather and countryside treacherous and unyielding. Ricky becomes fascinated by the bush birds and yearns to photograph them. Hec tells him how he was once taught to live in nature by an old aboriginal woman in Australia:

She just moved so good through the bush she never hassled an ant. She could tell you by the state of the insects what birds were in their area. . . . When we were looking for tucker I had to stay so far behind her I could hardly keep her in sight—I was so clumsy compared to her. I'm not bad in the scrub myself, but the only use I was to her was carrying the fire-stick and helping her roll logs over to get at the grubs. (75)

Ricky can connect himself to the aboriginal woman as a Maori-like ancestral figure, and he internalizes her as a totem and ideal. If he can learn this level of woodcraft, he can live among the birds and capture their wild images on film.

As they stay in the bush, the forces of law and order—the social welfare officers and police—begin to search for them, first as missing

persons and then as fugitives. The search adds spice and urgency to their survivalist adventure, creating an exciting game of hide-and-seek, us-against-them, natural men versus the mechanical laws and methods of society, which tracks them with helicopters and dogs. Eventually they find a sheep farmer on a remote station who shelters and helps them. They restock, eat, taste the benefits of civilization for the first time in months. Ricky sees himself in a mirror and realizes that he has changed:

"I'm thin," I said. "You're not allowed to call me fat any more."

"I don't," he said, drinking whisky out of a tea cup.

"Haven't called you that for months."

"Ever again," I said. (119)

Ricky has changed internally and externally, but he has not been able to see the change, any more than he could hear what his uncle was not saying to him. The vanished boyhood fat is like his awkward, alienated self, sloughed off and wasted away by the hardships of their spartan lives in the Urewera.

Robby, the sheep farmer who befriends them, in an epilogue to Ricky's narration, tells how he saw them:

They were both dressed in rags tied round with strips of torn cloth and flax. Where a button was missing they'd poked the cloth through the button-hole and inserted a piece of stick through it. One of the boy's trouser-legs had frayed off above the knee and the leg was covered with old bruises and scratches and he had a large scab on his knee that didn't look at all healthy. (157)

And the ordeal has altered more than their clothes—they have become animal-like in their reflexes: "They were both very nervous, especially the boy. They had a habit of glancing at one another every few seconds, for reassurance perhaps. . . . [T]hey arrived out of the dark that night like two wild animals, blinking in the light, looking around suspiciously and glancing quickly at each other at every sound." (158) They have formed a community of two that

holds together for security and survival, Ricky and Hec against the world.

While at Robby's farmhouse, the two admit their love for one another and their mutual dependence. They have brought in possum skins to sell and decide they will return to the wilderness. They have discovered much about each other and themselves. Ricky learns that Hector is illiterate, which explains much of his disdain for and distrust of formal education and his stubborn, touchy self-reliance. It reinforces Ricky's value for both sides of his own character—the educated, civilized side and the wild, intuitive side. He begins to understand how he is a synthesis of the best aspects of the Faulkner-Baker-Morehu family heritage.

In one of the most dangerous episodes of their trek, Ricky and Hec discover high, nearly unscalable cliffs, with some unusual bird life: "A big, shiny bird with an orange tuft on its neck was hopping around in the branches of a dead beech tree, picking grubs out of the peeling bark. Another one, a bit smaller with a smaller, straighter beak and not so brilliant, flew in and hopped and skipped up the same branch." (143) Hec has told Ricky these are kokako, an endangered species. Hec later tells Ricky that the birds are not kokako but huia, an unusual, gaudy species thought extinct since the turn of the century. They sell their possum skins and buy a good camera to photograph the huia, make their fortunes, and establish Ricky as a wildlife photographer with a worldwide reputation.

Ricky's narration ends with an optimistic note: "We've got a few hassles coming up, but we can handle them. We're okay now." (153) The story is rounded by Robby's epilogue, which tells us that the pair have never returned from their expedition, and we are left to guess why—if they have simply stayed in the bush, if they have repined of telling the callous world of the rare birds, if they have died in the attempt. Robby feels the latter explanation is probable: "Hec and Ricky must have dropped off one more ridge in a tricky place—too tricky. I do believe they're still out there in the Urewera bush, two ragged skeletons lying at the bottom of some bluffs, somewhere along the Huiaarau Range. Kokako Bluffs." (162) But Robby gives a more hopeful alternative to close the novel: "I'm not a particularly religious man, but if there's any justice in this life Ricky and his Uncle Hec are okay. Still sticking it out together and handling their own hassles in their own way. I hope so." (163)

And so do we, by this time, for Ricky and Hec have become the classic underdog buddies who deserve to win, to escape the cruelties of fate and nature. Just as Redford and Newman are frozen in time and space in the last frames of *Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid*, not dead but memorialized like the dancers on Keats' urn, so are Hec and Ricky caught in memory, out there in a landscape of mystery and possibility. No more dead than the huia's are extinct, but only hiding, sheltered by nature and distance from the judgments and limitations of our world, the multitudinous "hassles" of civilization and its discontents.

Wild Pork and Watercress is a wish-fulfillment story of a classic kind—on the order of *The Wizard of Oz* (a family of aunt-uncle-child) or *Treasure Island* (the dangerous voyage and the adoptive pilot) or *Huckleberry Finn* (the idyll during the odyssey of escape). Barry Crump has constructed a small-scale and believable adventure yarn that young readers will accept, along with its message of reconciliation of self with nature and individual with family apposite at the end of the troubled twentieth century. His version of the Man Alone story has the same mythic resonances as John Mulgan's, and its basic ideology is more constructive and salutary. It follows the pattern of growing up in New Zealand that is developed in many more-sophisticated Bildungsroman and uses the pattern for a modest but laudable end. The characters of Hec Faulkner and Ricky Baker become legendary in the end and point us back to meanings of New Zealand's wild past that are intractably imbedded in its present and future.

Pacific Visions: Four Exemplary Novels

Maori and Pacific Island writers of the past two decades provide a unique perspective on the lives and beliefs of people who exist in a complex transitional zone between traditional cultures and the fully technologized world of late-twentieth-century modernism. Central in their stories is not the Man Alone myth of Western individualism but a focus on the values of family and kinship. The inexorable erosion of the family in modern culture is a tragic truth defined and described in many ways. Four novels of the past twenty years show how kinship-focused cultures may still survive and even triumph.

Pouliuli: The Tragedy of Decline

Albert Wendt's *Pouliuli* (1977), a compact, dramatic tale of Samoa in the first three-quarters of the twentieth century, describes the life of a small village, Malaelua, and its complex family-structured order. The story is a tragedy of old age, power, authority, and renunciation of the sort that fascinated Shakespeare in his late plays—*King Lear*, *Macbeth*, *The Tempest*.

The short novel tracks Falesea Osovae, "the seventy-six-year-old titled head of the Aiga [family or "tribe"] Falesea" (1), who wakes up one morning and decides to renounce his long and (by the mores of his people) illustrious life as father and clan leader:

He despised everything he had been, had become, had achieved: his forty years as a deacon and lay preacher; his almost unlimited power in the matai [leaders'] council; his large profitable cacao plantation; his title as the highest-ranking matai in Malaelua; his nationally respected reputation as an orator; his detailed knowledge of genealogies and history, which was envied by other matai; his utter loyalty and devotion to his village and aiga and church; his unquestioned reputation as a just, honourable, courageous, and humble man of unimpeachable integrity . . . (1)

Falesea decides to escape this life of quiet desperation by feigning madness and demonic possession, to test his large family's loyalties and beliefs.

Wendt shows the intricate family-village structure through Falesea's eyes, and through his remembrances traces the modern history of Samoa. Falesea rejects his wife, Felefele, and oldest son, Elefane, who covet his power and authority. Falesea confers his favor on his youngest son, Moaula, who is loyal, stalwart, strong, courageous but not very bright or politically astute. Like *King Lear*, Falesea wants to relinquish his power and authority—to shed the shackles of rectitude and responsibility—but to retain his control and dignity and his family's unconditional love. Also, like mad *King Lear*, Falesea lays about him with vitriolic accusations and revelations of the hypocrisy, scheming, and corruption of his family and friends.

The novel reveals the conflicts between indigenous and European cultures in Samoa, as embodied in Falesea. He is a lifelong missionary Christian, but he wonders about the old, lost beliefs:

His one regret was that he had never bothered to learn anything about the ancient religion of his people because the missionaries and his church had made him feel ashamed (and afraid) of it. . . . [H]e now realised that his whole existence as a Christian had meant nothing deeper than the necessity of being a Christian because it was expected of a good leader. He had clung to Christianity too in order to help dispel his fears of the meaninglessness of life: Christianity gave a meaning to the void; but, he now reasoned, it was only one pattern of meaning; there were many others. (35–36)

Falesea has been shaped by both *faa*-Samoan (“true Samoan”) beliefs and palagi (European; NZ: pakeha) beliefs, embodied in a mysterious old man who appeared in his village during his childhood. This ancient, nameless magus Falesea calls “Lazarus,” his palagi-Christian avatar. (He is rumored to have been raised by English missionaries and to speak German.) He recites Biblical passages by rote, but he also enacts parable-like rituals that define the village in traditional mythic terms. Falesea’s instinctive response to “Lazarus” is to help him and admire him, even though he frightens and repels the others in Malaelua.

Falesea is also challenged by his Samoan background. He recalls a myth that is an analogue of the West’s Prometheus story, about the culture-hero Pili, who brings the gifts of technological civilization from the gods to Samoa—“a live ember, a fishing net, and a war club” (97)—with the aid of three magic helpers, “Tausamitele—Insatiable Appetite, Lelemalosi—Strong Flight, and Pouliuli—Darkness.” (95)

The myth helps Falesea find meaning in his life, though it is finally a recognition of darkness—Pouliuli—for whom the story is named, the darkness of blind fate, tragic failure, and death. Pili’s final helper is Falesea’s last recognition, as his scheming comes to a catastrophic end.

He has driven out his wife and eldest son and plans to ruin his

nephew Malaga, whom he has sponsored as a legislator, to make a place for his favored son, Moaula. But he miscalculates, and his humiliated nephew resorts to homicidal violence. In the melee, Moaula kills two of his kinsmen: "For the two killings, Moaula was sentenced to life imprisonment. Malaga's aiga was banished by the council." (143) Falesea's wife and eldest son take power in the family, and all his schemes are ruined. An old friend watches Falesea sleep and understands that he has become "Lazarus," the old mad wizard and quoter of Ecclesiastes of his childhood, in his ultimate tragic ruin:

It's all reality, isn't it? You wanted to be free in the last years of your life but that too was vanity. Look at you now, my friend. Just gristle and suffering and weeping sores. We lost out a long time ago, my beloved friend. The new world is for creatures like Malaga and Elefune; they're everywhere because of the times. . . . Sleep on, my most precious friend, safe in the embrace of Pouliuli, the Great Darkness out of which we came and to which we must all return. (145)

Falesea's story is a broad vision of Polynesian life, parallel with the stories of Witi Ihimaera, Patricia Grace, and other Maori writers. Wendt was educated in New Zealand and has spent much of his adult life there, and he illumines the similarities between Samoan and Maori cultures and worldviews.

Pouliuli is a tragedy of an individual and of a culture. Falesea and his antecedent Lazarus represent the effect of English, German, and other palagi influences on the traditional culture. They feel the pressure of family-kinship ties, the fabric of a society built on families and houses, and also are pulled by modern Western notions of individualism, personal freedom, Christian ideals, a consumer society, and technological modernization.

As a young man in 1921, Falesea first meets a palagi, an evangelizer from the London Missionary Society, and visits the town of Apia, which is as enchanting as the Emerald City of Oz to him and his friend Lemigao:

As they approached the jetty they sighed in amazed disbelief. Such large boats and ships and so many buildings!

And what a size the buildings were—so high and massive and all made of iron and stone and wood and glass! . . . They were also eager—and their hearts were by then thudding violently against their ribs—to go into one of those stores they had heard so many unbelievable stories about. Falealou—treasure houses, one Malealuan had called them, where you could buy every kind of food and machine and implement you could ever need or want. (47)

The modern urban paradise of material plentitude, however, fails to satisfy Falesea, leaves him with the desperate void or vacuum of the spirit that prompts his final, fatal renunciation and excursion into *realpolitik*.

Only Pouliuli, the old friend of comforting Darkness, is left from the old culture, the last marginal Promethean gift, to enfold Falesea in death. When he sees his beloved son Moaula killing his kinsmen, Falesea falls to the earth, thinking, “he knew he would not be forgiven. Not ever.” (143) There is no forgiveness in his London Missionary Society conscience, none from his family, who now possess the power they sought, none from the lost traditional culture, the deep mythic world of Pili.

Albert Wendt’s multiple perspective—Maori/New Zealand as well as Samoan/Pacific—illumines the themes and viewpoints of world literature in the twentieth century. His vision of Falesea is of a modern man embedded in the modern world, even as that world is conditioned and shaped by the long past of Samoan culture. It is finally a tragic vision, because Falesea and his family are doomed to live out the ambiguities and perplexities of modern life in a place that most Westerners imagine as a remote, sinless, unspoiled paradise, a “world elsewhere” untouched by the wounds and neuroses of civilization.

Once Were Warriors: The Tragedy of Impotence

Alan Duff’s *Once Were Warriors* (1990) is one of the best-known and most controversial novels by a Maori author, the controversy and notoriety focused as much on Lee Tamahori’s brilliant and disturbing 1994 film version as on Duff’s original text. Duff, a journalist and

Maori activist, generates dissension with all of his writing, and this story of Jake “the Muss” [muscle] Heke and his luckless family is a powerful naturalistic inside view of the urban Maori in the 1980s. Critics have attacked it as a caricature or as brutalist cartooning in the vein of Hubert Selby’s raw ghetto epic, *Last Exit to Brooklyn* (1964), but Duff generates relentless energy in the vivid pictures and uncensored stream-of-consciousness narration of his characters—Jake; his assertive but damaged wife, Beth; and their children, Nig, Boogie, and Grace. The story is recited in a forceful modern vernacular that defines the bottom-dog worldview of Beth, Grace, and Jake.

The Heke family is caught in the economic, moral, and social vacuum of Maori displaced from the land and from traditional work and culture, left as powerless clients of the welfare state, unemployed and unemployable in contemporary Auckland. Jake builds his body, drinks with the other rootless men, and broods, accumulating a charge of aggressive energy to be released in violence. Duff’s title refers to the old vision of the Maori as a proud warrior culture, but Jake is the pathetic modern remnant of warriorship, the semicriminal small-time drinker and barroom brawler, whose battles are trivial, graceless, and meaningless.

Beth Heke is caught between the rich pakeha world she can never reach and the lost Maori order of her past:

Bastard, she’d think, looking out her back kitchen window. Lucky white bastard, at the glimpse of two-storey house through its surround of big old trees and its oh so secure greater surround of rolling green pastureland. . . . Good luck to you, white man, for being born into your sweet world, and bad luck to you, Beth Heke (who used to be a Ransfield but not that life was so much better then), for being married to an arsehole. And yet I love him. Just can’t help myself, I love the black, fist-happy bastard. (7)

Beth’s world is one of innumerable “bastards” better off than she is, including her husband, whom she characterizes in racist terms (he is descended from a lost or damaged *iwi*, from slaves once owned by such Maori aristocrats as Beth’s family).

When early-adolescent Grace views the family home, this is what she sees:

Sitting room a mess. Broken glass, smashed beer bottles, wood splinters of beer crates, the overpowering stench of beer. And fags. Settee tipped over on its back, the armchair one more fight older with more blood splatters, beer stains; a circle of beer crates on their ends where they must've sat around in a circle continued drinking or saying their sorries and thrusting put-it-here hands at each other. (29)

This is the sad hedonism of the poor and displaced, creating the universal squalor of the underclass. Grace has a dignified name, and it echoes her self-contained awareness. Her brothers are branded, one called Boogie, "given that name because he was scared of the Boogie Ghost as a kid" (30), the elder called Nig because he is dark, a "nigger Maori," stuck with a blatantly racist handle. The family is scarred with this self-contempt and hopelessness. Grace thinks of her family and their friends in the Maori ghetto as "The Lost Tribe" (30–31), and "lostness" is a defining term and tone for the story—they are all profoundly lost souls.

The story rolls along a horrifying course of casual beatings, drunkenness, and despair, climaxing in the rape of Grace during one of the ubiquitous drunken parties. The film version assigns the rape to one of Grace's "uncles," but the novel leaves the event shrouded in mystery and ambiguity, so that it is possible that Jake Heke was the unseen rapist:

. . . the man breathing his rotten fumes all over her, his whiskers harsh on her face, going: mmmmm, as he kissed her. And she lying there with lips shut tight but not daring to twist away, or even indicate she was awake. And that smell stronger. And kind of knowing what it was . . . that it was somehow self-familiar, something sexual, an off-giving, except this sensed as somehow corrupted. By him. This man. Raping her. She wanted to vomit. (91)

Grace is so tormented by the event that she hangs herself. Beth believes Jake may have been the rapist, and even Jake, drunk and stupefied, begins to doubt his innocence: "All the time wondering: Did I touch her? But immediately the denial: *I can't have*. Because a man would know, wouldn't he? In his heart of hearts he'd know." (176)

Once Were Warriors derives power from the combination of blunt, direct statement and the uncertainty and confusion of its narrators, unable to understand their own motives and actions. Beth returns to the traditional beliefs and culture of her family, taking her youngest son Boogie with her, but Jake is left to lie in the gutters of the city, and Nig is assimilated into the vicious gang culture of the Maori ghetto. The family has fractured down the middle, one side drifting into the anarchic chaos of the modern city, the other moving slowly backward in time toward the values and practices of the ancestors.

The novel ends with Nig's funeral, after his death in a gang battle, with Beth standing by her Maori kinfolk and Jake hiding in the cemetery shrubbery, where he lives as a derelict with a street boy he has befriended, watching the ceremony: "this fulla [fellow] with this equally bedraggled boy, over in the pines, concealed, peeping out like thieves, or shamed children of slaves. And tears trickling from him—Him. He who they used to say was toughest in all Two Lakes. Bad. Mean as. Jake Heke. Now just a child weeping for another child." (198)

Tamahori's film version clarifies ambiguities, lets Jake off the hook for possible incest-rape, and ends with Jake sitting on the ground after battering the villainous "uncle," waiting for the police. It jibes more with the usual formulae of cinematic poetic justice than Duff's novel, in which Jake returns to a form of slavery—slavery to his impotence, guilt, and shame—much like the previous slavery to his fists and his temper that has enchained him all his life.

At one point Beth imagines she has the world for an audience to her ideas, and she summons up the Maori past:

And we used to war all the time, us Maoris. Against each other. True. It's true, honest to God, audience. Hated each other. Tribe against tribe. Savages. We were savages. But warriors, eh. It's very important to remember that. Warriors. Because, you see, it was what we lost when you, the white audience, defeated us. Conquered us. Took our land, our *mana*, left us with nothing. But the warrior thing got handed down, see. (47)

The modern city has no room for the warrior ethic or for *mana* itself. The Heke family is adrift on tides of social and political

change it cannot comprehend. Jake, the invincible warrior, has turned into a pitiful wino who sleeps in the underbrush and weeps for himself.

The Bone People: The Tragedy of Abandonment

Probably the most widely praised and widely read recent New Zealand novel is Keri Hulme's *The Bone People* (1984), recipient of Britain's prestigious Booker Prize, the U.S. Pegasus Prize, and the New Zealand Book Award. It is a big, virtuosic postmodern epic on the travail of the family and the individual from a Maori perspective. The story is told in a broad, macronic style that synthesizes Maori terms and cultural expressions, the language of international modernism, terms from New Zealand popular culture, and demotic, highly poetic, and idiosyncratic language. The style is dense, the basic story relatively simple.

The story revolves around three characters—Kerewin Holmes (a postmodern avatar of the author), Joe Gillayley, a working-class Maori, and his adoptive son, Simon Peter, a strange autistic child found washed up on a beach in mysterious circumstances. The author's double, Kerewin, is an artistic woman living a hermetic existence in an odd tower by the sea, trying to resolve contradictions in her person and character: she is part Maori but uncertain what this means. She describes herself to Joe:

Kerewin, blue-eyed, brown-haired, and mushroom pale, looked back at him. "If I was in America, I'd be an octoroon." Paused. "It's very strange, but whereas by blood, flesh and inheritance, I am but an eighth Maori, by heart, spirit, and inclination, I feel all Maori. Or," she looked down into the drink, "I used to. Now it feels like the best part of me has got lost in the way I live." (61–62)

She is wakened and challenged when Simon Peter appears one day at her home. The boy is an ambiguous figure, long-haired and mute, like some mythic, amphibious creature ejected from the ocean. Kerewin tries to communicate with him and understand him. At first she is repelled by his odd appearance:

Small and thin, with an extraordinary face, highboned and hollowcheeked, cleft and pointed chin, and a sharp sharp nose. Nothing else is visible under an obscuration of silverblond hair except the mouth, and it's set in an uncommonly stubborn line.

Nasty. Gnomish, thinks Kerewin. (16)

In trying to find where he has come from, Kerewin meets Joe, who has adopted the orphan and struggles also to reach him. Kerewin and Joe become lovers, forming a strange adoptive-surrogate family, three misfits struggling to create a community of love and knowledge.

Later, Kerewin sees the boy as a mystical creature, a mirror reflecting some of the mystery of her own existence and the quest for her meaning:

Simon the shadowed. Oddbod, spiderchild. A very unlikely but strangely likable brat. Me new toy is to discover whence Simon the Gillayley came from. Why there is a suggestion of the numinous in his shadow. Who else do I know who listens to the silences of God on lonely beaches? (Ah hah! That would be telling . . .) (96)

Simon Peter is like a profound question facing Kerewin, and she is in love with his mystery, even though he is violent and destructive (the "nasty-gnomish" side of his character, like demons possessing him), when his frustrations erupt into blind rages.

The boy has also drawn her into Joe's world, remote from Kerewin's self-imposed exile and artistic inclinations. He is a complex man, once drawn to the church as a seminarian and then to academia as a student in teachers' training college. He has fallen back into the working-class world of the uneducated Maori: "I tasted both vocations enough to know they weren't for me.' He laughs bitterly. 'I'm a typical hori ["George," racist and pejorative] after all, made to work on the chain, or be a factory hand, not try for high places.'" (229-230) The relationship of these three characters is immiscible. Conflicts and strains develop, until Simon Peter goes on a psychotic rampage, shattering shop windows and injuring himself. Joe's response is to beat the boy back into the broken condition in which he first discovered him.

Arrested and imprisoned, Joe becomes a "broken man," an experience that sends him onto a road toward enlightenment. He meets a *kaumatua* (elder, wise man) who tutors him in the traditional insights of the Maori. This old man regards Joe as his prophesied replacement to be the guardian of a Maori shrine, the location of a sacred *waka*:

"I was prepared, and aue! There isn't time to prepare you. I think it best to say it bluntly. I guard a stone that was brought on one of the great canoes. I guard the canoe itself. I guard the little god that came with the canoe." (363)

So Joe is brought to a paradoxical redemption, finding his way back into a form of religious training, now in the traditional religion of his people. After the *kaumatua* has explained the potency of the site, Joe cannot understand why its holiness has not restored the old Maori world:

"If it is the heart of Aotearoa . . . why isn't this whole place . . . flowering? Something as strong as that, would make the very stones flower, ne? And there is nothing at all . . . no birds . . . flies, you say, but . . . flies?" (370)

The *kaumatua* does not challenge the question but expresses his own doubts about his mission:

"Maybe we have gone too far down other paths for the old alliance to be reformed, and this will remain a land where the spirit has withdrawn. Where the spirit is still with the land, but no longer active. No longer loving the land." He laughs harshly. "I can't imagine it loving the mess the Pakeha have made, can you?" (371)

So Joe's new faith is still ambiguous, not absolute and certain. He struggles to learn from the *kaumatua* and reverently buries him when he dies.

The endings of Simon Peter's and Kerewin's stories are also unsettled. At one point she has defined herself only in terms of Joe and her art: "These are the only things in my life that are real to me now.

Not people. Joe. Not relationships. Not families. Paintings. That remind me I could.'" (264) Kerewin survives a struggle with what might be cancer, curing herself with old remedies and months of solitary exile in the mountains. At the end she thinks of Joe and Simon:

God, I hope he hasn't been warped too badly by jail, and the jail of memories. . . . And the goblin brat, oddbod spider-child indeed, the catalytic urchin who touched this off? Cataleptic then, bald as an egg on the palm of God, with shookup brain and terrible blank eyes where once the sly self-awareness flickered; where once the strange self-awareness showed; where once the lovelight shone. All gone. Unseeing, the sunchild. Too deep in the dark to know anymore. If he hasn't come back to himself, he's dead to me. Dead to us. (427)

They have all been badly damaged but have survived, perhaps stronger, as Hemingway suspected, from the breaking. The ending is cautiously optimistic, tentatively enlightened, as if only a provisional and partial healing is possible from the scattered remnants of Maori culture, old knowledge leaking slowly from the past into the turbulent chaos of the modern world.

Potiki: The Tragedy of Displacement

Patricia Grace has emerged over the past two decades as the leading female Maori writer, with three collections of short stories and three novels to her credit and several children's books. In *Potiki* (1986), her second novel, she developed a view of Maori history and culture both specific to the present and accountable to the past, our world of everyday reality and the timeless continuum of myth.

The story opens simply from the point of view of a Maori wife and mother:

My name is Roimata Kararaina and I'm married to Hemi Tamihana. We have four children, James, Tangimoana, Manu and Tokowaru-i-te-Marama. We live by the sea, which hems and stitches the

scalloped edges of the land. This piece of land is the family land of the Tamihanas. (15)

The story revolves around Roimata, her adoptive son Toko (who is a strange Jesus-figure, born of a Mary-and-Joseph couple, and parallel to Keri Hulme's mystical idiot-saint Simon Peter) and the family land, which is sought by developers anxious to exploit it for all the purposes of modern "progress." One buyer, Mr. Dolman, derisively called "Dollarman," makes a pitch to the Maori:

"So that's what it is, development, opportunity . . . first class accommodation, top restaurants, night club, recreation centre with its own golf links—eventually covered parking facilities . . ." (88)

But the Tamihana family associates their land with their houses, built by expert wood carvers and next to the family burying ground:

There was our own land with our own carved house built by the people long before, and carved by a man who had given life and breath. This house of his, of ours, carried forward the stories of the people of long ago, but told about our lives today as well. . . . [B]ehind the house is where the dead are buried. These were the places wanted by the money men, that they would pay thousands of dollars to have. (99)

To compensate for his adoptive status and his physical disabilities, the boy Toko is following the family tradition of carving. He eventually dies in a fire, trying to rebuild the meetinghouse that has been destroyed.

In *Potiki*, Grace sees Maori culture through the imagery of the land and the decorated buildings. She also sees it as an endless cycle of stories, with individuals' lives like chapters in the total text of continuing family and community existence. Roimata tells her children stories—genealogical, historical, mythical—to weave them into the present story of her people. When she decides to school her children at home, Roimata understands this function:

So I didn't become the teacher, or rather didn't become once more the teacher I had trained to be. There was no need for a room to be changed because a boy [Toko] had become five and could not find himself in schools. I became instead a teller of stories, a listener to stories, a writer and a reader of stories, an enactor, a collector and a maker of stories. (38)

Her role is parallel to Toko's, as he becomes a wood carver who will depict these stories in the elaborate beams and posts of the homes and meetinghouses he builds.

Roimata discovers that the stories span all time and space and shape or carve the children to whom she tells them: "these stories were, after all, about our own lives, were not distant . . . there was no past or future . . . all time is a now-time, centred in the being." (39) The children learn of wars, ancient and modern, which make them aware that they must fight for their existence, for the continuity of their family and community. They learn of the modern world wars and also of the Maori warrior tradition:

In yet other war games we fortified our villages and fought with clubs and taiaha [spearlike fighting sticks] in battles which mirrored, not the battles shot into our lives from other countries, but the running, leaping, dancing battles which came to our lives in our own stories from a different age. (44–45)

These stories prepare them for militant confrontations with the greedy developers and speculators who threaten their land.

The threat creates a sense of solidarity among the Maori, a renewed interest in family, the old language, the values of the past. Paradoxically, the threat of modernization invokes the past:

We were busy with our gardens and our nets, and busy learning all that could be learned about the land and the sea. We were busy telling and retelling the stories and histories of a people and a place, and learning or relearning a language which was our own, so that we could truly call it our own again. (107)

Roimata's family participates in a roadblock that prevents the developers' heavy machinery from bulldozing their homes and burying ground.

But the interference with nature—the cuts made by the big machines, the stripped hillsides—causes disaster when the rains come. The cemetery erodes and crumbles into the sea. Then the meeting-house burns mysteriously, taking with it the carved genealogies of the community. Again, the catastrophe unites the family and the community, who rebuild and relearn the traditions of building. Toko—the disabled adoptive child, who is the *potiki* (which means both “the youngest son” and an avatar of the demigod Maui [5]) of the title becomes a leader, learning to carve the ancient magic figures. But he too dies in a fire and becomes in his death the tutelary spirit of the community and its travail.

Toko was born on the beach, as if part of the sea itself, and dies by fire, so he is united by these two powerful elements. When a carver comes to complete his work, Toko is commemorated with a figure that clutches a fish and is ringed by fire:

Below the heart the *pito* [navel] became a plaited cord,
and the plaited cord became a penis-child sleeping between
the narrowed thighs. At each side there were the spinning,
patterned wheels [of Toko's wheelchair].

Each small leg was hobbled with knotted seaweed
strands and the feet were licked with fire. (172)

So the boy becomes a figure of myth in death, transcending the immediate present of his family and uniting the past and the future of his people. He has become part of the wood, itself from a tree (the heritage of Toko's people), so their houses are made from sacred elements, the trees now carved with figures of the gods that inhabit and animate the land.

Potiki ends with a strong feeling of triumph and continuity. The desecration of the land by the forces of modern materialism is forestalled by the rediscovery of values and feelings of the past among Roimata's family and friends. They have weathered tragedies of fire and water and the loss of the youngest son in a sacrifice that reani-

mates both the land and the people. What on the human scale is bereavement and loss is, under the aspect of eternity, growth and renewal, the temporal rejoining the everlasting.



These four novels by indigenous writers form a cyclorama of varied perspectives by contemporary Maori and Pacific Island observers. Their observations contrast with and complement pakeha sensibilities. The powerful presence of the mythic world and the re-discovery of ancient patterns of feeling and belief are central to all these stories, investing them with powerful meanings, often in sharp contrast to the estrangement, anomie, or absurdity shaping much modern literature. The foundation of family, kin, community, and the sinews of tradition strengthen the language of all four writers and give their stories urgency and relevance transcending the particularities of their fictions. Their writing seems both timely and timeless, reminding us of the continuity of basic human values and of the way that “modern civilization” has alienated us all from our families and our selves.

4

Once Were Crusaders

The Nature of Crusading

The long human settlement of Aotearoa over the past twelve hundred years has been marked by multifarious violence. Conflicts between people and the environment and between groups of people have shaped the culture in unique, subtle ways.

The Maori-pakeha experience through the nineteenth century was fundamentally different from the U.S. immigrant majority's experience with Amerindians, African slaves, and non-European immigrants. The Maori had developed a fairly stable, homogenous culture, including a complex military tradition in which men of an *iwi* served as a standing militia, expected to defend the *iwi* and its region against attack. They also developed a symbiosis with the incoming pakeha, basically a trade and economic system that ceded land or tenancy of land for European manufactured goods.

The interdependency of the two cultures was long lasting: Maori in many regions of the North Island outnumbered and dominated pakeha incomers until the end of the New Zealand wars, in the 1870s. The relationship was something like the "protectorate" system of early Japanese-European relations, from the seventeenth century until Commodore Perry arrived with his force of black ships in 1853. That is, Maori groups "sponsored" pakeha traders, settlers, and bureaucrats, and pakeha lived by sufferance among the Maori on "reservations" set aside for them. The majority-minority model of society developed tentatively and differently in New Zealand from the Americas, where white Europeans appeared as conquistadors and immediately became dominant, first in cultural energies and then in demographic fact.

In North America after 1620, as steady settlement replaced tenta-

tive exploration and outposts, a Crusader culture (like that already notorious in Latin America, the subject of the “Black Legend” of the conquistadors’ cruelties) rejected models of interdependency or cooperative coexistence for something like “ethnic cleansing.” The Crusader model of conquest, developed since the First Crusade (late eleventh century) was (1) to go heavily armed with an array of metal hand-to-hand weapons, body armor, shock-combat cavalry (all a form of “professionalized” feudal military); (2) to travel as an economically autonomous unit (i.e., to carry money and promote a gold-silver money economy as the standard of trade, as against work or barter economies); (3) to besiege and extirpate any large forces of resistance and to seize and dominate any significant settlements; (4) to impose Western (Latin) Christianity in a doctrinally focused form (i.e., as a “true faith”) to be adopted exclusively by the conquered—although some local syncretism or adaptation might covertly be encouraged; (5) to own or occupy all lands and territories invaded in an imperial fashion, so that an advancing army was also a force of exploration, survey, and de facto occupation. Columbus’ crew and all the following Conquistador groups wore the body armor and carried the banners of the armies that expelled the Moors and Jews from Spain in the years immediately before the voyage of 1492—the voyage that was an extension by sea of the last European Crusade. (Armstrong 340–341)

Crusader warfare was *to the death*, for purposes of annihilation, to guarantee undisturbed possession of territory or use of resources. Warfare in many other cultures has been traditionally of a ritual nature to fulfill religious, social, or mythical needs. The North American Plains Indian who “counted coup” (simply approached and touched an enemy in battle) or the Maori warrior who danced and taunted rather than assaulted the enemy or the Aztec fighter who tried to capture rather than kill an opponent all followed “rules of engagement” radically different from the maim-or-kill objectives of European combat from the Middle Ages onward.

The heavily armed and armored Crusader was a technologically advanced killing machine, and battlefields became killing fields. In New World societies, warfare was often about bravado and honor (“counting coup” or the Maori concept of *mana* [personal honor or charisma]), the arena in which individuals displayed daring and courage, corresponding to William James’ wisdom about a society’s

sport being sublimated warfare ("games are the moral equivalent of war"). Battles were about intimidation and capture, with humiliation or slavery or both the consequence for losers. Territorial expansion might not be relevant to this warfare, whereas Crusader warfare was unswervingly imperial in objective.

Maori warfare was in large part about bravado. It was also (confusingly to early witnesses) a form of siege warfare that recalled Crusader tactics. The use of hill forts (the *pa*) recalled European models of war, and thus Maori tribal wars observed by pakeha seemed like the basic territorial warfare of the Old World. However, Maori warfare was based on warrior roles and warriorship in small agricultural societies; Crusader warfare, in contrast, was the first model of "total war"—war waged by trained and professionalized soldiers on a whole society (men, women, and children), not a clash between select bands of armed warriors on a designated battlefield away from the everyday world. The Maori model was more like the yeoman-militiaman idea of Concord and Lexington, Massachusetts, than like the Siege of Ascalon.

Crusader campaigns routinely included "scorched earth" advances—massacre of civilians and total destruction of population centers. The Maori use of a *pa* as a stockaded war base and the games of ritual confrontations and ceremonial challenges (the *haka* or "war dance"), sallies, sieges, attacks, and counterattacks were inherently different from the Crusader aims of religious conquest (the choice of conversion from "heresy" or execution, or the infamous end-game ultimatum of the Albigensian Crusade, "Kill them all and let God sort them out"), territorial acquisition, and material wealth. The Maori model was one of tribal motives and interfamilial wars or vendettas, limited in scope and duration. The Crusader killing machine just kept on coming until it accomplished complete annihilation or "unconditional surrender."

Technology and Crusader Warfare

The merchant-explorer Captain James Cook was an advance man for the massive corporation that the British Empire had become by the late eighteenth century—as much "Britannia Ltd." as today's vision of

"Japan Inc." The merchant sailors who followed Cook established a trade-partnership relation quite compatible with traditional Maori culture. Maori were eager to "acquire" pakeha as intermediaries, to benefit from trade, to take a technological step from a culture based on stone, wood, and fabric to a sophisticated culture of complex metallurgy. The whalers and sealers operating along the shores were also entrepreneurs, and their work was quite explicable to the Maori. There was no early "land rush"—the land seemed relatively valueless in comparison to its raw resources. The Maori developed a trade relationship underpinned by military-strategic superiority over the Europeans. The pakeha had neither the resources nor the motives to stage a Crusader invasion of this remote place. This situation created a fragile alliance or coalition of Maori and pakeha, with neither side precisely understanding the worldview or social rules of the other.

The pakeha brought flintlock muskets (latest stage in Crusader military technology), which intensified the small-scale foray or vendetta culture of Maori militarism. The internecine "musket wars" of the early nineteenth century ravaged some Maori groups and reconstructed traditional balances of power and regional authorities. The Maori-pakeha "New Zealand Wars" of the 1840s–1870s were not so much one-sided conquistador processes of invasion and extermination as balanced strategic struggles between near-equals (like the later episodes in Palestine, when Islamic armies fully adapted themselves to draconian Crusader rules of engagement).

Another way to consider the Crusader model is as a powerful cultural-ideological vehicle for disseminating a cluster of high-impact, heavy-duty technologies, the proto-totalitarian sociopolitical organization that cultural historian Lewis Mumford called the "Megamachine"—the means for rapid, brutally imposed technology transfer. Many technologies were military, but many were also those of transportation and information. The oceangoing vessel on which Abel Tasman or Captain Cook arrived was the result of complex technical-scientific development of the past 250 years, including all processes for building bigger, more stable, more maneuverable, faster ships, many developments in navigation and mapping (most gained in the Crusader contact with Islamic science), increased understanding of shipboard hygiene and nutrition, development of commercial cartels to underwrite and finance shipbuilding and sailing (therefore the banking,

postal, and news-gathering systems of Europe in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries).

The cultural impact of these technologies on Maori village society is hard to imagine or reconstruct. Anne Salmond describes one Maori response to Cook's sailors that created a strange dissonance. HMS *Endeavour* carried a longboat that must have seemed similar in size and shape to the basic Maori *waka*. The British, as much as the Maori, were a skilled maritime culture, living on home islands not much different in size and climate from New Zealand. However, British ship-building techniques produced broad-beamed longboats with shiplap or clinker hulls, rigidly crossbraced, compared to the narrow, one-piece dugout construction of the Maori *waka*. Longboats were propelled by long oars held in swiveling oarlocks, result of a complex technological development. Each crew member sat on a bench or thwart and pulled one oar. Maori knelt in their canoes and stroked overhand with short paddles. Maori faced front as they paddled, British sailors (strangely!) faced the rear and were synchronized, instructed, and steered by a boatswain. When the Maori watched British sailors rowing in from the *Endeavour*, their response was, "'Yes, it is so: these people are goblins; their eyes are at the back of their heads; they pull on shore with their backs to the land to which they are going.'" (87) The Maori perception of the pakeha intruders followed Arthur C. Clarke's famous dictum that "any sufficiently advanced technology, viewed by a less advanced culture, is indistinguishable from magic." The fundamental spooky alienness of the pale invaders was as much communicated by their ways of living, their tools, and their methods, as by their language or dress.

The whole exploration enterprise—the effort to find the fabled land variously called Southern Continent or Beach or Antipodes—was designed to confirm a worldview of mixed medieval-renaissance assumptions, drawn from Aristotle and Ptolemy as much as from Galileo, Descartes, and Newton. One means to confirm or deny the paradigms in conflict was the circumnavigational voyage, comparable to the feverish competition of the U.S.-U.S.S.R. space race in the 1950s and 1960s. The "conversion ideology" of the basic Crusader model was originally religious but quickly became broadly cultural, so that by the eighteenth century the "missionary impulse" was not just conversion to Christianity but conversion to capitalism, industrialism,

urbanism—all the values often seen in the figure of Robinson Crusoe as the period's "economic man." All the tools and processes on board Crusoe's wrecked ship, which allow him to replicate his British life and "conquer" the wildness of the island, are those also on board HMS *Endeavour*.

Technology's role in the Crusader invasion was crucial. The very complex mechanism or system of the *Endeavour* was based on radical recent developments in timekeeping and navigation, on honed ship-building skills, on the technology of food preservation and dietetics (how to keep the crew alive and healthy over months at sea). Cook's mandate was part of an ongoing Enlightenment scientific project combining mapping and astronomy (observations of the transit of Venus, eclipses) with the search for exploitable resources for Western technology and manufacture.

HMS *Endeavour* had to be a wholly self-sufficient and self-contained unit of up-to-date British-European culture, it had to carry all goods and tools necessary for very long travel, so that everything on board could be repaired or renewed easily, so that the lives of the crew could be protected and maintained, so that the accumulated knowledge (in artifacts, records, and memories) could be returned to Britain intact. Cook was judicious and used his firearms mainly to intimidate—he usually fired muskets and cannon over the heads of the Maori he felt threatening or used small shot to wound rather than kill them. This is not necessarily a gesture of humanity so much as an understanding of the power at his disposal and the immense psychological effect of the mere appearance of his ship, weapons, and tools. In Maori terms, Cook was displaying *mana* (powers of self-confidence) and pride (leadership or chieftainly prowess, courage, and steadfastness). The Maori exhibited these qualities through the *haka* (the "posture dance" or "war dance," which combined song, epic tale, mime, military maneuver, and formal ballet), through other rituals, and through daring military forays or sorties. Like medieval knights in tournament, the Maori were less interested in melee tactics and more in single combat—the duel or challenge. The pakeha displayed their collective prowess rather than individual bravery—by discharging thunderous cannon or volleys of musketry, the awesome physical power of their technology, something of a premonitory "cold war" idea, deterrence rather than direct attack.

Concepts of Holy War

The Crusades were launched from Europe at the Middle East as a form of “holy war”—the diversion of Latin western Europe’s feudal military machine from local wars to a war against the Other, the foreign heretics of Islam who possessed the Holy Land. The religious motivation was a powerful one, and it lingered in European concepts of warfare, developing into the idea of the “just war” sanctioned because it fulfills religious mandates or advances the cause of Christianity. The term “crusade” became generic for any noble or justified campaign, for the aggressive imposition of ideology (so Dwight Eisenhower could title a history of World War II *Crusade for Europe*, to define the struggle of capitalist democracy against fascism and totalitarianism). Although the term became secularized, it retained a resonance or connotation of an underlying religious motive. Ultimately, the impulse of the Crusade invoked the response from Islam of the jihad, so one form of “holy war” begets its opposite. In New Zealand, Titokowaru and Te Kooti were religious leaders who led “holy wars” against the invading pakeha in the 1860s.

The settlement of New Zealand in the 1840s and 1850s derived from two powerful antagonistic impulses—the secular utopianism, fueled by rationalistic beliefs in human and social perfectibility, of the New Zealand Company and the religious and humanitarian roles of the missionaries who began arriving in 1814. Anglican lay ministers under the sponsorship of the Church Missionary Society were first, followed by Wesleyans and Catholics in the 1820s and 1830s. The “cultural imperialism” of evangelical missionary work was as powerful as the shock of trade and technology. While the New Zealand Company struggled to set up a pakeha state within the land, the missionaries, traders, and workers interacted directly with the Maori and changed the forms of their society and their beliefs.

Spiritual life and values were central to Maori culture. The Maori immediately responded to many aspects of Christianity as inculcated by the missionaries, especially to the emotionalism of evangelical preaching and singing and to a series of motifs in the religion: to messianic and millenarian ideas, to the idea of the Lost Tribes of Israel (often advanced by missionaries as a conversion strategy), to ideas of sacrifice and pacifism. Repeatedly, syncretist cults that adapted Chris-

tianity to Maori needs sprang up among the Maori, beginning as early as 1833, with

a new religion, *Papahurhia* (one who relates wonders). It rejected the European God yet contained Christian elements including heaven—an abundant and amorous paradise . . . a strong note of millenarianism [and] . . . Hebraic elements, including the appointment of Saturday as the Sabbath. (Sinclair 45)

This was echoed a generation later in the so-called Hau-hau movement, begun in 1862

by Te-Ua, who called it Pai-marire, meaning “good and merciful.” *Rongo-pai-marire* means “the good news of peace”—proclaimed by the prophet, who stressed the peace-loving and internationalist character and purpose of the movement. (Lanternari 248)

The movement led to the Taranaki war of 1864 and then to a new version of the cult: “The new movement initiated by Te-Kooti was a Christian version of the Hau-hau. It was called Ringa-tu, which means ‘raised hands,’ from the traditional religious custom of the Maori, who always raise their hands in prayer.” (Lanternari 256) When Te-Kooti was unjustly imprisoned, the religious movement took a new turn:

In prison Te-Kooti studied the Bible, read it aloud to his fellow prisoners who were Hau-hau followers, and eventually conceived a new religious movement based on ideas taken from the Scriptures. It was also during their imprisonment that the Hau-hau followers first identified themselves with the Jews of the Captivity and New Zealand with Zion. (Lanternari 257)

When he escaped, Te-Kooti waged another war that lasted until 1872. Ringatu, the religion he shaped, continued after his death in 1893.

So a path of resistance to pakeha domination was through wars

of religion in nineteenth-century Aotearoa. The crusading mentality of the Europeans was met with another version of the church militant. There was also a Maori secular response, in the form of the King Movement of the 1850s, in which the *iwi* of the central Waikato region united to create a quasi-European government of king and council. Even this, given the old idea of the "divine right of kings," was of some religious value. The foundation of the New Zealand wars was a collision between cultures but also a collision of beliefs, a way to find a heaven-sent solution to the oppression of the pakeha invaders:

The messianic movements of Polynesia have many mythical elements in common with cults flourishing in Melanesia, such as the end of the world and its regeneration, and the resurrection of the dead, as well as the major objective, common to all messianic movements among primitive peoples, which is independence from foreign rule. (Lanternari 259)

The stage was set for the wars that erupted in the years after 1840, when movement after movement developed among the Maori to protect Aotearoa from the indiscriminate settlement and domination by the ever-increasing streams of pakeha immigrants. These conflicts were once variously called the "Land Wars" or the "Maori Wars" but may best be known as they are described by James Belich, their premier contemporary historian, as the "New Zealand Wars."

Maurice Shadbolt's Versions of War

Maurice Shadbolt is one of the most proficient, prolific, and widely known New Zealand writers. His novels and short stories have, since the mid-1950s, depicted the life of New Zealand in the contemporary world and back through its history. Beginning as a naturalistic writer of short fiction in the well-defined path of Frank Sargeson, Shadbolt explored every fictional mode as he moved from short stories to fully developed novels. He has published carefully detailed realistic tales (*The New Zealanders*, *Summer Fires*, and *Winter Country*), emblematic stories of unusual episodes in New Zealand cultural history (*This Summer's Dolphin*, *An Ear of the Dragon*, *Danger Zone*), metafictional

caprices on New Zealand family history (*Among the Cinders, The Lovelock Version*), and a historical epic in the form of "proletarian fiction" (*Strangers and Journeys*). Increasingly, his work has included a rich vein of satiric observation, a means of social criticism via high and low comedy. His work has been published in *The New Yorker* and other international outlets, and his novels have sold well abroad, as well as being consistent best-sellers in New Zealand. In many ways, Shadbolt is today a presiding figure in the literature of his country.

A capstone of his fiction is an ambitious trilogy on the New Zealand Wars: *Season of the Jew* (1986), *Monday's Warriors* (1990), and *The House of Strife* (1993). With these three large novels, Shadbolt has synthesized and focused many themes and concerns of his earlier writing. The three stories cover the wars from 1845 to 1869, describing the backgrounds and campaigns of the fighting but also developing the backgrounds of the stories—the people, pakeha and Maori, involved and the social, political, and geographical settings of these strange wars on the misty periphery of the nineteenth-century world.

Shadbolt's trilogy forms an interesting contrapuntal trajectory: first, it moves backward in time and sideways in space, beginning (*Season of the Jew*) with the most recent campaign, that of prophet-general Te Kooti at the Bay of Plenty in 1868–1869, then moving westward (*Monday's Warriors*) to the struggle by another charismatic leader, Titokowaru, in Taranaki, also in 1868–1869. It then moves backward (*The House of Strife*) to 1845 and the ancestral conflict, the resistance campaign of Hone Heke and Kawiti at the Bay of Islands, the center of administration for the new British colonial government. The facts of all these small-scale but violent and bloody wars make for drama rich in intermingled tragic and farcical circumstances—the killing and maiming of soldiers, warriors, and civilians, pakeha and Maori, incidents of courage and chivalry, of comic-opera bluster and blundering, of cannibalism and massacre. The stories recall the Balkan wars of Shaw's *Arms and the Man*, a source of endless provincial slapstick and a sad running gloss on the utter meaninglessness of war in the modern world.

The other trajectory stitched on Shadbolt's epic tapestry of the wars is a steady increase in the comic, literary, and metafictional devices and content. As the trilogy unfolds, Shadbolt's confidence with materials and methods of the ambitious project becomes surer

and surer. Over the four decades of his writing, Shadbolt created an unmistakable, idiosyncratic style that, in the trilogy, finds its logical flowering and culmination. The Shadbolt style is a flexible combination of highly rhythmic, often comically elaborated description and laconic dialogue in a compressed stichomythia, like a supple synthesis of Faulkner and Hemingway. In energetic passages, Shadbolt creates an Anglo-Saxon style of ancient pedigree, a rhythmic alliterative prose like that of such early Renaissance satiric pamphleteers as Gabriel Harvey or Thomas Nashe, as in these passages from *The Lovelock Version* and *Monday's Warriors*:

Panic passes, and two or three days. Great gorges grow around him. Realms of forest unravel. He begins to accept the rhythm of the river. Birds tinkle and twang in the overhanging trees as wide waters give way to narrower. Startled shags soar from the riverside reeds. Ducks depart in storms of shining spray. (*Lovelock Version* 122)

The storming party, taking shot from two sides, bunched and bobbed, shedding men as lightly as leaves; the young captain floated free to join those prone. Survivors spun back upon others unscathed. Some tried to bash their way back to safety with butt and boot. (*Monday's Warriors* 212)

Using this mannered prose sparingly and strategically, Shadbolt creates a heroic diction that recalls *The Iliad* or *The Aeneid* but also suggests a comic tension, almost a Hudibrastic energy in his descriptions.

The dialogue, presented in brief, staccato bursts like controlled volleys of musketry, is also both herocially masculine and slightly absurd, the stiff-upper-lip clipped style of the adventure-tale British officer that Hemingway picked up and parodied in *In Our Time*. In *Season of the Jew*, for example, an inept and indecisive major asks observer George Fairweather for tactical advice:

"He wants more than capitulation," Biggs said. "He wants humiliation."

"Which should not surprise."

"What would you have me do, Mr Fairweather?"

"Prepare to repel attack, Major Biggs."

"It has not been a creditable day," Biggs said. "On my own initiative, without instruction from government, I have led good men into what might yet prove a massacre. And made matters worse by miserably failing to lead."

"It is a remarkably fair summary," Fairweather agreed. (131)

And in *The House of Strife*, Hone Heke lectures storyteller Ferdinand Wildblood on the value of stories:

"What are we, if not our stories?"

I had to think.

"Have you found yours?"

"Perhaps in those of others," I suggested.

"A man must have his own," he argued. "Otherwise he walks the world a shadow."

"You are in conversation with yourself," I judged.

"I," he agreed pleasantly, "am still looking for mine. Or my story for me."

"I shall watch with interest," I promised. (55)

Interestingly, Shadbolt most often uses the abrupt stichomythiac dialogue (the Elizabethans called the rhythm "snip-snap") in love scenes or tender passages between his pakeha and Maori lovers, where it both defuses sentimentality and suggests the exotic in Maori speech or a pidgin that is also a special language of courtship, as in the love-making of Meri Smith and George Fairweather:

"I find boldness most fetching," he said. "All lovers wish to be wanted."

"When is a lover not?"

"When seducing an Englishwoman. It is often her custom to pretend innocence of the proceedings; to fancy the under-taking as spiritual."

"You are telling me tales."

"On my honour. Though I recall a colonel's wife. A less frivolous woman. Her hands had an uncanny

life of their own when virile young officers were in her vicinity."

"You," she said. "You are a terrible man."

"When sufficiently encouraged."

"I am just as that colonel's wife to you."

"Never," he said. (*Season of the Jew* 29)

With this terse dialogue suffusing the trilogy, the style is consistent and compelling, without falling into (or even approaching) the ham-fisted absurdity of the mock-Spanish-peasant dialogue in Hemingway's *For Whom the Bell Tolls*, now virtually unreadable.

The trilogy of pakeha-Maori warfare and love (for the opposite side of the ferocious battle scenes are the tender moments between each central figure and his Maori lover) owes something to Thomas Berger's Great Plains-warfare burlesque epic, *Little Big Man*, and to the triad of jaunty, heroic stories of the twentieth-century provincial Chinese wars by Shadbolt's old friend, Stephen Becker (*The Chinese Bandit*, *The Last Mandarin*, *The Blue-Eyed Shan*). Like these two American writers, Shadbolt debunks the mystique of war and warriors without losing sympathy for their desperate situations, like them he has perfect pitch for the language of soldiers and battles, and also like them he mixes the language of the old soldier's cynicism with the spectator's romantic awe at the genuine heroism and self-sacrifice that occur randomly in armed conflict. The stories all follow "Maori-pakeha," men who become unwitting allies and confidants of Maori and who ultimately come to love them and to adopt their viewpoints and lives.

Season of the Jew follows the adventures of George Fairweather, "who might have been many things, but was most singly a soldier" (11), the most military of Shadbolt's protagonists (although he is also a talented artist and therefore a precise observer-describer). The story offers a series of perspectives that balance Fairweather's limited view:

In *Season of the Jew*, a third-person narrative, Shadbolt offers the reader at least three viewpoints from which to view events: the nineteenth-century colonial viewpoint . . . the nineteenth-century Maori viewpoint . . . and the liberal Pakeha viewpoint of the present.

It is through his mediocre hero George Fairweather that Shadbolt introduces these three apparently exclusive viewpoints. (Crane 103)

Fairweather thus gives us a powerful synthesis of views, as befits what Shadbolt in his afterword to the novel calls a "composite character."

In *Monday's Warriors*, we follow Shadbolt's fictional version of an actual historical character, Kimball (sometimes misspelled "Kimble") Bent, an American down-east picaro and quondam soldier of fortune, who provides a cosmopolitan insight, the estranged view of the wanderer, outcast, deserter, and petty criminal. When he tries to resign his status in the 57th Regiment of Foot ("refund the Queen's shilling" [2]), Bent reveals his basic rebel's viewpoint (which will stand him in good stead when he deserts and joins the Maori forces of Titokowaru):

"You think a discharge might be timely?" The colonel was curt.

"Yes, sir," Kimball said with hope.

"Over my dead body," Colonel Hazzard announced.

There was silence of a shaky sort.

"Then, sir," Kimball ventured, "there's one thing I will say for the likes of me. Americans, sir."

"And what would that be, Bent?"

"That it's not a hundred years since us rabble whipped the likes of you good, sir."

That failed to win a kindly smile.

"So long as I have command of this regiment," the colonel said, "let there be no further fancies of a discharge. You hear?"

"I heard, sir. Over your dead body." (3)

When the colonel is killed in a foolish skirmish, Bent takes him at his word and considers himself well and truly discharged, the shilling refunded. The colonel's phrase operates like a curse or a conjuration in a fairy tale.

The viewpoint of *The House of Strife* shifts to a more conventional first-person narrative, which allows Shadbolt to unleash all the pyrotechnics of modern metafictional prestidigitation. It is the story, recited

from the vantage of forty years' hindsight, of Ferdinand Wildblood, a British poet manqué who sails to New Zealand to gather accurate local color for a series of grotesquely melodramatic penny dreadfuls he has begun to write under the invertedly colorless nom de plume of Henry Youngman. Wildblood/Youngman form a Wildian or Stevensonian "composite character" like the doppelganger-ridden eponyms of *The Picture of Dorian Gray* or *Doctor Jekyll and Mister Hyde*. To complicate the story, Wildblood is pursued by a nemesis, James Dinwiddie, who claims to be the true author of the ripsnorting New Zealand potboilers.

This complex idea allows Shadbolt full rein for parodic inventions and narratives-within-narratives, history replicating fiction or life imitating art. Wildblood longs to be a genteel, romantic poet, but he is driven by need to rewrite (as "Henry Youngman") a hack's blood-and-thunder manuscript called "Monarch of Maoriland," whose popular success stimulates Wildblood/Youngman to write *Sirens of a Savage Shore*, *Murder Most Maori*, *The Vengeance of the Tattooed Trojans*, and *Death by a Thousand Muskets*, all without leaving London, by dint of research at the British Museum and copious imagination. The idea of Wildblood's overblown writing allows Shadbolt to satirize Britain's hyper-romantic and fabulous view of New Zealand, the idea of a "native" literature written by hacks ten thousand miles away and the general naivete and bumptiousness of the early novel. His invention of Wildblood recalls John Barth's virtuoso recreation of the Laureate of Maryland, Ebenezer Cooke, in his exuberant *The Sot-weed Factor*, another wildly comic ripping yarn self-reflexively encoded in a Fieldingesque novel and Hudibrastic epic. *The House of Strife* is sprinkled with outrageous Peacockian or Wodehousian names and ideas, the most unbuttoned comedy of the trilogy, echoing Henry Fielding's basic definition of the novel as a "comic epic in prose," firmly rooted in mock-heroic ironies.

In each of the novels, the viewpoint characters are careful observers of the strange new world of New Zealand. In also recording portraits of the other heroic protagonists, they give Shadbolt room to express his insights into and sympathies with the warriors. In *Season of the Jew*, George Fairweather recalls his first impression of Te Kooti, when he was known by his pakeha name of Coates, before the onset of war: "I saw a man who turned the Queen's peace to profit. Not

one who would have patience with the pagan and cannibal nonsense of your recent insurgents here. All else aside, the man was uncommonly committed to Christ, never at a loss for words when he had scriptures to quote.'" (75) Later, Fairweather observes Te Kooti in his role as prophet and charismatic chieftain: "An improbable figure materialised among the Maoris at the forest edge. Coates? Kooti? Or Moses on Sinai; Joshua commanding the sun to stand still. The apparition stood luminous in a long white robe trimmed with red, hands clasped high as if in prayer, grave, tidily bearded, his hair a cascade of ringlets." (125)

In *Monday's Warriors*, we similarly see Titokowaru first in a pakeha guise, as recorded by Kimball Bent:

... an English gentleman. The Holy Ghost could not have made a more magical approach. A small and leathery Maori of middle years, he wore a bowler hat and dark suit and black shoes with high polish; a gold watch-chain was looped between the fob pockets of a burgundy waistcoat ... [he] had no warrior tattoo and didn't need one to make an impression; he had been left hideous by a firearm at short range, his right eye shot from its socket. (40)

Titokowaru is contrasted through the action with one of the most outré and flamboyant of the pakeha soldiers, Austrian mercenary Gustav von Tempsky, artist, soldier of fortune, and leader of militia, whom Titokowaru's troops finally kill. One of Titokowaru's lieutenants describes him: "'Major Many Birds. He flits here, he flits there. He fights as an angry flock of birds. His true name is von Tempsky. Those hired to kill for the colonists call him the Prussian.'" (75) So Shadbolt inverts the stereotypes and our character expectations, with his Maori chieftain an untattooed "English gentleman" who believes that "clothes maketh the man" (45) and his pakeha opponent a bizarre, gaudily uniformed and quasi-magical charismatic leader called "Many Birds."

The novel also includes sharply contrasting death scenes for Titokowaru and von Tempsky. The Battle of the Beak is a Maori victory, and in a scene recalling the conventional description of Custer and Sitting Bull after the Little Big Horn, we see its gruesome aftermath:

Carcasses were stripped and heaped. On command order, however, Many Birds was left uniformed and apart. Titiko considered his victim at length, and in silence. Still staring, the Prussian seemed to have shrunk, and still to be shriveling. There was a drying tomahawk gash in his temple; otherwise his face was undamaged. Breeze blew through his ringlets. Titiko knelt finally to close the man's eyes. Then he tipped his hat in salute, took up Many Birds' sword, and drew back. Only Toa risked a question. "What ails you, cousin?" he asked. "Can't you believe him dead?"

"I miss him already," Titiko said. (188)

In the afterword to the novel, Shadbolt paints a picture of Titokowaru's own death:

A little more than two years after his last fight, on 18 August 1888, he was dead. Tradition says that his last gesture was to call for Major Many Birds' sword to be brought from hiding. He broke his old enemy's weapon—how or with what tradition does not say—and ordered it buried. "Let war be returned to the great nations of the earth," he urged. It was. The trenches of World War I were just a heartbeat of history ahead. (304)

Hone [John] Heke in *The House of Strife* is introduced as classically heroic and larger than life through Ferdinand Wildblood's romantic sensibility:

The first time I saw John Heke he was no disappointment. Heralded by hoofbeats and baying dogs, he rose shadowy out of New Zealand forest on a misty midwinter morning. As he took potent shape he might well have been mistaken for the young Alexander among hounds, horses and kinsmen in the mountains of Macedonia. Heke's beast was a picturesque piebald. A silver-plated musket sat across his saddle. (1)

Although the military actions are often brutal or farcical (Heke's resistance to the new colonial government at first consisted of repeatedly chopping down the flagstaff at Bay of Islands from which the Union Jack flew), he is consistently depicted as a real, live exemplar of the pulp-fiction heroes Wildblood has engendered in his imagination.

Shadbolt also treats the sheer strangeness of the New Zealand wars as a prime theme, the bush settings, the exotic Otherness of the Maori to pakeha eyes and the reversal of viewpoint that shows how deranged and disoriented the pakeha themselves were by the antipodean remove. Writing in 1886 to recreate the New Zealand of his first encounter, Ferdinand Wildblood in *The House of Strife* gives an example of this alien quality to the experiences:

Man had a problem in New Zealand. Save for birdsong the land was stirringly soundless. The first humans saw its untamed terrain as rubble left by feuding gods. Man had to fill it with his own din to feel at home. Nothing served better than battle. Firearms lifted the sound of mortal tumult even more satisfyingly. In the time of which I write the place was home to one hundred thousand tribesmen, with thousands of white colonists beginning to wade ashore. Nevertheless there was still a square mile of silence for every man, woman and child in the land. (93)

In a kind of cultural reverse-angle shot, we have in *Season of the Jew* George Fairweather explaining his painting and the latest European word on esthetics to his Maori wife:

"A good day?" she asked.

"Illuminating. I painted. Even Mr Ruskin might be pleased."

"Who is Mr Ruskin?"

"A tohunga, wise man, a priest of my tribe. A man of much mana. We have thus never met."

"How would he be pleased?"

"To know that his distant pupil took his words to heart. And had this day seen clouds moving in the harmonies he prescribes."

"So you painted clouds," she said. "That is all."

"All? Mr Ruskin has it that I am gazing at the visible face of God. He writes much of what he calls fleecy citizens of the sky. He sees them as free of earthly passions. Mr Ruskin is a most reverent man."

"Which you are not." (77)

And in *Monday's Warriors* we have something as "ordinary" as a Maori fortified village or *pa*:

A Maori village rose across the end of a wooded valley. It sat across a long and bald plateau lifting three hundred perpendicular feet above winding green river. In places the flanks of the plateau were eroded down to rock, with just fern, plumed grass and a few cabbage palms finding soil to take root. There was clearing and cultivation below the plateau, and a steep bridle-path wound into the defence works on the summit. There were stockades made of large tree-trunks reinforced with cross-rails and lashed with native vines. There were also moats and ditches to slow attackers. The entrance to the stronghold was a low gate. (31)

It is a scene that is simultaneously exotic and familiar—like a European fort but also like something from "jungle," from tales like *She* or *Heart of Darkness*.

Through his innocent observers, Shadbolt records the exotica of Maori life, including the action songs and *haka* for which the culture was known from the beginning of European contact:

With small balls of flax spinning from their wrists
[the women] swayed, chanted and sang to ensure
the twelve chosen [warriors] were of one heart. To
confirm their potency the men answered with a crash-
ing of feet, a slapping of limbs, and hoarse voices chanting
in unison. . . . With weapons high, knees bent back, they
leapt from land with tongues protruding. (*Monday's
Warriors* 141)

In a more comic view, the *haka* is seen as an awkward impromptu ballet reaching a rude conclusion:

Heke's lone chant was taken up by two hundred throats, followed by a thumping of feet and a flourishing of weapons. This exercise did not speak of moderation. I recognised it as a militant rite, designed as a preface to disembowelment, which sent European voyagers tacking away in terror for decades after New Zealand's discovery. Even to my unseasoned eye, however, something was missing. For one thing the choreography was of the sketchiest. For another the dancers could have done with more painstaking rehearsal. . . . The rousing rush to bare their buttocks, the time-honoured tactic for terrifying opponents, was no cheap spectacle. (*House of Strife* 64)

The tragicomic collision of cultures is more than military—it includes all the rituals and formulas of their lives.

Another bizarre episode of war comes in descriptions of the British attempt to introduce state-of-the-art weaponry, Congreve rockets (also depicted at comic length in Geoff Murphy's film *Utu*). The rockets promise to make up for lack of troops and tactical advantage but they merely provide a farcical and bathetic interlude:

[After the first rocket misfired] This time the rocket lifted with a lively bang which promised much. It too, however, proved coy. Once it had risen it began circling the fortress and then, with something of a sigh, soared away to the west. The third was even less robust of character. It farted unpromisingly before hitting an invisible wall and falling back among fleeing marines. . . . Maori cheering mounted as rocket after rocket was launched. Only the seventh could be counted a modest success. With the best of intentions it clipped a palisade, unleashed sparks, and lurched lukewarmly into the interior of the fortress. There was a frantic barking, then silence. Soon afterwards the defenders were holding up a canine carcass to encourage the besiegers below. "Britons are good to kill dogs," they taunted. (*House of Strife* 170)

In the world turned upside down, the ferocious becomes feeble, the tragic turns comic.

However, Shadbolt's view is often darkly saturnine or sardonic comedy, fully acknowledging the blackness of war and human folly. In *Season of the Jew*, he comments on the bloodthirsty history of Israel in the Old Testament, whose militant ethic matches the Maori's traditional value of *utu*—justice, equity, revenge:

Fairweather took up his Bible. He seemed to have drained all the red juice from the Book of Joshua; he dabbled as displeasingly elsewhere, and especially in Deuteronomy. Where Jehovah was not smiting, his chosen people were, and to effect. Canaanites upon the land promised had not just to be slain, like the Midianites, the Amalekites, and the deluged Egyptians before them; they had to be persuasively so under the sky of the Jew. (264)

When Fairweather returns to his Maori home at the end of Te Kooti's war, he sees the dreadful results of this eye-for-an-eye warfare in simple human terms:

The despoiled rooms echoed with his slow footfall. Broken windows had allowed storm to savage the building still more; shreds of curtain shifted in faint breeze. He stopped to pick up a trodden chessman from the floor, a whisper of an unfinished contest with Pita; a playing card insisted on an unpaid poker debt to Matiu. Stench persisted too. (394)

The tokens of innocent domestic games have been scattered in the lethal contest of war. The young Maori men with their New Testament names (Peter and Matthew) have been destroyed by the total war of Te Kooti's rampaging Lost Tribesmen.

The New Zealand wars all end in ruin, as wars always do. They have been a long, violent delaying action, the repeated "last stands" of the Maori against the inexorable influx of pakeha settlers. Although the Maori had learned quickly and adapted ruthlessly to the conditions of life imposed on them by the Europeans, the forty years of conflict through the middle of the nineteenth century were of no lasting avail:

The Maori system of war in 1845 remained essentially indigenous: it was intended purely to cope with local enemies of roughly equal resources. As such, it was markedly inferior to the British system at both the quantitative and qualitative levels. Under good leaders, the Maoris could still secure isolated successes, but even in the short term they appeared to be hopelessly outmatched. (Belich 25)

After a generation's struggle by the "good leaders" Shadbolt chronicles in his trilogy, the struggle proved unequal, the pakeha advance impossible to stem.

The elderly George Fairweather, as he writes his history of Titokowaru's war, looks backward with a profound tinge of melancholy, like the "tears-of-things" nostalgia for the ruined heroic past that pervades *The Aeneid*:

New Zealand is no longer a land lost in Oceania's mists. The new species of steamer on the route means a voyage of no more than four or five weeks. My former and much mourned acquaintance Anthony Trollope, a visitor to the colony before his demise, informed me that all the conveniences of civilisation welcome the traveller in that once unruly corner of Victoria's realm. . . . The Britannic lion has not roared there in vain. "All good things have been given to this happy land," he wrote. "When the Maori has melted, there will be the navel of the earth." (*House of Strife* 41)

And by the 1880s, it seemed to many that the Maori would "melt," that they like the Amerindians were a "vanishing breed," once admirable in a Noble Savage way but now doomed to rapid extinction in the Darwinian march of improvement and civilization, the implacable flow of social evolution.

Maurice Shadbolt's overview of the New Zealand wars in his trilogy moved from a basically tragic initial viewpoint to a much more complex ironic perspective. As Lawrence Jones says in an essay on Shadbolt, "*The House of Strife*, then, completes a historical trilogy not so much by revising the history as by relativising and ironising it, presenting it as competing stories, a completion one would not have

anticipated from *Season of the Jew*, but a satisfying one." (Jones 32) We move from tragic to mock-heroic ironies, a longer and more humane view of the flawed and fallible actors over the thousand pages of the epic. We end with a sense of the inextricable nobility and folly of war, the way mortal conflict calls out the best and worst of humanity. The lesson gives depth to New Zealand's nineteenth-century history, weight to the dilemmas that still face Maori and pakeha at the end of the twentieth century, the past of Crusaders and warriors that is still a burden in our present of laser-guided missiles and mass death by chemical, biological, and nuclear warfare.

5

The Bildungsroman at the End of the World

Frank Sargeson (1903–1982) is usually acknowledged as the key pathfinder of modern New Zealand fiction-writers, a pioneer who brought the language and attitudes of everyday New Zealanders fully into serious stories and novels. Sargeson described his slow self-apprenticeship in the mid-1920s, when he taught himself the art of writing by reading and imitating James Joyce—especially the intense confessional fiction of *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man* and the incisive social miniatures of *Dubliners*. Working alone and naively in a provincial culture with no incentives for his development as an artist, Sargeson defined a style and sense of structure that coalesced into short stories in the 1930s.

In these very terse, condensed stories, Sargeson worked in parallel with other pioneers of literary modernism—Ernest Hemingway and Sherwood Anderson. Beginning his own laborious self-apprenticeship, Hemingway took the principles and methods of newspaper journalism he learned on the Kansas City *Star* and the Paris edition of the New York *Herald-Tribune* and created powerful, ironic vignettes, which he collected into a little book first called *in our time* (1923). He added even more laconic “chapters” and some slightly longer stories to create a more unified text, *In Our Time* (1925). Hemingway experimented with very condensed tales that omitted all details except those leading to a single, taut emotional climax. The stories depicted Europe and America through the experiences of Nick Adams, who journeyed from innocence to experience through the devastation of World War I. The arc of the book’s meaning followed Adams from childhood in Michigan to the war, to postwar Europe, and back to Michigan. Sherwood Anderson had been an early mentor and model for Heming-

way. Anderson had walked out of a lucrative living as an advertising copywriter, had compulsively written of his own midwestern background and found a colloquial style as effective as Mark Twain's language for Huckleberry Finn. Anderson's stories were also terse, understated, and psychologically probing. The set of intertwined stories in *Winesburg, Ohio*, like Joyce's *Dubliners*, defines a place by its specific people, by small studies of the pressures and prices of a constrained, middle-class culture. Sargeson learned from Anderson a sensitivity and subtlety toward nuances of character and behavior, attention to the deviant or repressed feelings of people who were imprisoned in cultures of strict conformity.

Sargeson struggled to absorb and imitate the modernist methods and language of Joyce, Anderson, and Hemingway until he created the ultra-compressed stories that appeared in his first collection, *Conversation with My Uncle* (1936). These stories depicted New Zealanders in their most ordinary contexts, speaking their vernacular. Like Hemingway's and Joyce's short stories, they achieved their effects by omitting much background detail and focusing on sharply defined dramatic situations and compelling narrative voices. They took for granted the facts of everyday reality in New Zealand and spoke directly to the reader in the reader's language, especially the language of workers and farmers.

Like much modernist literature, Sargeson's stories were simultaneously international and provincial in focus—bringing a little slice of the great world into clear, detailed examination, as Joyce immaculately reproduced the city of Dublin in his stories and novels directed at a cosmopolitan audience. The systole-diastole movement between universality and particularity pushed Sargeson's New Zealand literature beyond a simplistic colonial attitude toward effective self-examination. He was trying to answer basic questions: "Who are modern New Zealanders? What makes them like or different from other peoples in the twentieth-century world?" Most of his stories depicted men at work, frontier farming, relationships between men, the hard economic realities of the 1930s in New Zealand. They define a strand of masculine—often ultra-macho—storytelling, a Boy's Own/Good Old Boy strain of robust, outdoorsy literature in direct opposition to the genteel tradition of earlier writing, often by women, often

epitomized for many inside and outside New Zealand by Katherine Mansfield's quiet, sensitive, and restrained short stories of controlled, middle-class life.

Another important model for modern New Zealand writers was John Mulgan, whose only novel, *Man Alone* (1939), was modeled explicitly on Hemingway (its title, supplied by the publisher, is from *To Have and Have Not*) for style and content. The terse, understated "tough guy" prose and attitudes of the story tapped into basic New Zealand attitudes toward men and manliness, the idea of "mateship" in farming and male loyalties and values matching many of Frank Sargeson's concerns and resonating with basic macho attitudes of New Zealand's frontier-image culture.

One basic literary format suggested by Sargeson's and Mulgan's work is the classic Bildungsroman in its primal form as "education of a young man." The novel of education, rooted in the eighteenth-century literature of middle-class aspiration and development (as in Goethe's *The Sorrows of Young Werther*, Fielding's *Tom Jones*, Sterne's *A Sentimental Journey*), was a tool for defining, analyzing, and criticizing social values and attitudes toward the growth patterns of boyhood and manhood. While parallel fictions about female growth and education immediately sprouted (beginning with Samuel Richardson's novels—*Pamela*, *Clarissa*—and ranging through Jane Austen's novels), the classic formula was a tale of the birth, childhood, and maturing of a man who somehow represented his culture.

From the beginning, the Bildungsroman represented a "problem story" pattern, describing the difficulties of growing up safely, the frustrations and anxieties of youth, the failure of elders to understand or communicate with their children, the pitfalls of the world before youth. The stories were often picaresque (as in Fielding or Sterne), with growing up represented as a journey—a quest or pilgrimage—from innocence to experience. In one avatar, this story is tragic (*The Sorrows of Young Werther* or *Clarissa*, both culminating in suicides induced by the culture's failure to support and defend the young protagonists, to bring them properly into a successful and constructive life as defined by and approved of by that culture). In another avatar, prevalent in American fiction from the 1880s through the 1920s, the failed or rebellious adolescent is comic, an entertaining rogue or rascal, the child-as-picaro (Thomas Bailey Aldrich's *The Story of a Bad Boy*,

Owen Johnson's Lawrenceville or Dink Stover stories, Twain's Tom Sawyer stories, Booth Tarkington's Penrod stories). Popular literature picked up this formula, probably (as George Orwell first observed in his essay "Boys' Weeklies") from *Stalky and Co.*, Rudyard Kipling's tale of boys' school life, and created the whole genre of "Boy's Own" adventure books, serial adventure tales of the Hardy Boys/Nancy Drew type (Enid Blyton's many series in Britain), leading to movie serial films and comic books of the 1930s.

By the time Sargeson and Mulgan and others began shaping modern New Zealand literature, both the comic and tragic Bildungsroman could be used and fused. The 1950s U.S. Bildungsroman was a "rebel without a cause" or "growing up absurd" pattern, represented in New Zealand by Ian Cross' best-selling *The God Boy* (1957). Cross' story is a naturalistic, straightforward novel of a boy from a disintegrating small-town North Island home. As his family's fortunes and structure crumble in the years after World War II, the protagonist's psyche crumbles in a directly parallel fashion—the unraveling of the basic social unit (the family), Cross emphasizes, inevitably causes the destruction of the individual's mind and spirit. Cross' story is analogous to J. D. Salinger's Glass Family tales (*Frannie and Zooey*; *Raise High the Roofbeam, Carpenters*; *Seymour: An Introduction*, and several short stories) and especially *The Catcher in the Rye*, which chart psycho-spiritual crises and malaises suffered by sensitive adolescents (mostly male).

Cross' "god boy" grows up in rural New Zealand, suffering some social and cultural poverty, the blankness of isolated small-town life; descends into anomie, crime, and violence; and is institutionalized (parts of the story eerily parallel Janet Frame's own story and the fictions and autobiography she made from her bouts with psychiatric detention and treatment [*To the Is-Land*, *An Angel at My Table*, and *The Envoy from Mirror City*]). The novel ends on a note of ambiguous optimism; there may be short-term redemption in society's remedies for the failed education, but it is unclear what final salvation is foreseeable.

Another basic Bildungsroman, overlaid with Kiwi gothic, is David Ballantyne's *Sydney Bridge Upside Down* (1968), a novel tracing the disturbed adolescence of a boy from a crumbling family in a seaside village. The boy's mother has abandoned his ineffectual father for a lover and and a bright life in the city, leaving her two sons. Harry, the

older boy, grows up desperately seeking affection and understanding. The narrative encompasses a summer when Caroline, his older cousin, arrives for a holiday, and he begins to understand love and sexuality. The milieu is the open seaside, the village, a derelict freezing works (a haunted backdrop appearing in many New Zealand stories, a surrogate for the obligatory ruined castle of eighteenth-century gothic fiction). A series of violent episodes—several deaths amounting to murders—parallel the boy's introduction to the turbulence of sexual drives, leading to madness and dissolution.

The story is narrated by Harry, who analyzes his own progressive disintegration. At the end, he summarizes his story parodically as an explicit form of conventional literary gothic:

Do you know, I say, that there was a castle near where I lived? There are no castles in this country, he says. Do you know, I say, that I once saved a beautiful short-sighted girl from being captured by a hairy monster? You must have read too many fairy-tales, he says. Do you know, I say, that I slew the hairy monster and a skinny witch? No doubt, he says. Do you know, I say, that I was once the strongest hero, inch for inch and pound for pound, in the world? Of course, he says. Do you know, I say, that I used to run along halls and up and down staircases with this beautiful girl and that neither of us wore clothes and she used to lie on a big satin-covered bed and let me look at her breasts and pussy and say what a nice big cock I had and let me lie with her and let me cry on her breasts and if I'd been a few years older would have let me marry her and would probably have waited for me to grow a bit if an older hero hadn't turned up in a Daimler one day and taken her to the castle and fucked her right left and centre while I looked on? (219)

Harry's simultaneous fantasy and analysis is the clearest picture of the Bildungsroman pattern underlying such gothic mysteries.

The basic Bildungsroman pattern is of stunted or thwarted growth—a consensus that growing up healthily in modern New Zealand has become difficult. Characters are threatened with psychic and spiritual destruction by social forces of repression and control: puritanism,

conformism, self-restraint or self-loathing, a basic lack of family or community support, trust, or love. In emblematic fashion, many fictions depict broken families in which one parent has absconded or died or parents are physically damaged or incomplete. The number of maimed or crippled fathers (especially) is notable. Writers point repeatedly to a sense of damage or loss in the society, which recurs as a feeling of isolation, emptiness, abandonment, or dislocation. This is a keynote of descriptions of pakeha culture especially, and Maori characters are often posed as contrasts, as the Other that embodies values lost to the pakeha: a network of valuable traditions, close family (even tribal) and community beliefs and feelings, an intact system of spiritual values, a sense of belonging in nature, a sense of self and place. One feeling seems to be that if pakeha cannot be Maori then they cannot grow up intact in Aotearoa.

In Ronald Hugh Morrieson's eccentric comic-gothic novels, growing up is very hard to do: adolescents are threatened by deranged adults who are ghouls and necrophiles (*The Scarecrow*) or by an individualistic, capitalist society that positively encourages criminality and hedonistic irresponsibility (*Came a Hot Friday*, *Predicament*), usually in Morrieson emblemized by the macho pursuits of hard drinking and gambling, compounded by reckless driving and timid sexual encounters. The manic Morrieson world is one of stunted adolescence—charged with toxic levels of testosterone, hectic and highly colorful but ultimately destructive and defeating. His young protagonists escape death only through the good luck embedded in high comedy and the comic-book-like resolutions of the stories, the basic cheerful poetic justice of popular culture genres.

Morrieson's novels are reminiscent of Preston Sturges' dark film comedies of the 1940s (*The Lady Eve*, *The Miracle of Morgan's Creek*, *Hail the Conquering Hero*) in which young, saintly innocents are flung into the maelstrom of American society and escape only through ironic "educations" that run sharply against the grain of the official culture: Joel McCrea in *Sullivan's Travels* (1941) plays a naive idealist who has made a Hollywood fortune directing mindless slapstick comedies (such as *Ants in Your Plants* of 1939). He goes on the road (the American Pilgrimage of Grace) in the depth of the Depression, gathering material for a serious film study to be called *O, Brother, Where Art Thou?* In his travels he is robbed, mugged, and finally wrongfully

sentenced to a chain gang as a vagabond. Sturges' dark parody of the pious sociopolitical tract *I Am a Prisoner on a Chain Gang* shows McCrea's character the value of comedy, its redemptive and healing virtues. The film is a complex, self-reflexive metacomedie that comments on the blindness and crassness of Hollywood while crafting a superb Hollywood product.

In Sturges' *Hail the Conquering Hero* (1944), Eddie Bracken (a favorite Sturges stooge, fuddled, feckless, and incompetent) plays a young man, son of a Marine hero of World War I, who is classified 4F in World War II. He feels helpless, isolated, and emasculated, stranded in a one-horse midwestern town. Through bizarre comic coincidences, he is adopted by a squad of tough Marines home on leave and represented as an authentic war hero. The film, remarkably made at the height of the "war effort" and hyper-patriotic feelings, comments incisively on the phoniness of propaganda and the difficulty of growing up sane in a world gone homicidally mad. Again, Sturges uses metacinematic devices throughout, creating a film that parodies and undercuts cinema techniques and conventions to question the whole concept of heroism, the war and the homefront and other very difficult ideas for his audience. Although Sturges was widely admired for his virtuoso scripts and film techniques, his movies left viewers uneasy and ambivalent about the values he attacked and defended. Even so serious and careful a film critic as James Agee could never quite decide if Sturges was a black nihilist or a useful social critic.

Morrieson works with the same materials as Sturges—the Depression, the inherent self-limiting poverty of provincial smalltown life, the stifling restrictions of provincial beliefs and mores, the sense of claustrophobia and exile common to adolescents in out-of-the-way places. His small towns are dead ends, and his novels are New Zealand versions of the "revolt from the village" pattern of U.S. fiction around 1920, exemplified by Sinclair Lewis' wars with the Babbitts and Boosters—*Main Street* (1919) and *Babbitt* (1925). Like Lewis, Morrieson had an original and cutting comic vision and the ability to invent type characters that embodied the essential vices of his society yet were more complex than flat allegorical tropes. "Babbitt" and "Babbitttry" passed immediately into the language as terms for middle-class conformism and hypocrisy. Likewise the milieus defined by Lewis were accepted as accurate (if satirical) depictions of the devel-

oping U.S. midwestern culture—Gopher Prairie, the archetypal “Main Street town,” and Zenith, the new prairie city. In this and the next chapter, I describe the range and effect of Morrieson’s fiction as a remarkable and unique New Zealand literary achievement.

Morrieson’s milieu is always the small-town life of Taranaki, the deep farming country of the southwestern North Island where he grew up and lived his entire life. His characters are unremarkable denizens of a small town like Hawera, Morrieson’s home, and the viewpoint is always that of a character caught in the sticky web of people and place and yearning to grow up and leave home. A technical problem Morrieson worked to solve was that of point of view, and in his first novel, *The Scarecrow*, his solution was to split the narrative vision between a central character as a young man participating in the action and as a middle-aged man reviewing and relating the tale through the scrim of memory. In a carefully controlled feat of tight-rope walking, Morrieson communicates the basic Bildungsroman pattern from this split-screen perspective, so we feel both the innocence of youth and the painful experience of memory—a doubly emotional process, since the young boy suffers anxiety, terror, and uncertainty, while his older self feels the unquenchable pains of loss. This is the basic definition of the Bildungsroman:

how a boy or a young man comes through both comic and horrifying experiences to prove himself stronger than what others might impose upon him.

Each of [Morrieson’s] three finished novels in fact fits one of the oldest forms of story-telling: how a youth survives tests and temptations to prove himself worthy of adult status. (O’Sullivan 100)

The Scarecrow is a serio-comic horror tale, and the double narration fulfills one convention of gothic (multiple narrators and multiple story-times, as in *Wuthering Heights*), but it also functions as a Bildungsroman in the same fashion, so that all the horrific elements of the action contribute to the creation of the narrator’s adult persona. In this story, to grow up is to be “scared stiff”—to pass from mindless Wordsworthian childhood to panicky adulthood in a ceremony of terror.

Morrison introduces his narrator and a complex terror tale in memorable fashion. The first line of the novel is the best-known opening of any New Zealand novel, the Kiwi version of "Call me Ishmael": "The same week our fowls were stolen, Daphne Moran had her throat cut." (1) This oxymoronic nonsequitur combines the mundane and the horrific in a way that indicates the narrator's schizophrenic vision—it lumps together two discreet orders of ideas in a disturbing way, so we associate barnyard fowls (which are slaughtered to eat) with a young girl's mysterious murder. The narrator introduces himself with a rococo flourish: "This is the voice of Edward Clifton (Neddy) of the Poindexter ilk." (2) A self-reflexive process is started, as we are inducted into the problems of writing this story and shown how the techniques of fiction will be employed:

In *Treasure Island* I liked the sound of "The same broadside I lost my leg, Old Pew lost his deadlights." When I get around to writing myself, I decided, that is how I am going to sound. It is harder than it looks. The opening sentence of my story is as near as I can get. (2)

Neddy Poindexter is very like Stevenson's eager, naive Jim Hawkins and also like clever, knowing Huckleberry Finn—a boy with an adult-sized adventure-life to tell us, who has inducted us as compellingly as Coleridge's Mariner who "stoppeth one of three" (us) and holds us pinioned by a method that includes us firmly in the milieu and process of the story. We are extra implements in the metafictional toolkit.

Neddy must tell us about his best friend Leslie Wilson, his slightly older sister Prudence (who is exploding into adolescent sexuality at the time of the story, like a classic poltergeist-medium), his roguish Uncle Athol, a "prize bludger" (cadger, sponger) (3), and a family of picaresque nonchalance, which Neddy summarizes breezily:

Apparently, while the slump was playing fortissimo and I was playing cowboys and Indians, we became locally celebrated for not paying the rent, chopping up partitions for fuel against the wintry blasts, boozy parties, and the girls getting into the time-honoured spot of bother. (2)

The story is set up, then, to describe life among the urban savages, teenage gang struggles, Neddy's burgeoning awareness of sex and romance—something like Booth Tarkington in Taranaki.

However, the slaughtered Daphne Moran is there in the background, and then another uncanny presence is introduced:

A large truck, turning off the main highway into one of the narrow roads which shoot away and vanish like arrows aimed at the eternal haze of the backblocks, drew up at the crossroads a few hundred yards from the Te Rotiha railway station. When the truck rolled off on its way to the distant hills, it left a tall, gaunt man standing motionless beside the dusty road; for all the world, in the rays of the declining sun, like a scarecrow, strayed from the cloud-shadowed field. The shadow he cast heightened the impression of a scarecrow for, under his arm, he carried a cardboard box and this gave great width, in silhouette, to the shoulders of his flapping suit coat, as if his arms were spread. He topped the six-foot mark by three or four inches and was thin to the point of emaciation. (24)

This voice is mature, literary, retrospective, and scientifically exact—the mature Edward Poindexter looking back at the juvenile Neddy's context. The scene is full-scale gothic, introducing a character who is demonic and dreadful, who appears at the crossroads, where criminals were executed and vampires buried. He seems to appear or erupt into Neddy's small-town world without antecedent or explanation.

This is Morrieson's (and Neddy's) basic theme: this demonic intruder who ravishes nubile girls and cuts their throats at least introduces some drama, some interest, into an everyday world of banal misdemeanors and juvenile misunderstandings. The scarecrow is an ancient and barely living creature like something from H. P. Lovecraft, partly human, partly animal: "His nose was enormous, like a beak . . . claw-like hands . . ." (28) He is ancient and only partly alive, only partly in the world of small New Zealand towns, Saturday matinees, and sensational newspaper stories describing Daphne Moran's fate, as observed by twelve-year-old Lynette:

Beneath the black, arresting headlines summarizing the progress made in the search for the slayer, ran the second-day story of the young theatre usherette who had vanished and whose ravished, nude body had been discovered the following day by boys sailing boats on a pond. The body had been semi-submerged in a weed-choked corner of the pond. Daphne Moran's throat had been cut. (30)

Daphne is from the world of the B-movies that shape Lynette's view of the scarecrow; it is as if, in a Woody Allen bit of metacinema, a character from a Saturday serial, from a vampire movie, has descended from the small-town screen and murdered an usherette, flinging her into the pages of the tabloid papers, transmuted from one form of popular fiction to another. Horror from pulp fiction has come alive and stalks among the placid fields and sheep of the real, monotonous, and verifiable New Zealand backblocks.

In developing the story of the mysterious half-alive demon, Neddy and Edward Poindexter alternate in giving us the adolescent vision of events and the retrospective analysis of a grown man reconstructing, through the fragile scrim of nostalgia, a story of growing up wild. Neddy is involved in skirmishes with the Lynch gang, lectures on sex from his delinquent, poolshark brother Herbert, and observations of silk stockings, garters, women's underwear, and the growing awareness of his tomboy sister Prudence's emerging sexuality. Morrieson has linked love and death, sex and murder, in the traditional way of gothic fiction:

The emphasis on sex in [Morrieson's] novels may seem at first to be merely titillation—nylon-clad legs, suspender belts, school-girls playing basketball, a bit of the one-two when the right cards are dealt. But then the power behind the titillation breaks out. Most of the violence in the stories is related to sex, or to control over other people. And so bodies are decapitated, stabbed and hacked, mutilated in arranged accidents, set on fire, shoved under trains, tossed over cliffs. The energy and images of the unconscious seem constantly to buckle the surface of the narrative, like a tree forcing its way beneath a pavement. What breaks out is both

the rage behind repression and the delight at observing nemesis so clearly at work. (O'Sullivan 101)

And this link between sex, mutilation, and death is ultimately personified by the knife-wielding scarecrow, Hubert Salter, who turns out to be an itinerant magician and sword-swallower, but whose compulsions are pedophilic, voyeuristic, and (finally) necrophilic (he pulls a dead woman from a coffin to rape her). He is a zombie, a monster, a member of the living dead—what begins as broad parody of pop horror becomes more and more serious, more and more realized in Neddy Poindexter's biography.

Morrieson's forte, however, was not sociology or serious philosophical introspection—it was broad comedy, even slapstick farce. He piles on effects, exaggerates ideas already broad as they occur in popular fiction, to make a trenchant parody of the Saturday matinee movie serial Neddy Poindexter follows (*The Fire God's Treasure*) and to reflect it in his intricate plot (house fires recur in the story, culminating in the incineration of the town of Klynham's "haunted house," a decayed mansion inhabited by a crazed old woman, echoing Faulkner's florid gothic in "A Rose for Emily"). His characters absorb the ethos of popular culture from stories, films, vaudeville routines, music—they revel in the working-class culture of slam-bang action stories, sentimental romances, and exotic supernatural horror tales. Fittingly, Morrieson has crafted for them a complete world of popular culture values and sensibilities.

In his second novel, *Came a Hot Friday*, Morrieson extended and varied these processes of developing serious insights from popular comedy. It focuses on the two-bit underworld of Te Arahau and Tainuia Junction—an inept arsonist named Morrie Shapaleski; two tinhorn gamblers and short-con artists, Wesley Pennington and Cyril Kiddman; an anxious used-car salesman, Don Jackson; his newlywed friends Dick and Dinah Smelton; the local gangster-gambler, Sel Bishop; and the most bizarre and astounding character in New Zealand literature, a Maori named Tui Porano, a.k.a. The Te Whakinga Kid. The novel develops as a complex cross-plotted tale (like *The Scarecrow*) of the machinations these characters set in motion. Shapaleski, in debt to Bishop, burns down a one-room saloon Bishop owns for the insurance money. Inadvertently, he injures Pop Simon, an old

logger sleeping in the place. From this crime and the attendant guilt, a series of other crimes are generated, by a ripple effect, like a broad parody of *Crime and Punishment*.

Although the characters in *Came a Hot Friday* are older than the juveniles of *The Scarecrow*, they are still young men beginning to learn the complexities of existence and the interrelatedness of actions in a social environment. They begin as free-floating, self-seeking social atomies and end as bonded fragments in a complex molecule of social interaction. The consequences of Shapaleski's crime affect all the others, and their crimes are interlinked. Pennington and Kiddman set up a horse-racing con game, involving Jackson, the Smeltons, and Kiddman's pesky teenaged niece Penny.

Jackson, at one point, has a reverie of the good life he might live with his gambling buddies:

Don was with them in the heart of the King Country, in a gloomy billiard room in the small hours of the morning, the time, loaded with loot, they had smashed the board at a big crown and anchor game. As Wes pointed out "money made money". Once they had begun to rake in their fraudulent harvest off the racetracks their luck had smiled even on such chancy games as crown and anchor and two-up. (39)

This is every gambler's utopian vision, the idea that keeps every sucker coming back for every rigged game.

It is one thing to run small-time con games and another to tackle someone else's operation, which is what the youngsters do when they try to break Sel Bishop's crown and anchor gaming parlor (a woolshed out in the remote backblocks). By virtue of Jackson and Dick Smelton's work as car salesmen, they are supplied with big old fast cars—Packards and Jaguars—that they fantasize as "gangster jobs," adding to their swagger as would-be badmen. They run up and down the rough backcountry roads to inns and after-hours joints. After losing their money and being battered by the brutal Sel Bishop, they find the tutelary spirit of the place—a man Jackson first sees as a "young Maori," but who turns out to be wholly a self-created fantasy character:

The Kid could have been anywhere between thirty-five and fifty. He was light in colouring for a Maori, several shades more so than even half-caste Esmerelda. He was of medium height and dapper build. The Kid doffed an invisible sombrero of at least ten-gallon calibre. (160)

He has invented himself as eternal sidekick Pancho or perhaps even the Cisco Kid himself: "'You behold before you, Tui Porano. Better known as,' he leaned towards them and snapped his fingers, 'ze Te Whakinga Kid.'" (156) He has prepared speeches for the adventure in which they find themselves imbedded:

"And now," said Tui Porano, "ze Te Whakinga Kid will go to the assistance of your friend. It will help me if you and ze senorita will return to your automobile hidden in ze zungle, er bush. I will bring him to you. I will travel alone. Zis is my territory." (156)

And indeed it is: Morrieson has created a wonderfully zany concoction of mixed exoticisms—the Otherness of the Maori crossed with the stereotyped exotic romanticism of the Hispanic hero of Saturday matinees. Tui Porano inhabits full-time the fantasy world of heroes and winners that the young pakeha are beginning to explore in their picaresque adventures. The Maori has invented a world that is hospitable and in which he can succeed at his own games. As a speaker in an e. e. cummings poem puts it: "There's a hell of a good universe next door./ Let's go." Morrieson depicts Tui Porano as the B-movie cowboy hero:

Esmerelda kept looking at the Kid and putting her hand over her mouth. Except for the missing sombrero, he was attired in full cowboy regalia with a strong Mexican flavour. He even wore a holster with the grip of a revolver protruding. . . . The Kid was complete from earrings at one end to spurs at the other. Pinned to his chest was a highly polished tin badge of officialdom—a sheriff's star. His aura was one of engaging lunacy. (161)

But this hero is really a small boy “playing cowboy,” wholly bewitched and inhabited by the myth of selfless chivalry the cowboy movie invented. Tui Porano has accepted both congruent sides of the Hollywood cowboy myth—of the law-enforcing hero and the noble outlaw—and is left feeling self-divided:

Cigarette alight, the Kid’s mind began cautiously to shape up to the problem which tormented his waking hours. As the famous Te Whakinga Kid, bandit and two-gun man extraordinary, how was it possible for him to wear the beautiful sheriff’s star purchased along with his last cap gun? Every natural instinct in the Kid urged him to pursue the role of the outlaw, brilliant outwiter of the sheriff’s posse; but his new acquisition, the star, was a lovely thing and not to wear it was unthinkable. The more he pondered over this the more irreconcilable the two roles became. (172)

In a way, Tui’s outrageous persona, his freed fantasy, embodies the dilemma of all the young people in *Came a Hot Friday*—this collision of noble and rebellious urges, the need to be free outlaws in the bush, like the Duke’s men in *As You Like It*, and the need to do and be good. There is a collision between real criminals, ruthless and amoral, and the merely adventurous youths, as Huckleberry Finn and Jim play at pirates and runaways but meet the real outlaws and villains along the Missouri and Arkansas shorelines, who really murder and lynch each other with real guns and real bullets.

Came a Hot Friday winds up into an outrageous and surreal conclusion. The Te Whakinga Kid confronts the gangster Bishop, who has managed to capture or defeat the young pakeha gamblers. While “Deep in the Heart of Texas” booms from a jukebox, the Kid picks up Bishop’s rifle and becomes a bona fide hero:

“I am ze excellent shot, senor Bishop.”

This was a downright fib, the Kid having never had a real gun in his hands in his life before. It was the idea of actually handling the genuine article, the real McCoy at last, which had given his courage the little extra fillip required for the stealthy dart into the enemy’s stronghold.

"You will release ze senor Pennington pleez," said the Kid firmly, "otherwise it will be my pleasure to—ah—eliminate you."

In a way this was the crowning moment of his life. To be actually using the fascinating term "eliminate" in real earnest, face to face with the real thing, seemed like a dream to the Kid. (223)

The dream coming true is the growing up of Tui Porano, who (along with the others) lives out a true-life adventure and becomes the hero once only accessible through the Saturday matinees and the pulp thrillers. They have all become "the real McCoy," made authentic by their headlong, dangerous, and unpredictable adventures.

At the end, in a final twist, the idiot-savant hero Tui Porano makes off with the money from Sel Bishop's burned gambling hall. He is the ultimate winner of the adventure game, as he soliloquizes:

"I am rich," he shouted so crazily that the moon cocked an eye at him. "Ze Te Whakinga Kid ees ze richest man in ze world. He ees ze slick operator. Ze sheriff of Te Whakinga ees a bandit. He ees ze richest bandit in the world. To hell with ze sheriff." (233)

Tui feels he has outgrown his belief in the *taniwha*, the ancient, mythic river dragon of the Maori that has haunted his childhood:

"And as for you, old Father Taniwha," he screamed down at the dark swirling pool of river below the bridge. "You can do ze worst. You have frightened my peoples long enough. Who has ever seen you anyway? I tink you are ze great humbug, you old river monster." (233–234)

But by a typical Morrieson comic coincidence, a section of Sel Bishop's burning woolshed appears floating down the river: "The shape of some nameless monster with an enormous pair of fearful, diabolical, glowing eyes was gliding along on the surface of the water." (234) And the Kid flees in panic, dropping the hard-won rifle and the money into the river. The story that started in a fatal fire ends with a

symbolic fire, which reminds us that our heroes and monsters are real and infinitely powerful, no matter if they seem caricatures from pulp fiction.

Morrieson's third, posthumously published novel, *Predicament* (1974), also contains the outline of the classic Bildungsroman. Like *The Scarecrow*, it is set in the 1930s ("while the slump was playing fortissimo and I was playing cowboys and Indians"), a Golden Age for Morrieson—the time of youth and innocence. *Predicament* begins by spelling the nostalgia out explicitly:

In those days motorists could fill up with Big Tree
gasolene at the blue pump and the only guys with anything
like a Beatle haircut were Hitler and one of the Three
Stooges.

One day in the mid-thirties, just before the end of the year,
a boy of fifteen and two young men became involved in a
bizarre, macabre and altogether despicable adventure. (15)

The three comrades (read Musketeers or Caballeros, also—this is an odd three-sided buddy tale) are Cedric Williamson ("fifteen"), son of a wildly eccentric and socially inept father; Mervyn Toebeck ("twenty or so"), son of a "metho king," a dipsomaniac who dies of alcoholic poisoning; and the most grotesque and disturbing character in the story, Fred Haunt, a.k.a. The Spook, who is "twenty-three or twenty-four" and either "a Peeping Tom or a moron." (64) He is the equivalent of Hubert Salter, a radically incomplete human being who is both comic and sinister because he is hollow and inscrutable. After an abortive attempt at armed robbery, The Spook glides around on rubber soles and startles people. The young men become tangled in a convoluted Morrieson plot that includes romantic competition, bootlegging, and eventually murder and dismemberment. The characters, regardless of their chronological ages, are all three arrested juveniles who need the tempering of serious adult life to make them complete.

The Spook becomes a version of Nemesis, an instrument of the poetic justice Morrieson imported from the cliff-hanging serials, when they collude on a scheme of extortion—an attempt to blackmail "sinners" they catch by using a high-powered flash (which they claim to be a flash camera). Cedric has thought up the mechanism of the despicable scheme:

Cedric wasn't ever sure where the inspiration came from, but he recognized immediately the opportunity to dazzle his company. As far as he was concerned this blackmail business was just a lot of tommy-rot, just a game to fill in time, but here was an opportunity to impress people with his ingenuity and prove that he really was a leader by virtue of superior intelligence. . . .

"I fail to see the necessity for a flashlight camera. Maybe later on, but not immediately. The flash should suffice. A nice bright flash from a big torch. . . . It'll never cross our victims' minds that it's just a colossal bluff. They'll think they've been photographed and that's all that matters." (84)

This passage contains complex Morrieson elements: the idea that light is used to do a dark deed, that an innocent boy thinks up a vile (and very cunning) fraud because he believes it is all a game, that the exposure of sin and sexual crime is itself a form of crime. Cedric's dazzling inspiration leads to several unexpected and unpredictable crimes, including a gruesome death.

The three young men are classic antipodean "bludgers"—scroungers or spongers, those who cadge off others. Their extortion scheme is simply an extension of the bludging process, another way to get a free ride from others, from society. With this theme, Morrieson taps a basic New Zealand quandary—the paradoxical conflict between the idea of "cradle to grave" socialism, the obligation of the welfare state to support and nurture citizens, and the powerful sense of individualism and self-sufficiency of a pioneer culture.



Since their obscure publication, Morrieson's novels have moved from cult status to wide popularity in New Zealand, today read as school texts. Their comic outrageousness is accepted as a norm of the culture. Morrieson's sad biography has also become a legend, sometimes conflated with his fiction.

Ronald Hugh Morrieson was born in 1922 in Hawera, a provincial town in south Taranaki, regarded then as an agricultural outback. His father died when he was six, and he lived out his life in the large wooden house built by his grandfather, staying with his mother and

his aunt. He followed music by family tradition, working as a teacher and dance-band musician. Living the life of a slightly eccentric small-town figure (musicians, writers, artists all marginal and raffish, suspect in 1920s and 1930s New Zealand), Morrieson at age forty also began seriously to write fiction.

He was frustrated by his culture as a musician and a writer, late in life scribbling a melancholy note reading "My music and my writing may as well be classed as hobbies." (Simpson 18) He is that familiar figure, the neglected and misperceived small-town artist *manqué*, overlooked in life and turned to grotesque legend after death. He struggled with his musical career, playing at the road-houses and dives he describes so vividly in his novels, and worked to be published as a novelist, all without leaving Hawera, without contacting the literati or (very small) writing community in New Zealand. He became something of a naive or primitive artist, creating wonderful and strange objects in his big wooden house, with a home-made esthetic and a unique, untrammelled imaginative vision.

His first two novels appeared in 1963 and 1964 to good reviews in Australia. At home he was little noticed. Thereafter, Morrieson struggled to be read, valued, and published. His mother died in 1968, and Morrieson descended into the spiral of alcoholism. He died in 1972, barely fifty years old, leaving his two published novels, one completed but unpublished novel (*Predicament*), a ragged draft (*Pallet on the Floor*), and two excellent short stories as his total literary legacy.

This bare tale is the stuff of cultural myth, which (along with the astonishing vitality and quality of his writing) has kept him read. He has become an icon, an epitome: the provincial artist-social critic, ignored or scorned in life, whose work in retrospect seems an acute critique of a limited, self-satisfied puritan culture. Reality is never that simple and monolithic, and Morrieson's tales are caricatures, exuberant comic exaggerations of a Rabelaisian magnitude, comic-page blowups of a milieu and characters for which Morrieson obviously felt much nostalgic affection. Even his nastiest creations are cuddled a bit in the stories—"They may be bastards, but they're my bastards!" As the Kiwis say about rough-and-ready characters, each is "a bit of a dag," uncouth, unwashed but embraceable.

Small-town life of Depression New Zealand is Morrieson's spe-

cial province, a culture slightly retrograde and obsolete, out of touch with the great world except through the distorting glasses of popular culture—pop music, movies, tabloid journalism—and everyday local realities of gossip, family history, and shared deprivations.

But like all significant literary artists, Morrieson is far more than the sum of his biographical parts. His home in Hawera is gone, replaced (in an irony he would relish profanely) by an American fast-food outlet. His books still sell, have been filmed reverently, and may be the most powerful evocations of a New Zealand nearly forgotten in the microchip-driven, cyberspace-launched new world order of the 1990s.

What Morrieson brought to his writing may stem from the very restrictions of Hawera and lower-middle-class rules of respectability. He became a wrestler in school, played the guitar, piano, and bass, imbibing the self-liberating conventions of jazz, hung out in seedy bars and dives, lived his life well below the Plimsoll line of the constrained bourgeoisie. Then he brought his observations and experiences to his writing, with great affection for the outcast, wayward, undereducated, vulgar. His language is colloquial, his sensibility populist. The sense of egalitarian camaraderie that marks New Zealand life is strongly displayed in Morrieson's fictions. One of his most perceptive commentators defines this process:

He put the New Zealand of provincial pubs, race-tracks, dances, two-up schools, sly-groggers, back-seat gropes, small-town rumours and fears and comedy, into intricately plotted stories quite unlike any others that have been written. . . .

The setting . . . is always Taranaki. It is a very funny world—or, one should say, the way it is written about is splendidly comic. It is a place of tragedies and comedies of the kind that appear, without the wit, each week in *Truth*. It is convincing and recognisable, and yet grotesque. Almost every character is playing at being someone else, as though without the predictable lines that come with the roles of gambler, jazz-player, small-town hood, brilliantined seducer or whatever, there would be too demanding an emptiness to face. (O'Sullivan 100)

Morrieson made of New Zealand a discernible world, a literary creation that was “real” and “fictional” simultaneously, like Faulkner’s Yoknapatawpha County, a mappable abstraction. And he did it with an individual, explosive imaginative power, of the sort that does not derive from purely literary training and preoccupations. However, Morrieson’s command of language and style is in no way compromised by his robustness. One of the most acute contemporary critics of New Zealand writing comments on Morrieson’s language:

The tradition of the novel in English includes Fielding, Smollet, Sterne and Dickens, all lapsers and nudgers who are likely to lose their cool at the onset of another bright idea. In Mr Morrieson as in them the crudeness is part of the energy, and that energy, as well as generating the total vision, can produce moments of astonishing verbal beauty and flashes of genuine wit. (Stead 144)

The same commentator also cites and commends Morrieson’s “cool sentences” and “instinct for combining the bizarre and the beautiful.” (Stead 142) He was a writer capable of reaching for and encompassing the literary sublime, even in the midst of pop-culture horrors and farcical exaggerations.

In the end, what drove Morrieson was a comic vision, a sense of the ludicrous incongruity of our daily lives. His books are persistently and ingeniously funny. Morrieson underlined this when he asked novelist Maurice Shadbolt about the meaning of the literary term “Southern gothic”:

“Tell me,” Ron broke in, after the point had been sufficiently elucidated, “do you crack a smile when you read these people?”

“Why?”

“I can’t stand reading books where you never crack a smile.” (*Predicament* 10)

The importance of Morrieson’s own “Taranaki gothic” stories is that beyond and between the horrors they do move us to “crack a smile”—even to laugh aloud.

6

The Necessity of Ghosts: Aotearoa Gothic

A common cultural link between pakeha and Maori, although unconscious and largely unacknowledged, is the belief in the hauntedness of the landscape, the sense that Aotearoa New Zealand is a land of sinister and unseen forces, of imminent (and immanent) threat, of the undead or revenant spirits. This feeling and the presence of the gothic mode are among striking first impressions of modern New Zealand literature and film.

The novels of Ronald Hugh Morrieson are a prime example. His three completed novels—*The Scarecrow* (1963), *Came a Hot Friday* (1964), and *Predicament* (1974)—are all versions of pop-vernacular gothic, with parodic-comic plots. Morrieson skates on the verge of spoof or outright parody in his handling of forms and conventions of popular literature. Earlier tales like Katherine Mansfield's "The Woman at the Store" refer to an unseen terror lurking below the normal, placid surface of middle-class New Zealand culture. The gothic theme is usually linked explicitly with a story of adolescence, with the idea of growing up into an unknown and fearful adult universe, as in David Ballantyne's *Sydney Bridge Upside Down* (1968). This novel, similar in tone and feeling to Morrieson's writing minus the manic comedy, deals with an adventure that goes wrong, ending in a series of deaths, some of them killings.

The theme of the haunted landscape and gothic feelings underlies a recent documentary film on New Zealand cinema assembled by Sam Neill (*Cinema of Unease*, 1995), which describes the alienating empty landscape hinting at unseen horrors. The characteristic New Zealand cinematic (and literary) effect Neill catalogs is that of uncanny suspense—the instant before the ghost appears or the ectoplasm materializes. The films of director Peter Jackson (*Brain Dead*

[1992], *Heavenly Creatures* [1994], *The Frighteners* [1996]) have generously dispensed gothic-horror elements, tempered by outrageous comedy and parody.

In the process of self-definition, cultures need to pass through a stage of hauntedness. This may be a simple analogy for the birth of historical consciousness—one way to gain historical rootedness in other than an abstract, intellectual way is to feel that the past is a horror waiting to reinvade the present. If you feel raw, young, unformed, lacking in historical status, a way to gain stature is to acquire suitably ancient ghosts.

This seems one impetus behind early American literature. Aside from the fact that the gothic mode was pervasive in the novel of the late eighteenth century (which accounts for the ponderous gothic tales of Charles Brockden Brown), there was a drive to find “native” subjects, uniquely American themes, that both contradicted and incorporated the desire for a sense of the past to rival old Europe. Thus the ghost stories of Washington Irving (including “Rip Van Winkle”) try to create an “ancient” history for early-nineteenth-century Americans to recall and enjoy. There are terrifying or disturbing elements in that past, like the duckpin-bowling goblins in “Rip Van Winkle,” the ghostly revenants of Hendrick Hudson’s crew from his exploration ship *Half-Moon*, or the folktale-like quasi-comic story of haunting in “The Legend of Sleepy Hollow.” In other tales, like “The Spectre Bridegroom,” Irving returned to conventionalized ancient European settings (a haunted Germany of ruinous castles and sinister barons) to make the ghostliness work.

In reanimating the horror story, Edgar Allan Poe created a strange half-world between the European past of old gothic (“The Pit and the Pendulum,” a tale of the Spanish Inquisition, right out of the catalog of papist horror by Monk Lewis, or “The Masque of the Red Death” and the background of the bubonic plague), an ectoplasmic transitional landscape (is the setting of “The Fall of the House of Usher” American or European? are there “tarns” in America? do American families think of themselves as “houses” in the European, dynastic sense?), and purely American locales like that of “The Gold Bug.” Poe had to invent a French detective and invoke the medieval quarters of Paris to find the vintage terror needed for many “tales of ratiocination,” but the impulse behind them was clear—to create a literary-

cultural "pedigree," a certificate of classic historicity to dignify the new nation.

The same impulse is present in writers like Melville and James, whose ghost or horror stories move away from the clanking mechanisms of the old gothic into modes of psychological horror, as in "Bartleby the Scrivener" or "The Encantadas" or "The Jolly Corner," "The Beast in the Jungle" and "The Turn of the Screw." In "Bartleby," Melville painstakingly sets the tale in his contemporary Wall Street and details it as an American theme—the materialist-industrial culture of the counting house of Manhattan, just downriver from the ghostly bowlers of "Rip Van Winkle." James, similarly, is at pains to build a rational, naturalistic background for his tales, which treat the idea of hauntedness as a feeling imbedded in his contemporary American culture. By the 1890s, America was old enough to have a "distant" past, and James could concentrate on the theme of people who lack a sense of self and the way they are invaded by the ghosts of their own pasts, the slippery idea that our "ghosts" are psychological states—failure of will, self-doubt, lack of courage, unwillingness to love.

This mode of fiction becomes a historical-cultural analysis, a way to rationalize the gothic feeling. Ghost stories and the sense of horror and alienation at the root of the gothic mode are simply disguised historical fictions (and there is ample evidence for this in very early gothic like Walpole's *The Castle of Otranto*, which relies for most of its horrific effects on the transposition of readers from mid-eighteenth-century England, with its comfortable rationalistic culture, to the "gothic" ages—medieval Italy, a land of papist superstition, crumbling architecture, and Machiavellian villainy). The "disguised history" strategy of gothic supplies a landscape and a genealogy for the culture by way of the unconscious and the unknown. America in the 1840s was simply too raw and new to have ancient, crumbling castles, houses inhabited by decadent noble families for a dozen generations, sites of antique horror.

Nathaniel Hawthorne tried overtly to mine such ideas, and like Poe was only partially successful in Americanizing the themes. In his best explicitly supernatural tales, like "The Gray Champion," "Ethan Brand," and "Feathertop," Hawthorne invokes the history of puritanism that became his great resource and uses the seventeenth and

eighteenth centuries as America's "gothic age" of superstition and terror, while Poe stretched to Europe for the same themes. In other tales, like "The Artist of the Beautiful" or "Dr. Heidigger's Experiment," Hawthorne went directly to the old European gothic model, creating stories more like the surrealistic fantasias of E. T. A. Hoffman or Mary Shelley's gothic in *Frankenstein* than like American models.

Aside from horror as surrogate history, there are other cultural needs for ghost stories. Freud, in one of his most famous psycho-literary essays, "The Uncanny" (1919), establishes the categories of "*unheimlich*" and "*heimlich*" as apparently antithetical ideas or feelings that become identities. Using the dictionary and a history-of-ideas methodology, Freud shows that by consulting alternative definitions of these two terms, eventually we find a usage in which "*unheimlich*" becomes a version of "*heimlich*."

"*Unheimlich*" is translated awkwardly in English as "uncanny," but its literal translation would be "unhomelike," the sense it carries in German—not at home, uncomfortable, displaced, alien or alienated. "Uncanny" is an old-fashioned term in English and suggests something intellectual and abstract like "unknown" or "inexplicable," while the sense Freud searches for is closer to "creepy feeling," a sensation like "goosebumps" or "chills"—the abrupt realization that one has been transported from mundane reality to a different place. It is the hair starting up on the back of the neck or the nightmare sensation of being suddenly injected into an unexplored and forbidden space, the land where anything can happen.

So the German terms referring to the sense of place—*heimlich* and *unheimlich*—invoke the sensation of fear, the chilled, pit-of-the-stomach vulnerability that horror tales aim to induce. In Freud's view, we cease being "at home" with ourselves and feel something like an out-of-body experience—we are distanced from our true selves by the sensation. This may occur when we feel the vulnerability of our physical bodies, the sense that we are not an integral whole but a collection of parts—organs and limbs. He says: "Dismembered limbs, a severed head, a hand cut off at the wrist, feet which dance by themselves—all of these have something peculiarly uncanny about them, especially when, as in the last instance, they prove able to move of themselves in addition." (397) (This leads Freud to one of his standard rationalistic explanations, when he sees this as one more version

of castration anxiety.) He cites and explicates in detail Hoffman's complex tale "The Sand-Man" (source of the Coppelia/Olympia stories of dancing dolls that became the bases of musical works by Delibes and Offenbach), to show how we are fascinated with creatures that appear alive but are mechanical—a way of saying "living dead" or "undead." (378–386) He treats the theme of blinding in Hoffman's tale as another form of the castration complex, but the basic point of the story is that the central character (Nathaniel) is deluded into believing that a mechanical doll is a live woman: what is dead comes "alive," and what lives is "dead." But Freud dismisses this obvious interpretation of the story as put forward in a paper by E. Jentsch (the starting point for Freud's own essay).

Freud concludes that most uncanny experiences relate to the castration complex, but that the fear of premature burial (Poe's central theme) is "a transformation of another phantasy . . . of intra-uterine existence." (397) He develops this:

It often happens that male patients declare that they feel there is something uncanny about the female genital organs. This *unheimlich* place, however, is the entrance to the former *heim* [home] of all human beings. . . . There is a humorous saying: "Love is home-sickness"; and whenever a man dreams of a place or a country and says to himself, still in the dream, "this place is familiar to me, I have been there before," we may interpret the place as being his mother's genitals or her body. (399)

We may deal with this idea of *unheimlich* (now inverted to be identical with *heimlich*) as "country matters," indeed, in Hamlet's punning sense. The vagina and womb are metonymized as landscape, as place, in the old sense of "motherland" or "mother country" (to keep Hamlet's pun).

So the "uncanny," in the sense of ghostly, horrific, terrifying, is built into the understanding of place—especially a new place, a fantastic place, a place met in dreamlike conditions. Freud in the end feels that the uncanny is created when either "infantile complexes" or "primitive beliefs" (like animism) that have been "surmounted" by "civilized people" are revived (403). The *unheimlich* experience is an

atavism, a reaching back to buried or repressed feelings and beliefs, thus the feeling that this is a familiar place, a *deja vu* sensation. The “return” feeling of *deja vu* in this case is an experience of revelation: “The Freudian uncanny is itself a sort of phantom, looming up out of darkness: an archaic fantasy or fear, long ago exiled to the unconscious, that nonetheless ‘returns to view’—intrudes on ordinary life but in a form so distorted and disguised by repression that we fail to recognize its psychological source.” (Castle 7)

The cultural geographer Yi-fu Tuan in *Landscapes of Fear* describes how cultures define space:

The minimum requirement for security is to establish a boundary, which may be material or conceptual and ritually enforced. Boundaries are everywhere, obviously so in landscapes of fences, fields and buildings, but equally there in the worlds of primitive peoples. Boundaries exist on different scales. Minimally and perhaps universally, three are recognized: the boundaries of the domain, of the house, and of the body. (206)

However, these boundaries may also be blurred or conflated to create that paradoxical synthesis of *heimlich/unheimlich*—when each is seen as a metaphor or metonymy of the other. The domain, house, and body are versions of each other on a microcosmic-macrocosmic scale, so a person becomes a fragment of the homeland or the homeland is felt to be a totality, a *gestalt* mechanism, of all the inhabitants (as Hobbes felt the state was “leviathan,” the composite superorganism compiled of all individual humans inside it). To be “at home” is to feel comfortable inside one’s body, one’s house, one’s country.

The uncanny experience—that is, creation of a haunted landscape, a geography that admits the existence of ancient terror—is one instrument for building a national or cultural identity. It certainly becomes a method, however perverse, for creating a sense of “home ownership”: to possess a place is to be possessed by it, as Robert Frost asserted in “The Gift Outright.” A place that haunts you is in some sense “home,” as in the phrase “haunted by memories of home.” The confusion of “real” or “historical” memory (as in autobiography) and the memory of dreams (as in *déjà vu* experiences, fantasies, reveries,

etc.) is at the root of gothic and horror fiction. It is the sense of a chthonic experience that informs the essentially American tales of H. P. Lovecraft, with their references to ancient civilizations beneath the earth, an unimaginably old horror erupting from far back in time into contemporary space. To occupy a landscape comfortably, humans seem to need this chthonic feeling—"this my own, my native land"—which connects with Freud's image of the land as womb and birth canal. This connects *déjà vu* and chthonic feelings directly: to feel at home in a place is to feel that one has been born not just *in it* but *by it*, that the metaphoric idea of "motherland" is in some important way literal. Chthonic birth implies literal roots—that human beings are organically stuck into the soil, have a "vegetable" consciousness of the sort celebrated by Andrew Marvell. We are haunted, then, by pre-natal memories, by a profound nostalgia for the state of being before birth.

Ghosts and haunting—messages erupting into nature via the supernatural—help confirm this sense. We need more than the facts of history and experience to understand who we are. Identity is created by powerful feelings, including the feeling of terror or dread, as much as by rational information. Ghost stories confirm our individual and cultural importance: "I am of interest to the gods, demons, spirits—I know, because they have revealed themselves to me." This is why the precise, rationalistic Samuel Johnson refused to reject reports of ghosts in late-eighteenth-century London: he felt belief in the supernatural in any form should be encouraged, because it led toward profounder belief in Christian revelation (Clery 18–24). A ghost story may move us toward a sense of at-homeness, of comfort with ourselves.

However, Freud's idea that *unheimlich* and *heimlich* are paradoxically linked is important, too. The terms are connected under tension and threaten to separate themselves at any moment. There is an uneasiness, an uncertainty or ambiguity to being haunted—it is profoundly disturbing and disorienting, and until some crisis or resolution is reached, an exorcism or end to the haunting or an absorption of the haunted by the haunTERS, there can be no conclusion, no denouement to the story. Thus many of Poe's and Hawthorne's tales end ambiguously, without explicit resolution. We are not sure exactly what happened or why.

This sense of inconclusiveness, of ongoingness, also helps create cultural identity: the experience is not a piece of dead history, completed fiction, but unfinished business, the present evolving into the future. The transition from *unheimlich* to *heimlich* is the process of nation building, of acculturation. We move from a sense of alienation and rootlessness—being separated and detached from the landscape around us—to a sense of being rooted in it, sprung from it, possessed and haunted by it.

The Maori term equivalent to (and as ambiguous as) *heimlich* is *turangawaewae*, usually translated as “domicile” but carrying connotations of “at-homeness” or “possession.” Because the sacredness of the land and the sense of habitation was as important as the idea of ancestors and the ever-present dead in Maori belief, the *heimlich/unheimlich* concept is relevant to an understanding of Aotearoa. Alternative Maori creation/culture-hero myths do not describe the Pacific navigation and the canoe fleets but deal with chthonic ancestors—people who sprang from the earth, not the ocean. These stories insist on *turangawaewae* connected to the soil, the islands themselves, distinct from the larger web of Polynesian nations. The central Maori idea of *tapu* is also important to the sense of place in Aotearoa—“*tapu*” (usually spelled “taboo” in modern English) is the sense of sacredness, which also means both “holy” and “forbidden” or “cursed.” *Tapu* places are at once utterly possessed and proscribed, both fearful and venerated. Maori settlements were in part the temporary camps of nomadic hunters and in part carefully anchored places with fortifications, *marae*, and other blessed sites. Important persons were sometimes laid to rest in mountain caves or other secret places that were powerfully *tapu*. The Maori also named all significant features of the landscape as they explored them, for naming is the first step in possession. Places given a name were given a human sense, infolded into language and memory and thereby “conquered” in a basic cultural process.

A complex image develops of the “motherland” as a female form, a hollow, hallowed womb from which emerge the chthonic inhabitants of a place. “Mother Earth” is both holy and haunted. Because she is alive, she must be treated respectfully and not damaged or wounded. She enfolds the living and the dead, and spirits may be born from her as readily as human beings. The rolling hills and

valleys, the softly feminine forms of much of Aotearoa's landscape help reinforce the image of a reclining goddess drifting in the great ocean, on which humans exist in a symbiosis. The sexual imagery is not only that of motherhood and birth:

As well as mother, the earth is also conceived in the role of lover, an idea that may have originated in the practice of agriculture, or the discovery that there is in cultivating the soil a reproductive process comparable with human reproduction. Both Freud and Jung believed that the influence went the other way, that man's sexual experience suggested the possibility of agriculture. (Lutwack 82-83)

Whatever the process of discovery, a sense of chthonic "ownership" of the land is like sexual exploration and the beginning of sexual identity.

This strongly sexualized landscape recalls Freud's Oedipal ideas of the birth passage and our nostalgia for the vagina and the womb. We are haunted by the sense of ourselves as chthonic beings expelled from the *hortus conclusus*, the closed paradisaical garden of the womb, into an open world, dangerous and hospitable. In death we return to the womb of earth, but in our lives we live in anxiety, on but not of the earth, uneasy because simultaneously at home and in exile.

Turangawaewae is a feeling of acceptance by the land, of being at one with it, not isolated or distanced by *tapu*. The sense of "domicile" is the unification of body, house, and domain. Both Maori and pakeha in Aotearoa needed to discover this feeling, since both were relatively recent voyagers, immigrants, to the islands, intruders on the primeval paradise of flightless birds.

The Western tradition of imagining the earth as a sexualized (as feminine, gendered) landscape, a reclining and receptive goddess waiting to be invaded and impregnated by explorers came to a peak in John Donne's famous metaphysical conceit in his "Elegy to His Mistress on Going to Bed":

*License my roving hands, and let them go
Before, behind, between, above, below.
O my America! my new-found-land,
My kingdom safest when with one man mann'd.*

This habit of mind and image creates the idea of geographical conquest as an extension of sexual conquest: to discover a “new” land is to penetrate and ravish it, to plumb it sexually. Commentators on Sir Walter Raleigh’s expeditions to Guiana have detailed how Raleigh’s imagery in his descriptions of exploration makes the land feminine and emasculates the men of its societies:

Apparently masculine societies—societies from which women have already been verbally effaced—are themselves rendered invisible by a metonymic substitution of place for persons, a substitution of the land for its inhabitants. . . . By subsuming and effacing the admired societies of Amerindian men in the metaphorically feminine Other of the land, the English intent to subjugate the indigenous peoples of Guiana can be “naturalized” as the male’s mastery of the female. (Montrose, 188, and see Nicholl, 165–169)

To the degree that this habit of mind still existed in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, Aotearoa was a set of feminine islands waiting to be explored by “roving hands,” the coastline “felt” by Cook’s mapping expedition, its bays and inlets penetrated and plumbed, the feminine roll of the hills and valleys charted.

This pakeha habit of metaphor differs from the essentially communal or family idea of *turangawaewae*—hearth or home, domicile in the shared, domestic sense. For Westerners, the new-found-lands are “kingdoms” to be “mann’d” (i.e., possessed as in sex or “manned” as a hawk is manned—tamed or broken to the human, masculine presence). For Maori, the lands have long been “found” and now are inhabited familiarly, as a person inhabits his or her body. The complex Maori beliefs about time, death, and the continuing presence of the dead among the living accentuate this sense of “possession”: the land is “home” to both the living and the dead, who share equal and simultaneous habitations. In a sense, Maori are always haunted by the dead, while haunting is an anomaly, an exceptional state in pakeha culture. The opening act of *Hamlet* might seem tame and ordinary to a Maori audience, for whom “something rotten in the state of Denmark” and the idea of a ghost doomed to walk the earth in a pur-

gatorial state would be not at all disquieting. To the degree to which Maori beliefs include the chthonic sense of emerging from the land, the feminine image here is of "Mother Earth," the familiar womb, not the "Lover Earth" image of Donne or Raleigh. Being at home is "all in the family" for the Maori, while for the pakeha it is "conquest of the Amazons."

We are back to the old argument of dominion versus stewardship that has percolated since cultural historian Lynn White sparked the famous theologico-ecological debate in the 1960s. Do humans cooperate with nature or compete with it? Do we subdue and conquer the planet or live in harmony in its infinite complexity? Does the story in Genesis grant us "ownership" of the planet, or are we merely servants and caretakers holding it gingerly from generation to generation? The Treaty of Waitangi tried to express ideas of chieftainship and ownership of the land, as Europeans had thought of themselves and their environment for hundreds of years. The Maori were puzzled by such concepts: for them leadership was a purely social and familial term, like "fatherhood" or "motherhood," and surely no transient, mortal humans could think of "owning" land in perpetuity? For the Maori, acquisition and maintenance of *mana* was transitory, not a "fact" of law and real estate, material property to be captured in a contract, preserved and bequested to unborn posterity.

The worldviews in collision left New Zealand haunted by a variety of ghosts almost as eccentric, multifarious, and multicolored as those wishfully invoked by Wallace Stevens in "Disillusionment of Ten O'Clock":

*The houses are haunted
By white night-gowns.
None are green,
Or purple with green rings,
Or green with yellow rings,
Or yellow with blue rings.*

The legacy of the ancient gaudy ghosts—of persons, of ideas, of events—has been Aotearoa gothic, a sense of unease, dread, and anxiety under the smooth skin of New Zealand's literature and culture.

Ronald Hugh Morrieson's Haunted Worlds

An example of how gothic attitudes pervade New Zealand literature, and how they spring out of the everyday and ordinary, occurs in one of Janet Frame's earliest published stories, "The Lagoon," which describes family secrets and memories. The narrator asks her aunt why she is fascinated by a dirty lagoon at Picton, an apparently innocuous, meaningless site:

— Is there a story? I said. I was a child again. Grandma, tell me about . . .

My aunt smiled. She guesses things sometimes.

— The sort of story they put in *Truth*, she said. On the morning of the tragedy witness saw defendant etc. etc. Your great-grandmother was a murderess. She drowned her husband, pushed him in the lagoon. I suppose the tide was high, I don't know. They would call it "The Woman from Nelson," she mused. They would have photos. But then nobody knew, only the family. Everybody thought he had had one over the eight and didn't know where he was going.

My aunt drew aside the curtain and peered out. She reminded me of the women in films who turn to the window in an emotional moment, but the moment wasn't emotional, nor was my aunt.

— It's an interesting story, she said. I prefer Dostoevsky to *Truth*. (Frame 10)

In this passage a number of characteristic references are made—to tabloid journalism (*Truth*), the home of the sensational, to movies, the form of popular culture that most molds attitudes toward emotional responses, and to high literary culture, a great Russian author who wrote persuasively of family murders and crime and punishment. The facts of life, death, and tragedy within a family are converted to cheap headlines, blurry newsprint photos, or the postures of romantic film making rather than to the enduring truths of art.

Ronald Hugh Morrieson often used the same process of allusions to convey the hauntedness of his small-town New Zealand milieus. His first novel, *The Scarecrow*, draws from cinematic models—Satur-

day afternoon serials (*The Fire God's Treasure* is playing) and standard Hollywood horror films, especially vampire or zombie stories of the living dead. (The film version of Morrieson's novel reinforces the allusion metacinematically by casting John Carradine in his very old age in the title role, making us recall his innumerable performances as a ghoul, right back to the 1930s, when this story is set.) The character, Hubert Salter, is first closely described to us through the eyes of a twelve-year-old girl who is terminally bored with a slow train journey, where she sees only the neutral landscape and ubiquitous sheep through the frame of the railway carriage window. She turns to a more cinematic vision as she looks at the passengers:

Although she had been reared in city streets which abounded in unusual-looking characters, her eyes became round as she studied the newcomer. He looked as tall as a lamp post and carried about the same amount of fat. His dishevelled dark suit of clothes hung limply around his bony structure. He was so thin, so gaunt, he looked as if he might belong to the walking dead. In spite of the censor's ruling, Lynette had recently seen not one, but an entire series of films about the walking dead and considered herself an authority on the subject.

"A zombie," she breathed. It was frightening, but it was an improvement on that sheep. (27)

Salter looks like F. W. Murnau's atavistic vampire, Nosferatu, a starveling, subhuman monstrosity.

Salter is described as a magician, a sword-swallower, and a knife-man. His weapon is explicitly phallic—he kills young women to practice his necrophilic sexuality on them:

"Behold," he said, producing from under his coat the longest-bladed knife I have ever seen. It must be remembered this is some time ago, but I am prepared to swear it had a blade nearly a foot long. (107–108)

Salter is like Svengali or like a serpent who hypnotizes his prey, and he is attracted to the narrator's ironically named tomboy sister Prudence:

Slowly he withdrew the fearsome knife again and passed it to Prudence. She fingered the steel in awe. He retrieved it from her, but instead of returning it to its place of concealment under his coat, he pressed the hilt lightly against Prudence's chin so that the blade glittered down between her breasts, reaching to the pit of her stomach. (110–111)

The knifeplay becomes increasingly explicit surrogate sexual activity:

He laid the knife flat against Prudence, this time with the hilt down against her stomach, the contour of which was so plainly etched against her knitted frock that I could almost see the fish and chips. Now the blade pointed upwards between her breasts. "See, see," he said. "See how long it is, mer dear, and how far up into yer lovely young body it reaches."

One thing I could see anyway and that was, holding the hilt of the knife against her stomach the way he was, he had the tips of his fingers pressing hard up between her legs. (112)

Salter, an itinerant vaudevillian, is a cheap actor right out of horror melodrama—but he is also authentically menacing, so that Morrieson's story takes on the quality of a nightmare in which you tell yourself "It's only a dream," only to feel it is also indisputably real. Morrieson exploits the stereotypes of popular cinema and literature as an Empsonian ambiguity, so we can take them as both comic-book fantasy and small-town realism.

Salter, like a film vampire, has been hiding in the town's funeral parlor, evidently sleeping in the coffins, and he is finally killed when he falls and strikes his temple on the edge of a coffin, as if he must be destroyed by an emblem of death. The last we see of his knife, it is like another icon from comic-book tales of terror:

It was as if it had just thudded home into the wall above our heads. It was well over even big Len's head and yet, it dawned on us after our first alarm had abated, it had been slammed up there, effortlessly, in passing. Each time the

wind, having batted its way through the ranks of driving rain, shook the building, the hilt of the knife quivered realistically. An intrepid cobweb had already staked its claim on the wicked steel. (208)

It is a shadowed still life, a prop or set for the terrifying drama that has just unfolded, like a chromolithographed movie poster or a bit of stage set that “quivered realistically.”

With *Morrieson* we are inside the stagy conventions of popular literature, which he loves to manipulate but also to unveil, so we are often reminded that we are reading a comic thriller and that New Zealand is a place where such a story could really unfold in a real, three-dimensional and topographically locatable place as *Morrieson's* hometown of Hawera, Taranaki, North Island. The last words of the novel are like the big block letters *THE END* that close a Warner Bros. or Monarch or Republic Pictures film—even better, a serial installment—of the 1930s: “Episode closed!”

In *Came a Hot Friday*, *Morrieson* turned from straight Hollywood gothic to a mixed mode of popular drama—the picaresque buddy story of short-con criminality, mixed with backwoods gangsterism like that of Faulkner's *Sanctuary* (itself a version of gothic storytelling). It also uses visual emblems to set up a highly convoluted plot. Wesley Pennington and Cyril Kiddman, two would-be grifters, meet a barroom habitué right out of movie comedy, “a ringer for Harpo Marx” (31), who sells them a packet of pornographic pictures and a scheme for bilking bookies on horse races that were not broadcast by getting results relayed by phone from the racecourse (a variant on the con game practised in the 1973 Newman-Redford film *The Sting*). All these elements unleash a complex tale that keeps returning to models of popular culture—movies and movie characters, pop music and dances, popular adventure stories and their models of heroism and skullduggery.

The dirty pictures—“photographs of a winsome and voluptuous lass in nylon stockings and earrings disporting herself with a coloured gentleman arrayed in turtle-neck sweater and sandals” (26)—are confiscated by a small-time bookie, a simian bully named Norman Cray, on whom Kiddman and Pennington attempt revenge.

The tale is set in small-town bars and cafes, in after-hours joints,

and finally the woolshed gambling casino of the villainous Sel Bishop, an even more menacing version of Norman Cray. The world is in part defined by Morrisson through a repeated self-reflexive device—the recurrence of a cheap print of melodramatic import that turns up on the walls of these places. It is first described in Uncle Jim's Fish Restaurant:

Cyril surveyed the scene as depicted by the tall mirror on the opposite wall. Around the white draped table (it looked spotless in the mirror) he saw his elegant self, armpit supported, draped over the back of his chair, Wes leaning right back in his chair smoking a cigarette with great relish, and Don leaning forward, chin in cupped hands. The flask of Bells was partially concealed. Hanging on the wall was a big picture of a black horse and a white horse in a terrible storm. (32)

This is a remarkably artificial and composed scene—framed (and reversed) in a mirror, studied by Cyril like a work of art and incorporating in itself another picture, the outdoor/wild/nature painting of the horses.

The device recurs quickly at Don Jackson's house, where we get another carefully composed tableau:

Pennington, seated at the table behind a jar of pickled onions, an array of beer bottles, a whisky bottle and water jug, beamed complacently. Also scattered around the table were three copies of the racing guide *Horse Talk*. Cyril was stretched out elegantly on the old sofa. Hanging on the wall above Cyril was a big picture of a black horse and a white horse in a terrible storm, a replica of the painting in Uncle Jim's restaurant. "Harpo" had not the distinction of being unique in his line of business. There had been other itinerant vendors of artistic gems. (39)

The pornographic photos are connected explicitly to the horses (and to those plotting schemes of fixing race results). We learn that "Harpo" has been arrested for indecent exposure, fittingly enough for

an "itinerant vendor" of lust. And we must keep our eyes on these other "vendors" of gambling schemes, for we are in a world where images can be manufactured and counterfeited readily—a world of artificial sex and artificial thrills, as reproduced and multiplied photographically.

To underscore this, we follow Norman Cray and the pornographic pictures and find out that "he had been sleeping with his step-daughter for fifteen years. Everybody in Tainuia Junction said so, but none of them really believed it. They should have." Cray, drinking with his stepdaughter, "stood staring at the wall for a while, his eyes fixed unseeingly on a big picture of a black horse and a white horse in a terrible storm." (105) Cray's gaze is unseeing, because he is infused with lust for the girl and rage at Pennington and Kiddman, who have fleeced him with their late-results con. In the meantime, Pennington and Kiddman are celebrating at a bar called the Blue Kiwi, and as they are leaving stop to talk "immediately underneath a picture of a black horse and a white horse in a terrible storm." (109)

And elsewhere, Don Jackson's father, a one-legged veteran of Gallipoli, has been whiling away his evening at the Soldiers' Club, where

he had been running up a billiard break, with a few snooker balls at the baulk end of the table, but suddenly he couldn't be bothered any more. He put his cue on the rack. Hastily he averted his eyes from the distraught gaze of a black horse and a white horse, storm-lashed and terrified for ever, in a picture hanging above the rack. (134)

The horses are now more emotionally described, as if the storm in the picture has intensified—"storm-lashed and terrified." At the very end of the novel, Don's father responds again to the baleful picture:

The thought of going to the club and being stared at by those black and white horses in a storm had sickened him. In a sudden frenzy he had ripped down from the kitchen wall the Jacksons' own copy of the masterpiece and smashed it up. (229)

It is like an exorcism for this cryptic image that haunts the whole tale and is not quite decipherable as a simple, coherent symbol or an allegorical element. It is a bit of atmosphere, a randomized, objective correlative for the stormy, foreboding mood of the story, beneath the comic zaniness.

Although *Came a Hot Friday* is basically a wild, discursive comedy, on the order of P. G. Wodehouse's madcap adventure stories, much of it occurs at night and in such creepy surroundings as the deserted bush, with moonlight and moreporks (owls). Morrieson increases the poignancy of the nutty Te Whakinga Kid by placing him in context, the rundown Maori village of Te Whakinga:

The road ended in Te Whakinga. It might be more apt to say it threw up its hands in horror and disappeared. Te Whakinga had fallen on evil days. The atmosphere was of decay, and melancholy. The houses and whares, arranged to make three sides of a square hemming in a big marae or common, were in a sad state of disrepair. Behind the houses were doorless latrines, tottering like decrepit tombstones and giving the impression of having been moved a few yards to pastures new, time and again. (177)

It is a New Zealand version of "The Deserted Village," a bit of retrospective melancholy and nostalgia for the vanished peasantry from the 1940s, the time when Maori left the land in large numbers for the cities.

Behind the village is further gothic landscape, a dark riverside:

The decimated ranks of ancient bush, all dead, only ghosts of trees, but adopted by alien foliage and lichen, cast shallow pools of unconvincing shadow here and there. The river was very wide. The high cliffs which stood a few hundred yards upstream had dwindled to mere banks of mud. Away in the middle, the water looked swift and deep, but for a long way out from either bank it appeared to be stagnant and treacherously shallow. (181)

It is a *Salvator Rosa* landscape, haunted but artificial, like a stage set for a melodrama, with "ghosts of trees" and "alien foliage" and

"unconvincing shadow." Morrieson wants to underline the shallowness of the gothic trappings, via the shallowness of the dead river.

When the young pakehas and the Te Whakinga Kid cross this river to ambush Sel Bishop, they find themselves in the middle of the night in a cemetery that, ironically, contains the graves of soldiers from Titokowaru's war in the nineteenth century, when pakeha fought Maori for the land of Taranaki province:

Here they had found a row of four yellowing ivy-grown tombstones, sacred to the memory of a family of pioneer settlers. Just above the ledge among the trees a few more old monuments gloomed. A bugler boy, a private, and a sergeant were interred there. The very eeriness of the place had seemed to make an instant appeal to Pennington in his mood of deep dark desperation. (190)

In a tale about a Maori-pakeha coalition against oppression, the ancient graveyard is a paradoxical staging ground for them, one that makes Tui Porano very nervous: "The Kid put up a good show but the whites of his eyes rolling above the mask he had seen fit to don for the adventure gave him away. The intrepid Te Whakinga Kid had his Achilles heel. Old cemeteries at dead-o'-night were not his cup of tea." (190) So Morrieson converts the gothic solemnity to pure Stepin Fetchit farce, to defuse the incipient sentimentality of the pioneer graveyard.

Morrieson's third novel, *Predicament*, is his most thorough foray into comic gothic. The story is set in a large, drafty old house flanked by a gothic folly—a strange tower of irregular, zigzag proportions. Much of it occurs at night, when the young protagonists are trying to perpetrate schemes of blackmail (which misfire and precipitate a gruesome decapitation). One central character is introduced in a scene of farcical horror:

They became aware just when they came within sight of the tower, that they were being followed. Mervyn stopped and took Cedric by the arm. They looked back. Cedric froze. What appeared to be a white disembodied face loomed up out of the darkness. Cedric grabbed at Mervyn. The wine had worn off and his nerves were taut. The floating head

came closer and closer and stopped within a few feet. The white face belonged to a man as thin as a reed and dressed entirely in black.

"Jumping Jimmy Jackson," said Mervyn. "The Spook!" (61–62)

This is an irrational, terrifying moment, the pure gothic feeling, deflated by the rational explanation Mervyn makes:

"His name is Fred Haunt, so you can see where this Spook business started. I don't think the poor devil is the full quid actual. It's childish the way he sneaks up on people in those rubber-sole shoes and tries to scare the tar out of them. He doesn't walk like other people: he's practised a sort of gliding movement. Ever since he got dubbed 'the Spook' at school he's never happy unless he's gumshoeing around in the dark, gliding up to people and standing at their elbow and that sort of thing. It's pathetic. Not that it's not effective. . . . He nearly got himself put away years ago going around at night pressing his nose up against windows. They didn't know whether he was a Peeping Tom or a moron." (63–64)

It is as if Fred Haunt were condemned by fate, by the force of society, to act out a symbolic name. He is an automaton, a witless instrument of terror, whose odd perversion (a combination of double-action voyeurism and sadism—spying on people to frighten them, then observing their reactions of fear) leads inexorably to his violent death.

As well as being a comic-gothic tale, *Predicament* is explicitly an homage to boys' adventure stories, a deliberate metafictional pastiche meant to evoke the world of untrammelled excitement of youthful reading. Cedric, a bookish sort, becomes convinced that he should write literature (so we feel the self-reflexive notion of a character in literature meditating self-consciously on the medium itself):

Cedric picked up the book on the top of the pile and fingered it lovingly. He opened it and smelt the new print and the new paper. Then he stroked the other books. There were

two sets of companion volumes. *The Mystery of Nameless Island* by John Hunter, and *The Quest of the Pirate Gold* by Peter Martin; and, both by Lindsay Thompson, *Blue Brander* and *The Gang on Wheels*. There were also copies of J. B. Priestley's *The Good Companions*; *Very Good, Jeeves* by P. G. Wodehouse, and a *Greyfriars Holiday Annual*. (78)

This is a literary universe of whimsy and adventure. When Cedric begins reading *Huckleberry Finn*, the epitome of the liberating comic-adventure novel, he realizes he should be an author so he can write his own life's direction:

He laid down *Huckleberry Finn*, too happy to read further at the moment. His eyes were misty with happiness. As he had hoped, but had not dared to admit even to himself, the solution of all his problems had stolen softly up to him. Cedric was beginning to respect the machinations of his subconscious more and more with every day that passed. *He would be an author*. It was perfect. His essays at school proved he had a flair for writing. It was a noble ambition. It would bring pleasure to tens of thousands of generations. It fitted in with being "the Professor". . . . On top of all the other blessings, it now occurred to him he would be rich. Everyone knew that authors were simply lousy with money. (109–110)

While Morrieson is gently mocking himself and his naive protagonist, he is also describing the moral and literary universe in which his horrific tale is circumscribed. It is a highly literary excursion within the basically safe world of Huck Finn, Billy Bunter, and Bertie Wooster, all unwitting can-do heroes who are unsophisticated survivors.

The world of Aotearoa gothic, then, is often one of safe horrors and insulated terror. It is full of the thrills and spills of the carnival midway, rollercoaster rides that are carefully checked for security. They are often connected with the process of growing up, with childhood uncertainties and confusions, in which the world of everyday domestic reality can be abruptly infused with fear and disgust. Bruce Mason, in his virtuosic one-man drama *The End of the Golden Weather*,

captures this, describing through a scrim of nostalgia for the 1930s his father's holiday-time family dramatic performance as a mad Jack-the-Ripper doctor:

In bursts my father, swivelling round corners, Chaplin-wise, bowler-hatted, frock-coated, holding a bulging and jingling carpet-bag. He advances on his victim, the light of self-abandoned frenzy in his eye, speaking in a voice of comic heaviness and briskness:

"Come here, come here, come here! Don't like your colour! Looks like a bad case of hydrangea! Put out your tongue!"

He seizes the organ delicately, shakes his head. His eyes gleam with a terrible zeal.

"Oh ho ho ho! This is serious! *Convolvulus* has set in. We must operate at once!"

The victim is hustled off his chair, screaming with laughter and thrown flat on a table; tries to rise, but the mad doctor presses his head. The patient crumples. A fearsome jingling from the carpet-bag.

"Now, now, what's best for the incision? Ah ha! The very thing. My tenon-saw. Don't worry, don't worry! It'll only tickle!"

The victim struggles to sit up: the doctor flattens him with an imperious gesture. He saws furiously, making a ghastly, ticking scratching sound.

"Now that didn't hurt, did it? Stop laughing! Pin back the flaps . . . that's the way. . . . Now we have to dig. Get at the root of the trouble. Where's my garden trowel?"

He drops the saw, seizes the trowel, makes great swooping motions with it.

"Intestines? No use to you. Better without them." He throws them over his head. In horror, we see long loops and festoons of them sailing round the room, lodging on the clocks, hanging on the pictures, whirling round and round the light bracket.

He digs again, ferociously.

"Heart? Lungs? Kidneys? Liver? Useless lumber. Out they go."

He throws them at the wall: we hear a hideous squelch.
He looks down at his patient, benevolently.

"Why, you're looking better already. Now, we'll sew you up. Here's my skewer. Thread it with a piece of string, and away we go!"

He becomes a maddened seamstress, frenziedly sewing, the skewer flying in and out. He dusts his hands, dismisses his patient.

"Go thou, and sin no more."

He bows to us, cold and dignified.

"Adieu. Adieu! Remember me!"

He grabs his carpet-bag, whirls on one leg, stops suddenly.

"What's this on my lapel? A stray kidney? Tt-tt-tt."

He flicks it off with a lordly air and whirls off on some other fearsome errand. (*Bruce Mason Solo* 10–11)

Mason's world is one of childhood theatrics, analogous to Morrieson's world of childhood reading. Both literary activities involve safe adventures, cozily vicarious experience with death and dissolution. Both involve careful limits by literary convention of the actual risks, the materials of the unconscious unleashed. They are connected with the process of maturity, of coming to an understanding of sexuality, personality, mortality. They begin to define the way *unheimlich* becomes *heimlich* in New Zealand literature and culture.

7

Falling through the Hole in the Godzone

I'm not going to write about my family and the house where I live when I'm in Oamaru, the queerest little house I've ever seen, with trees all round it, oaks and willows and silver birches and apple trees that are like a fairy-tale in October, and ducks waggling their legs in the air, and swamp hens in evening dress, navy blue with red at the neck, nice and boogie-woogie, and cats that have kittens without being ethical.

—Janet Frame, “My Last Story”

Fortunately this final story in her first collection, *The Lagoon* (1951), was by no means Janet Frame's last story, and in fact she wrote steadily on the topics she listed, plus many others, in a powerful three-decker autobiography—*To the Is-Land* (1982), *An Angel at My Table* (1984), and *The Envoy from Mirror City* (1984)—one of the century's great feats of imaginative self-description.

The story unfolds as a record of Frame's coping with what may or may not have been genuine mental illness, her cruel mistreatment in the mid-twentieth century (including long periods of electro-convulsive therapy [ECT] and narrowly avoiding a leucotomy), and her long, self-imposed recovery through her art. In many ways it ranks as a harrowing survival tale with the work of Franz Kafka, Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn, Primo Levi, Isak Dinesen, and others who have recorded the sociopolitical upheavals of our time through intensely personal literature. In a long series of stories and novels, all written over nearly fifty years in a spare, idiosyncratic poetic prose, Frame has partici-

pated in international literature by defining a highly specific and local life.

Born in 1924 and raised in the south of the South Island, Frame grew up in rural and small-town New Zealand through the Depression and World War II in a family marked by disasters and disturbances and oppressed by working-class poverty. Her older and younger sisters died unexpectedly while swimming, her brother was plagued by epilepsy, her mother's intense Christadelphian faith was tested, her father's resilience as a railway worker gradually worn down by decades of poverty-line subsistence. Young Jean Frame ("Janet" was a literary adoption) was an introverted, often repressed, girl whose world was haunted by death and loneliness, whose horizons were tightly constricted.

She became aware of problems with knowing who she was and what her life meant early, and typically in her story, she encountered a first clue in reading:

That year I discovered the word *Island*, which in spite of all teaching I insisted on calling Is-Land. In our silent reading class at school, when we chose one of the Whitcombes school readers, those thin, fawn-colored books with crude drawings on the cover and speckled pages, I found a story, *To the Island*, an adventure story that impressed me so much that I talked about it at home.

"I read a story, *To the Is-Land*, about some children going to an Is-Land."

"It's I-Land," Myrtle corrected.

"It's not," I said. "It's Is-Land. It says," I spelled the letters, "I-s-l-a-n-d. Is-land."

"It's a silent letter," Myrtle said. "Like knee."

In the end, reluctantly, I had to accept the ruling, although within myself I still thought of it as the Is-Land. (*To the Is-Land* 41)

The last detail is the significant one: she kept on obstinately adhering to her first imaginative misconception, a pattern of stubborn self-certainty (masked by social insecurity) that defines much of her story.

Thinking about "is-ness" and the land-of-being idea, Frame spent

much of her childhood wrapped in dreams and slightly skewed literature imbibed from random reading. The Land of Is, the perpetual present of childhood consciousness, is the topic of her first volume. One disruptive fact dominating *To the Is-Land* is the omnipresence of death, imaged first in domestic animals and family pets that were casually culled ("cats that have kittens without being ethical"): "We found cat skeletons under the house and sheep and cattle skeletons in the long grass of the bull paddock" (39) and "in the creek the rocks, cockabullies, eels, and the old weighted shredded sacks of drowned kittens and cats" (40); "gradually over the years, the bed of the creek became the resting place of many cats, kittens, pups, not only from us but from neighbors, with now and then, when the sack rotted, a wet cat shape with teeth set in a skeleton snarl, rising to the surface." (52)

Janet Frame's early childhood is death-haunted, with the image of the submerged, underworld animals rising up as accusing revenants reminding that in the midst of life and domesticity was brutal death, the lesson reinforced in human terms when her sisters Myrtle and Isabel died (by water) at the apex of their youths. The family moved often up and down the rail line and finally came to rest at Oamaru, a small harbor city that offered a view of the limitless Pacific to one side and the remote inland mountains to the other. Frame's young life was constricted by these perspectives and by the marginal family economy. However, she got a solid education at the excellent local school, Waitaki, and slowly became conscious of literary stirrings. She became vaguely aware of the possibility of writing and of a context for her imagination when asked to prepare a speech on a favorite writer, and "I felt curious when one member of the class, choosing Katherine Mansfield, was commended by the teacher for choosing a New Zealand writer when none of our English studies even supposed that a New Zealand writer or New Zealand existed." (158) The first volume ends as Frame leaves home for Dunedin, her first largish city, and teacher's training college, being aimed by her teachers and her family toward a career as a schoolteacher, the only genteel professional possibility imaginable for a woman in her time and place.

In the years covered by *An Angel at My Table*, her experience deepened, as did her isolation and dislocation in her culture. The introverted, withdrawn child became a young woman nearly paralyzed

by indecision, fear, and awkwardness. Her fears for her own sanity and her developing self-destructiveness eventually led to her commitment in a psychiatric ward. She began to lose her sense of identity and her connection with others:

My previous community had been my family. In *To the Is-Land* I constantly use the first person plural—we, not I. My time as a student was an I-time. Now, as a Seaciff patient, I was again part of a group, yet more deeply alone, not even a creviced “I”. I became “she”, one of “them”. (70)

This loss of self or confusion of identity and community is a major strand in Frame's story. As in childhood, when she was not wholly aware that either New Zealand literature or even New Zealand “officially” existed, so was she later unclear whether she had a recognized, credentialed identity. The “is-land” she sought was both personal and cultural identity, a sense of being and being known, certainty that the small islands of New Zealand were acknowledged by a wider world. As a person and as a budding writer, Frame teetered on the edge of an abyss of solipsism, with only the slim lifeline of her own words connecting her to social reality.

In her search for friendship, approval, a simple semblance of normal adolescent life, Frame fastened on a young psychology teacher, John Forrest, who offhandedly diagnosed her as schizophrenic. The idea had a powerful effect:

I was playing a game, half in earnest, to win the attention of a likeable young man whose interest was psychology and art; yet in spite of my pretence at hallucinations and visions I was growing increasingly fearful of the likeness between some of my true feelings and those thought of as belonging to sufferers from schizophrenia. I was very shy, within myself. I preferred to write, to explore the world of imagination, rather than to mix with others. I was never withdrawn from the “real” world, however, although I was convincingly able to “use” this symptom when the occasion required. (80)

It is an intriguing story of at least partially self-induced derangement, of a strange state something like *folie à deux* initiated as a romantic ploy by an intense young woman. She became caught in a vortex or a feedback loop, in which her “imaginary” illness was increasingly the world she wholly inhabited, in which the more she pretended the more pretense was verified as reality. It is a perfect metaphor for the self-generating creative imagination and the processes of art, infinitely seductive, the basic “romantic agony” of the art-madness paradox, the self-enclosing and self-defining universe of “lunatics, lovers and poets.”

Clearly aware of the boundaries of her delusive behavior, Frame could not resist the seductive powers it endowed her—the attention and curiosity, the mystery and exoticism her state signaled. She describes her discovery and deployment of the imagery that became her hallmark and that is reflected in the title image in the third volume of her autobiography (*Mirror City*), when she mentions two poems she sent one doctor to convince him of her condition: “I deliberately chose imagery known to be ‘schizophrenic’—glass, mirrors, reflections—in the hope he would get my message.” (131) The mirror-world of fun-house distortions, of “through a glass darkly,” of the kind of twisted crystalline self-images with which Vladimir Nabokov brilliantly endowed his mad novelist John Kinbote/Botkin in *Pale Fire*, is the context for Janet Frame’s young adulthood. The transparent glasslike fragility of her psychic state is also like the mind of wistful Laura in Tennessee Williams’ classic study of anomie, *The Glass Menagerie*.

In one of her first attempts to treat the experience at Seacliff as art, Frame wrote *Faces in the Water* (1961), a “documentary novel” following a narrator named Istina Mavet (weird name!) through many episodes and thoughts we also find in the autobiography. At one point, the narrator realizes she does not want to leave the institution and uses the dislocated, surreal imagery of Frame’s pseudo-schizophrenia:

I dreamed of the world because it seemed the accepted thing
to do, because I could not bear the thought that not all
prisoners dream of freedom; the prospect of the world terri-
fied me: a morass of despair violence death with a thin layer

of glass spread upon the surface where Love, a tiny crab with pincers and rainbow shell, walked delicately ever sideways but getting nowhere, while the sun—like one of those woolly balls we made at occupational therapy by winding orange wool on a circle of cardboard—rose higher in the sky its tassels dropping with flame threatening every moment to melt the precarious highway of glass. (38)

Istina also perceives the universe as a form of demented music, an incomprehensible concert performed by the asylum inmates for her benefit:

their violent orchestration of unreason that seemed like a new kind of music of curse and cry with the undertones of silence flowing from the quiet ones, the curled-up, immovable and nameless; and the movement was a ballet, and the choreographer was Insanity; and the whole room seemed like a microfilm of atoms in prison dress revolving and voyaging, if that were possible, in search of their lost nucleus. (90)

The music becomes cosmography, the “music of the spheres” on both a micro- and a macrolevel, so the great world is built up from atoms of mad music, a remarkably intricate set of concentric metaphors, almost a metaphysical conceit.

For some eight years Frame was incarcerated and treated (with hundreds of separate ECT sessions), and the brutal world of primitive mental wards became another set of private visions nearly impossible to communicate to others. Everything in her life conspired to drive her into closed, private universes, solipsistic infernos, black holes with gravity so intense no words could escape to everyday places like Dunedin and Oamaru. The hospital became the whole world, and madness was accepted as “normal.” Life became a continuous process of “adjustment” to the realities of the institution: “The act of ‘settling in’ was surrounded with approval: ‘the sooner you “settle” the sooner you’ll be allowed home’ was the ruling logic; and ‘if you can’t adapt yourself to living in a mental hospital how do you expect to be able to live “out in the world”?’ How indeed?” (*Faces in the Water* 42)

On one visit home, she could only describe the institutional world in children's story terms, simplistic images—"It's like a whole village"—rather than the detailed reality:

I didn't tell them how I had peeped through the fence of a building called Simla, away upon the hill, where there were strange men in striped shirts and trousers and some without trousers, walking round and round in a paddock with the grass worn away; and how I'd seen a paddock of women, too, wearing the dark blue striped clothes; and how there was a cart, like a rickshaw, that passed every day by the ward, how it was full of coal and two men harnessed to the cart carried the coal, driven by one of the attendants; how, curious as ever, I had peered into a room that stank of urine and was full of children lying in cots, strange children, some of them babies, making strange noises; their faces wet with tears and snot. (*Angel at My Table* 71)

It is a vision from Dante or from the Holocaust, one so horrible that no outsider, no one except a fellow inmate-survivor, could ever really understand it except as a mad, schizophrenic picture, the disordered imaginings of a mind diseased.

The world itself conspired to reinforce the self-diagnosis of schizophrenia, to accept readily Frame's own spiritual void as a social condition. Treatment simply conditioned Frame to "be" schizophrenic, behaving in accordance with the world's wishes:

After having received over two hundred applications of unmodified ECT, each the equivalent, in degree of fear, to an execution, and in the process having my memory shredded and in some aspects weakened permanently or destroyed, and after having been subjected to proposals to have myself changed, by a physical operation, into a more acceptable, amenable, normal person, I arrived home at Willowglen, outwardly smiling and calm, but inwardly with all confidence gone, with the conviction that I was officially a non-person. (109)

Like the most brutal totalitarian state, the regimen of therapeutic treatment aims to erase personality, to cancel individualism, to turn the "I" into an "it." Frame's language is that of the gulags, of "internal exile," of "reconstruction" and "reeducation." Her story is somehow a typical one of the 1950s everywhere, of the twentieth century's irresistible need to smooth out social wrinkles, to suppress deviance, to subordinate the ego to the crowd.

The climax of the terrible ordeal is one of the great hairbreadth escapes of contemporary literature: as she was about to undergo a leucotomy (which severs portions of the brain and makes the patient permanently docile and tractable, weatherless and emotionally empty), the Christchurch newspaper carried the story of the literary award given her collection of stories, *The Lagoon*, which deflected the doctors from the operation. Frame reports it emotionally: "It was my writing that at last came to my rescue. It is little wonder that I value writing as a way of life when it actually saved my life." (106) It was as if a part of her own past, her previous life as a functioning literary artist, had projected itself forward and plucked her from the "loony bin," from the frozen, immobile hell of the present that was her "schizophrenic" persona.

If *To the Is-Land* was the story of the child Janet Frame discovering the force of death and dissolution, *An Angel at My Table* deals with life-in-death and another form of dissolution—loss of self, the drowning of identity. The story is a resurrection tale, a report from beyond this life, so that the angel image (borrowed from her mother's Christadelphian faith) is central. The following years were times of healing and escape from the experience, when she moved from presumed insanity to her identity as a writer. She received a government travel grant, which allowed her to go to Europe, but first she was interviewed:

This was to be the beginning, after my known length of stay in hospital, of a number of investigations of my sanity by people who would try to find out for themselves whether I was incurably ill as the medical diagnosis would imply, or whether (as was later proved during my time in London) there had been an awful mistake even in my first admission to hospital, and from then a continued misinterpretation of my plight. (177)

Janet Frame left New Zealand, scarred victim of that “awful mistake,” seeking healing and further knowledge of what her “plight” truly might be.

The conclusion of the trilogy, *The Envoy from Mirror City*, probes her youth and the beginning of her career as an internationally regarded modern writer. On arriving in London in 1956, after a harrowing month at sea, Frame found that a letter reserving accommodations had not reached its destination, and she was alone, without contacts and without shelter in a city larger than any she had known or imagined, across the world from her home. The memory prompts the key image of the book, an expanding emblem of her new identity as a working writer:

For a moment the loss of the letter I had written seemed to be unimportant beside the fictional gift of the loss as if within every event lay a reflection reached only through the imagination and its various servant languages, as if, like the shadows in Plato’s cave, our lives and the world contain mirror cities revealed to us by our imagination, the Envoy. (19)

Her grant is designated for travel overseas to broaden her experience, and she has taken this as an artistic credo—she is storing up memory and experience, to be transformed into fiction by the alchemy of creative imagination. The trope she chooses is a version of Plato’s myth of the chained prisoners in the cave’s shadows versus the world of reality but drawn from Frame’s “schizophrenic” imagery of glass and mirrors, the imagination a servant of experience, which is a kind of mirror gazing. The key idea resonates through the story, as when she first arrives in Ibiza, where she plans to think and write, and sees the view from her window: “My bedroom was large and airy with a wide window overlooking the harbour and the distant shore where the buildings lay like those of another city, a sea or mirror city reflected in the clear water.” (56) Later she realizes that the physical image she sees is allegorical, standing for a more profound vision: “I looked each day at the city mirrored in the sea, and one day I walked around the harbour road to the opposite shore where the real city lay that I knew only as the city in the sea, but I felt as if I were trying to

walk behind a mirror, and I knew that whatever the outward phenomenon of light, city, and sea, the real mirror city lay within as the city of imagination." (66)

Her experience of travel was often painful, but she collected important realizations about herself, her experience of the world in New Zealand, and the reality of human life around the planet. She finds that "God's Own Country" is not a unique concept but a feeling of home ownership common to all cultures. First she encounters it in a pesky Irish acquaintance: "The Republic of Ireland, he said, was God's Own Country and it was full of poverty. I thought, surprised, 'But isn't New Zealand God's Own Country?' It hadn't occurred to me that other countries, perhaps every country, made this claim." (23) Later she finds that the Spanish echo the thought:

I tried to give the impression that New Zealanders were unlike the rest of the world in being clean, pure, unprejudiced, well disposed toward all members of the human race. And New Zealand was a beautiful country. It was *God's Own Country*.

Fermin understood. He frowned. Ibiza, he said, was also *God's Own Country*. (55-56)

Frame is absorbing a healthy experience of the simultaneous similarity and difference of people from widely varied cultures. She is moving outside the closed and claustrophobic room of fun-house mirrors, her pseudo-schizophrenia.

The story describes Frame's evolving sense of herself as an artist, as one saved by words and literature. At first, she reverts to the romanticism of her "madness":

Although I was still inclined to cherish the distorted "privilege" of having schizophrenia because it allied me with the great artists more readily than my attempts to produce works of art might have done, I suspected that my published writing might destroy that tenuous alliance, for I could not people, everlastingly, my novels with characters suffering from the "Ophelia syndrome" with details drawn from my observations in hospital. I knew that the Ophelia

syndrome is a poetic fiction that nevertheless usefully allows a writer to explore varieties of otherwise unspoken or unacceptable feelings, thoughts, and language. (105)

In London she underwent extensive medical-psychiatric examinations and was declared not schizophrenic. The finding evoked an ambiguous response, another large truth to learn:

The loss was great. At first, the truth seemed to be more terrifying than the lie. Schizophrenia, as a psychosis, had been an accomplishment, removing ordinary responsibility from the sufferer. I was bereaved. I was ashamed. How could I ask for help directly when there was "nothing wrong with me"? (116)

In her mid-thirties, she begins to experience the painfully ambiguous reality of normal adult life for the first time ("I'd had the years of my twenties removed from my life" [97]).

One standard debate about art and the mind since the Romantic period has revolved around the relationship between creativity and madness, the way the imagination demands violent energy and disorder as a fuel while the everyday mind demands calm, stability, and consistency. In the 1950s, exactly when Janet Frame was undergoing her crucifixion of therapy, literary critic Lionel Trilling meditated extensively on the paradoxes of these conflicting demands. He was responding to Edmund Wilson's famous discussion of "the wound and the bow," the idea that artistic creativity is a divine curse, a psychic wound that damages the artist while gifting humanity with the profound products and insights of art.

Trilling described basic differences between the seemingly "mad" creations of the visionary artist and the prosaic madness of ordinary neuroses or psychoses. The first difference is that "the poet is in command of his fantasy, while it is exactly the mark of the neurotic that he is possessed by his fantasy." (45) Young Janet Frame spent long years of her early life learning to tame and command the "fantasy" that was given her as a developing writer. Trilling also suggested that the adoption of a mask of madness is a symbiotic process of both writers and readers, that both collude in, benefit from, and are complicit in maintaining the "madness" as a guise or robe of office:

The myth of the sick artist, we may suppose, has established itself because it is of advantage to the various groups who have one or another relation with art. To the artist himself the myth gives some of the ancient powers and privileges of the idiot and the fool, half-prophetic creatures, or of the mutilated priest. . . . [T]he myth has its advantage for the philistine—a double advantage. On the one hand, the belief in the artist's neuroticism allows the philistine to shut his ears to what the artist says. But on the other hand it allows him to listen. . . . If he did not want to listen at all, he would say "insane"; with "neurotic," which hedges, he listens when he chooses. (163–164)

This ambiguity or selectivity of understanding was true of Frame's own self-understanding and probably true of many readers who discovered her early works. They were at once reading the work of a "madwoman" and a powerful artist, depending on how they wished to understand her energetic and disturbing language.

In concluding his discussions of art, neurosis, and psychosis, Trilling makes a statement directly applicable to Frame's early fiction and the confessional remembrances in her autobiography: "It would be impossible to deny that whatever disease or mutilation the artist may suffer is an element of his production which has its effect on every part of it, but disease and mutilation are available to us all—life provides them with prodigal generosity. What marks the artist is his power to shape the material of pain we all have." (175) The "material of pain" shaped Frame's early life and work in a distinctive and indelible way. The slow journey from her neurotically adopted pseudopsychosis to wholeness came through the therapy and cleansing of her writing, not through the brutal instruments of the doctors and hospitals whose cures were in fact the source of much pain. As she writes, she begins to see on the pages the face that is truly her own.

This discovery of the double nature of her disorder—the way it has been both a crucifixion and a fortress—is directly allied to her burst of literary creativity, the outpouring of fictions that came a decade after her first publications. As she struggles to write again in London, she is worried that she has lost her identity as a working author: "I was reluctant to say the title for so much had happened since the book had been written and published that I was beginning to think of

it as disintegrating, dissolving, and soon it would be nothing. Although I knew that words and ideas and their expression may disappear, I had not realized the fragility of a published book." (121) Her use of passive voice here ("book had been written") marks the tenuousness of her identity as a writer, as a living, breathing "active voice." It is as if that Janet Frame, who wrote that book years before, were someone else. What she discovers, in her London treatments, is that she was never schizophrenic, but that "my life had been erased, almost, by expert bullying while I played the role of victim that like any other repeated role, resists a change." (144)

Her story records a succession of "bullies" who took a shy, passive girl-woman under their "care": her father; John Forrest the psychology teacher; fussy author Frank Sargeson (who taught her the discipline of writing in his "army hut" at Takapuna, almost like a stint in the military, "boot camp" for little Janet); landlord Patrick Reilly in London, a self-appointed moral guardian; various landlords in Spain and Andorra, all of whom treated her as a helpless "patient," as did the doctors and nurses in the psychiatric wards. From the middle of her childhood, she had developed a hopeless-helpless persona, a needy self-characterization to which certain other types responded, mostly men of authority (or who aspired to authority), for whom the awkward, self-abnegating, and essentially "disabled" Janet Frame was an ideal pupil/patient/child/victim. She found the counterparts she needed to complete herself in the closed world of confusion and pain in which she had grown comfortable.

She escapes the self-assigned role of mirror-world-entrapped victim, but she has accrued a literary reputation of some complexity, which includes the ominous and titillating entry "schizophrenic": "now that my books were being published there was a constant reference to me as 'unbalanced, insane' with a tendency to ally this to my writing and even make it a reason and explanation for my writing." (165) This realization leads her to leave Europe for New Zealand, to come back to her native ground and find her past there in its reality, not through the glistening self-delusions in the glass universe of "schizophrenia."

When she left New Zealand and said goodbye to her father, he amazed her by using what was once a common Kiwi locution, referring to Europe or Britain as "home":

"So you're going home," he said.

I was startled. I had never heard him call the northern hemisphere home; he had usually laughed at people who still talked of the United Kingdom as *Home*; I had heard him say scornfully, "Home, my foot. Here's home right here. Or I'll go hopping sideways to Puketeraki." (*Angel at My Table* 188)

She found one kind of home in Spain and England, but the result of her self-education as a writer was that "home" meant New Zealand in a profound way she had not recognized before.

The return to New Zealand was a voyage of discovery and exploration more challenging than the trip to Europe. Frame describes it in highly charged language: "the first layer of imagination mapped by the early inhabitants leaves those who follow an access or passage-way to the bone. Living in New Zealand would be for me, like living in an age of mythmakers; with a freedom of imagination among all the artists because it is possible to begin at the beginning and know the unformed places and to help to form them, to be a mapmaker for those who will follow." (166) Returning to New Zealand in 1964, Frame won a literary fellowship that took her back to Dunedin and the University of Otago, where she had first broken down, where John Forrest helped convince her that she had the Romantic disorder, the "schizophrenia" that marked such self-destructive Romantic artists as Vincent van Gogh and Hugo Wolf.

In this circle of return and homecoming, she reaches a place from which to develop and extend her creative life. She closes the autobiography with a small interior dialogue, a discussion between herself and her imagination, the Envoy:

"That's Dunedin. I was born there. Let me write of my life there, how I made friends and wrote books, how I went north to live by the sea, how I moved to other cities with other clouds and skies."

"You say it's Dunedin? It's Mirror City. You know it's time to pack this collection of years for your journey to Mirror City." (191)

And so the end becomes the beginning, and we have completed a great circle to watch Janet Frame prepare to write the expanding story of her life that began some 500-odd pages earlier with "From the first place of liquid darkness, within the second place of air and light, I set down the following record with its mixture of facts and truths and memories of truths and its direction always toward the Third Place, where the starting point is myth." (*To the Is-Land* 9)

From this point in her life, Janet Frame went on to write a remarkable series of books that made her the best-known living New Zealand author. Her work is the testimony to her own courage and fortitude, and it is also a tribute to the culture of her country, which has supported and encouraged the long, productive career that followed the tragedy of her youth.

8

Aotearoa at the Movies

When the New Zealand film industry re-emerged from its slumber in the late seventies it turned first for its dreams to traditional Kiwi male themes: mates on the road (*Sleeping Dogs*, *Goodbye Pork Pie*); women as sluts or prudes (*Skin Deep*); men alone (*Bad Blood*, *Beyond Reasonable Doubt*, *Smash Palace*). But by the 1990s, when the industry achieved international success, the images had been transformed. Now the Kiwi male was presented as a violent domestic abuser (*Once Were Warriors*), and other films featured camp esthetics (*Desperate Remedies*) and women in leading roles (*The Piano*, *Heavenly Creatures*). Sam Neill, who had first made his name as a macho hero of *Sleeping Dogs*, reappeared in his own documentary about the New Zealand film industry (*Cinema of Unease*) as a sensitive liberal intellectual.

—Jock Phillips, *A Man's Country?*

Although pioneer cinematographers made New Zealand films from the 1920s onward, as movies became a worldwide medium of communication, a major film industry did not develop until the 1970s. Documentaries and theatrical films were made, New Zealand was an exciting and exotic setting for a few Hollywood movies, but only after the age of television was well advanced (national TV broadcasting began in 1961) did an indigenous film industry develop, and then

slowly and modestly. (Two useful references on New Zealand cinema are Jonathan Dennis and Jan Bieringa, eds., *Film in Aotearoa New Zealand* [Wellington: Victoria University Press, 1992], and Nicholas Reid, *A Decade of New Zealand Film* [Dunedin: John McIndoe, 1986].) A number of recent New Zealand films, many now available on videotape, give important insights into the country and its culture.

This is not an exhaustive listing, focused as it is on dramatic works made for theatrical release and excluding fine made-for-TV works and a long list of exceptional documentaries. Films included might bring a mental traveler insights into the land, people, traditions, and meaning of the culture. Films are listed by director and date of release.

Films on Legend and History

An Angel at My Table, Jane Campion (1990). A faithful and dramatic cinematic realization of Janet Frame's autobiography. Gives a sweeping review of New Zealand in the second two quarters of the twentieth century and makes Frame's poetic vision of the world graphic.

Bad Blood, Mike Newell (1981). A dramatic but responsible retelling of the manhunt for Stanley Graham in 1942, one of New Zealand's most notorious mass-murder stories and an archetype for the Man Alone myth (as comprehensively discussed in Lawrence Jones, *Barbed Wire and Mirrors*, part 3).

Carry Me Back, John Reid (1982). A gentle comedy on the New Zealand obsession with rugby football and the committed fans of the game, set in urban Wellington and the rural South Island.

The End of the Golden Weather, Ian Mune (1992). A film adaptation of the classic one-man drama by Bruce Mason, lovingly embalming the summer beach culture of 1930s Auckland in quirky nostalgia.

Footrot Flats: The Dog's Tale, Murray Ball (1986). An animated feature version of the immensely popular cult cartoon depicting rural New Zealand from the point of view of a working border collie, in a landscape peopled by basic Kiwi comic stereotypes.

- Heavenly Creatures*, Peter Jackson (1994). A fictional rendering in a baroque surrealistic style of a major murder case from 1950s Christchurch, featuring intense psychological drama rendered through sophisticated computer-animation techniques.
- Illustrious Energy*, Leon Narbey (1988). A moody, abstract depiction of Chinese gold miners in central Otago in the mid-nineteenth century. Gives poetic insights into the conditions of immigrant labor and the alien qualities of the barren high plains.
- Make All Fair*, John Reid (1985). A controversial dramatization of the Katherine Mansfield–Middleton Murray relationship, which makes Murray a heartless Svengali to Mansfield's helpless Trilby. Rejected even by unswerving feminists.
- The Navigator: A Medieval Odyssey*, Vincent Ward (1988). A highly imaginative quasi allegory of plague and exploration, notable for imaginative blending of medieval Europe and modern New Zealand, as explorers bore through the earth in search of redemption.
- Ngati*, Barry Barclay (1987). An evocative rendering of Maori culture in rural New Zealand after World War II and the beginnings of cultural pride and solidarity among young Maori. Tackles questions of racism and personal identity.
- The Piano*, Jane Campion (1994). Widely acclaimed poetic version of the white settlement of New Zealand, with sidelights on male and female views on possession and domination as European cultural practices. The big-league cast includes Sam Neill, Harvey Keitel, and Holly Hunter.
- Starlight Hotel*, Sam Pillsbury (1988). A nostalgic, slightly sentimental view of Depression New Zealand through the eyes of a man and an adolescent girl on the tramp. Set in Oamaru's white city and central Otago, a Steinbeckian tale of survival.
- Utu*, Geoff Murphy (1983). A ground-breaking dramatization of the New Zealand Wars as a "revisionist Western," dealing with Maori views and values and the brutal pakeha seizure of lands. Violent and often exaggerated, it depicts in detail frontier conditions of the 1850s and 1860s.

Vigil, Vincent Ward (1985). A poetic black-and-white psychodrama of back-blocks living, in the shadowy, nearly wordless style of Tarkovsky or Bresson. Oblique but engrossing study of a few characters in a desolate place.

Films on the “New” New Zealand

Brain Dead, Peter Jackson (1992). A mischievously ghoulish horror-comedy, with comic stereotypes and ingenious special effects, fully exploiting New Zealand gothic.

Goodbye Pork Pie, Geoff Murphy (1981). A pioneering road comedy that traverses New Zealand from Auckland to Invercargill in a wild, slapstick car chase involving a bright yellow minicar and three bizarre, pot-smoking retro-hippies. Affectionately funny.

Mauri, Merata Mita (1988). A dramatic study of modern Maori culture, from the inside, shown elliptically and mystically. Vivid characterizations and locations. A useful complement to *Ngati* (above).

Once Were Warriors, Lee Tamahori (1994). Highly acclaimed study of Maori life in the urban ghetto, including violence and intractable conflicts following the collapse of traditional family-tribal values. A powerful Maori cast, strong script, and high-energy direction.

Patu, Merata Mita (1983). A riveting documentary on the protests and police responses to the 1981 tour of the South African rugby team in New Zealand. Cinema vérité/propaganda handled in an intensely dramatic form.

Ruby and Rata, Gaylene Preston (1990). A quirky comic study of young and old New Zealanders in conflict and in cooperation. Insightful rendering of contemporary culture and its reflection in nostalgia for a simpler, safer world.

Smash Palace, Roger Donaldson (1982). Another study of a New Zealand macho obsession—cars and racing—and the corrosion of marriage and family. Powerful performances and intensely realized settings.

Ronald Hugh Morrieson on Film

Two of Morrieson's best works were lovingly transferred to film in versions that are careful cinematic homages to his style and feeling and also effective films in their own right. Both capture the cinematic qualities in Morrieson's writing and are masterly comedies. (His unfinished sketch for a novel, *Pallet on the Floor*, was also filmed [1986] in a version as unsatisfactory as the manuscript itself.)

Sam Pillsbury's *The Scarecrow* (1982) conveys the nostalgic, naive qualities of the novel and features the ancient but infallibly creepy character actor John Carradine as the monstrous knifeman-prestidigitator. Ian Mune's *Came a Hot Friday* (1985) is equally meticulous in bringing Morrieson to film. It features the brilliant performance of the late Maori stand-up comedian Billy T. James as Tui Porano, with evocative settings and a host of excellent character actors. Both films capture the period qualities of Morrieson's stories and his obsessive interests in small-town vices and foibles, and both are swiftly paced comic adventure tales.

These two films convey both the iconic affection for Morrieson's work and the attention to detail and setting characteristic of New Zealand cinema. The land itself, along with houses, farms, highways, often is a major player in these films, focused by an idiosyncratic sense of place. The persuasive verisimilitude of film drama is a cultural medium for self-definition, and the open landscape and dramatic settings become both defining and limiting. The ideas of a "magic landscape" and New Zealand Picturesque as a visual mode have become such cultural clichés that many New Zealand filmmakers have consciously rebelled and deliberately restricted the horizons of their films, using tightly composed and focused scenes, deliberately muted colors (by way of filters), antipicturesque devices.

Morrieson's stories give directors Pillsbury and Mune scope to depict these cultural attitudes along with all his Kiwi stereotype characters. The two films show interestingly unselfconscious views of small-town life and lower-middle-class families. They also show how imagination transforms and enlivens existences of otherwise cheerless uniformity. They deal with risk, daring, adventure, gambling, bending the rules and constraints of everyday existence in a self-restricted, slightly timid, slightly puritanical society. The movies con-

vey Morrieson's bawdy exuberance, love of language, and buoyantly hyperactive imagination.

Aotearoa New Zealand and the Postmodern Sublime

The landscape and images of New Zealand in films are as impressive and moving as those created by novelists and poets. The big screen lights up with mountain gloom and mountain glory, with the roll of hills and ubiquitous sentinel peaks at the horizon, piercing the clouds. A repeated theme in literature that cannot be avoided by the movie camera's open eye is the conflicting feelings of grandeur and loneliness, of beauty and foreboding in this topography. Filmmaking in New Zealand has been a challenge, to keep the human stories in scale with the landscape, to prevent the sheer physical beauty from overwhelming the drama. The large, empty landscapes are like blank canvases—or more like palimpsests or Rorschach tests. We want to project our narratives onto them, to make the majestic backdrops consonant with the small, quotidian dramas that create the realism of cinema.

In eighteenth-century England, at the apogee of neoclassicism's orderly reign, Edmund Burke formulated his idea of the Sublime, a complex feeling engendered by experiences with nature. He pursued an experience commonly felt in grand landscapes, the sense of magnificence or awe that is tempered by unease, by shadings of fear. It is the radically unsettling feeling of looking down a precipitous chasm or up at a towering pinnacle, the double feeling of exhilaration and vertigo that draws thousands to the quintessential New Zealand fad of bungee jumping, the horrific nanosecond of free fall, flirting with death on the end of a barely adequate elastic safety line. The fall reminds us of the precious fragility of life. Burke pronounced "terror . . . the ruling principle of the sublime." (109) New Zealand cinema often takes us on metaphorical bungee dives, abrupt plunges from the merely picturesque to the fatal, a retreat from the esthetic pieties of travelogue-style panoramas to death viewed close up.

Neoclassicism put Beauty at the center of its cosmos—a complex esthetic-ethical conception of grace, proportion, symmetry, and elegance that could be measured and replicated by the artist. The classi-

cal ethos celebrated civilization, the state, the careful ordering of humans into cities and states, into a sheltering human-made environment. This is the core cosmic virtue of Euclid, Archimedes, and Pythagoras, the magic of number, the "science" of numerology. But by Burke's time toward the end of the eighteenth century (decades when Captain James Cook was mapping the Pacific and circumnavigating New Zealand), the Sublime was ascendant, a new Romantic sensibility embodied in it.

John Keats, at the turning axis of Romantic poetry in the years when New Zealand was settled by itinerant whalers, sailors, and merchants, set Beauty at the focus of his most profound tribute to classicism, "Ode on a Grecian Urn." There the stasis of the classical order is celebrated, its eternal verity and permanence. Keats' "storied urn" (it speaks its own narrative) is an artifact, a pot thrown into symmetry by the centrifugal forces of the wheel, like motion itself caught and frozen forever. Its story, however, is of Nature—a forest in Arcadia, a "flowery tale" recorded by a "Sylvan historian"—in a perpetual springtime. But it is also a "Cold Pastoral," caught and recorded there, not living human passion, even though its meaning is composed of unheard melodies of "soft pipes," which enunciate the final insight of the poem: "'Beauty is truth, truth beauty.'"

The Sublime, in contrast to this decorous "sacrifice" depicted on the urn of classicism, is raw nature itself unmediated, experienced directly by our senses. William Blake, a London poet (like Keats) of Captain Cook's generation, felt the sinister power of the Sublime when he wrote, "Great things are done when Men & Mountains meet; / This is not done by Jostling in the Street." Away from the classical city, from the order of civilization, nature waits to act upon us, to transform us, the Romantics said.

In our century, cinema has transported us into nature via the stream of flickering images that knit themselves into continuous motion by grace of our optic nerves, the phenomenon of persistence of vision. The process is a typical twentieth-century synthesis of nature (the subject) and technology (the medium) into that multiple message—"the medium is the message"—that Marshall McLuhan postulated. The images chosen by New Zealand's film industry as it developed in the 1970s were of cities and urban life (as in *Sleeping*

Dogs, Patu, Once Were Warriors) and of boundless nature (as in *Utu, Vigil, Bad Blood*).

The demographic truth in the 1990s is that most New Zealanders live in cities, towns, villages, or suburban enclaves. The empty beach, high plains, bush, mountains, and wild rivers are images from the deep pioneer past, for holidays and nostalgia. But the instant *accessibility* of nature is an important fact, a psychological pressure on the culture like the force of gravity or the atmosphere. Mountains and sea are almost always in sight. You can stroll easily from the heart of urban New Zealand into dense bush.

Images in film convey oxymorons of "tamed wilderness" or "civilized nature," as in *Once Were Warriors*, when we see a six-lane highway that slashes through the city and forms both an entrance to and a barrier around the Maori ghetto. The same image recurs in *The Navigator*, when the medieval English time-travelers try to cross the Auckland thoroughway at night. In reality, this highway is a short bit of freeway transecting the city, only a dozen miles of what Americans would recognize as "interstate highway" and expect to see unrolling for literally *thousands* of miles. In New Zealand, this segment of six-lane road has become a metaphor for the whole paved-over modern world beyond these islands.

The Sublime conveys a "pleasing terror" or a synthesis of pleasure and pain, the unsettling sensation of looking off a high precipice, feeling the tug of gravity, the disorientation of vertigo intermingled with exhilaration, the upward pull of soaring and self-transcendence. New Zealand's modern films build on this radically mixed emotion, this *discordia concors* of sensation. In them, we follow a rapid course of beauty inextricably blended with fear and disquiet.

In *Goodbye Pork Pie*, the naively anarchistic central character, who has been traversing New Zealand from north to south in a disintegrating minicar, is abruptly killed in the final reel, run over on the highway in a version of poetic justice. In *Heavenly Creatures*, the mad teenage girls commit murder at a scenic overlook outside Christchurch, beating the matronly mother to death with a sock-wrapped stone at a vista upon which most tourists would exclaim "How glorious, what a stupendous view!" If we shift our view from the mountains and valleys, from the sea sparkling in the distance, we see mud and blood. Films sometimes combine the experiences of squalor and

uplift, as in *The Piano*, which intercuts the muck and incessant rain of the deep bush with rapturous open cycloramas of sea and surf, all pulsing with highly romantic piano music. At the center of the film is a conflict between stiff-corseted Victorian culture and naked Edenic nature, the imported self-repression of the colonists filmed against tangled and irrepressible jungle. And in *Once Were Warriors*, the cinematographers subverted the inherent picturesque splendor of the landscape by using yellow filters, by mocking nature as an advertising billboard (the famous opening shot), by using claustrophobic interiors and an urban ghetto of junked cars, empty lots, superhighways, and mean streets. To keep the story sharply focused on the family tragedy at its center, the filmmakers must manacle and straitjacket the landscape, mute it, discolor it, keep us from feeling the uplift and awe that is half of the Sublime.

In early Hollywood, filmmakers discovered the unlimited grandeur of Monument Valley and other western vistas, and the cowboy movie became a staple genre. These films worked out small, violent, and mundane tales against the sweep of arid valleys and remote rocky peaks. The scenery itself conferred a dignity, a tragic scale to the hackneyed tales. The same interplay of foreground (human) and background (nature) works in New Zealand cinema, to show a small land as a grand, sweeping landscape, to magnify and uplift the subjects of the movies. The clichéd feeling of "Godzone" as a "pretty picture," the merely picturesque sensation, is overcome by making the landscape an object of fear and apprehension—or by blocking it out with cityscapes, the closed spaces of urban modernity. Aotearoa Postmodern Sublime, as expressed in films of the past twenty years, is a way of bringing together the feelings of the traditional categories, of making a synergy from pain and pleasure, as Edmund Burke felt it:

Sublime objects are vast in their dimensions, beautiful ones comparatively small; beauty should be smooth and polished; the great rugged and negligent; beauty should shun the right line, yet deviate from it insensibly; the great in many cases loves the right line; and when it deviates, it often makes a strong deviation; beauty should not be obscure; the great ought to be dark and gloomy; beauty should be light and delicate; the great ought to be solid,

and even massive. They are indeed ideas of a very different nature, one being founded on pain, the other on pleasure. (172)

New Zealand at the movies sees this synthesis of great and delicate, of dark and light in the films that have marked its recent culture.

Haka—Noble and Sentimental

A central icon in New Zealand literature and film has been the Maori, the Polynesian Other poised as a balance to the European (pakeha) Intruder. The figure that recurs is of the mid-nineteenth-century Maori, clad in cast-off frock coat and beaver hat, bustled Victorian gown, the abandoned glad rags of the settlers. The pakeha has flung aside the formalities of the parlor for moleskins and corduroys, while the “savage” has dressed up from flax and feathers to crinoline and taffeta.

This image occurs in the excellent nineteenth-century portraits by Gottfried Lindauer and Charles Frederick Goldie. It peoples *The Piano* and *Utu*. It recurs in Maurice Shadbolt’s New Zealand Wars trilogy, in Wedde’s *Symmes Hole*. It is the figure first captured by Melville in *Moby Dick*’s Queequeg, as he burst onto the world stage:

Good heavens! what a sight! Such a face! It was of a dark, purplish, yellow color, here and there stuck over with large, blackish looking squares. . . . He now took off his hat—a new beaver hat, when I came nigh singing out with fresh surprise. There was no hair on his head—none to speak of at least—nothing but a small scalp-knot twisted up on his forehead. (115)

The “savage in finery” is a way we see in visual metaphor the transformation of the Maori from “natives” half-clad in flax and feathers to civilized people decently shrouded by missionaries and settlers in the constricting, dark, heavy garb of Queen Victorian’s golden days.

This figure is one softened by sentimentality. A way to view this clothed Maori is as “nature’s gentleman (and lady),” the truly noble savage who has a Rousseauesque sensitivity to nature and to human-

ity. Pakeha survivors of the New Zealand Wars commented on the bravery and chivalry of the Maori, their battlefield etiquette and heroism. They became "worthy" adversaries by being endowed with classical virtues, as the romance-writer in Shadbolt's *The House of Strife* must make them Trojans in a new *Iliad*. To find meaning in the terror and squalor of frontier New Zealand, the Maori must become like the Vanishing Redman of the United States, a figure nostalgic, tamed, civilized, made familiar and lovable. The last alien bit of Maoriness is rubbed away by those who today feel that New Zealand has become a perfectly egalitarian state, that the Maori have been wholly assimilated and blended into the mix of culture, melted in the melting pot as blubber was once liquefied in the whalers' tryworks.

But the Maori Renaissance of the past generation has insisted on and underscored the essential Otherness of Maori culture and revealed the continuity of traditional beliefs and practices, the survival of ancient beliefs and family and tribal structures beneath the surface of presumed homogenous Europeanizing mainstream society. Continued controversy over the Treaty of Waitangi and its historical and contemporary implications has kept the figure of the unassimilated, rebellious Maori vivid in the public imagination. The whole culture has been forced to reexamine and discard comfortable assumptions and stereotypes. Aotearoa New Zealand, as the double name implies, thinks of itself as a multicultural society at the end of the twentieth century and is self-conscious—both troubled and hopeful—about the implications of this concept.

Every New Zealander is familiar with some bits of Maori culture—the songs and dances from the concert parties, the *haka* as practiced by the All Blacks (national rugby football team) and others. The *haka* is variously described as a "war dance" or an "action song." To European sensibilities it seems a curious synthesis of chant, cheer-leading, and balletic gymnastics, all vividly expressive of warlike ferocity. But the *haka* is part of the complex musico-literary traditions of the Maori, probably closer to poetry (think of epic in its original orally transmitted form) than to "dance." The expressiveness of the body is joined to the expressiveness of language, and facial and bodily gesture become as prominent as vocal inflection or cadence.

The ritualistic, stately quality of *haka*, with its ceremonial and repetitive gestures, the droning chant, the lilt of language intertwined

with foot stamping, chest slapping, eye rolling, and tongue-wagging expressions makes it a profoundly un-European experience. It is hard to shrug off, once absorbed. Observation of this one bit of Maori culture makes it hard to maintain the polite fiction that Maori are simply Noble Savages, brown people temporarily dressed up in civilizing dress. They demonstrate through their preserved language and cultural traditions a separateness that is more than clothing-deep. The gradual realization of this fact makes New Zealand in the 1990s a more complex and turbulent society than it was in the years of complacent colonialism. It is no longer a ward of the British Empire to be treated as cousins across the wide ocean but islands inhabited by diverse people who must learn to live together without losing their own identities.

New Zealand's young but adventurous cinema culture has helped develop the sense of the diversity and richness of the culture. It has evolved many diverse—often conflicting—images of the land and its inhabitants and has thereby moved the whole society toward some measure of self-reflection and self-assessment in the years since New Zealand has charted its own course as a Pacific nation. Distinguished works by Maori filmmakers—Lee Tamahori's *Once Were Warriors*, Mereta Mita's *Patu* and *Mauri*—have shown us the world through their own lenses. If the relatively small and fragile film industry can maintain the remarkable momentum of its first twenty years of modern efforts, the next decades will be very interesting ones for filmmakers and audiences alike. New Zealand's movies now are shown worldwide, and the "global village" that is the modern film audience is forming its own image of this place so small and so very far away on the maps.

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